

Teen And Up Audiences

No Archive Warnings Apply

Gen

Danny Phantom

Batman - All Media Types

Danny Fenton & Tucker Foley & Sam Manson

Danny Fenton & Jason Todd

Batfamily Members & Danny Fenton

Batfamily Members & Jason Todd

Danny Fenton

Vlad Masters

Jazz Fenton

Sam Manson

Tucker Foley

Bruce Wayne

Dick Grayson

Jason Todd

Tim Drake

Damian Wayne

Duke Thomas

Cassandra Cain

Stephanie Brown (mentioned)

Barbara Gordon (Mentioned)

Supernatural Elements

no beta we die like jason

Jason Todd Needs A Hug

Danny Fenton Needs A Hug

Jason Todd is Red Hood

Jason Todd Has Issues

Barbara Gordon is Oracle

Protective Siblings

Bruce Wayne is Batman

Dick Grayson is Nightwing

Tim Drake is Red Robin

Damian Wayne is Robin

Crossover

No Romance

headcannons ahoy

Jason Todd-centric

no idea what to put for tags

Canon-Typical Violence

DP x DC crossover

this is a crossover

DP X DC

dpxdc

Vlad Plasmius is creepy

talks surrounding death

Dani Phantom is not in this

Danny has no living clones

Pit water is corrupted ectoplasm

Bruce Wayne Tries to Be a Good Parent

fic touches on Pit Madness

Pit Madness works primarily by enhancing negative emotions in this

English Part 1 of Whispers Next Work → A Collection of Beloved Inserts , Transversing , Crossovers I'm obsessed with , dc (mostly crossovers) , EpicCrossovers , Magpies Superhero Favs , The Witch's Woods , FicsforKrusti , Suggested Good Reads ,

hereBeGems , 🧚 A Phantom In Gotham 🦇 , hello yes i can't stop thinking about these works , BatPhantom , A Picky Vest's Favorites , Leymonaide fic recs , My Favorites/Rereads (iamtryingartist) , ✨🐼 Wan Shi Tong's Library 🐼 ✨ , Completed but marked for later , Fics for Lady Reinacorn , Noa's TBR , ☆*: .o. o(≧▽≦)o .o.:*☆ , cauldronrings favs (• ω •)💎

To Join the Whispers

ayamari_no_goshi

Summary:

A contact for the Batfamily passed along a rumor that the League of Assassins were investigating a small city called Amity Park. The old man and Tim managed to find evidence of unusual paranormal activity in the town. While they weren't entirely certain it wasn't just infested with metas, the locals believed the entities that haunted, for lack of a better word, the town were actual ghosts. If there was one thing Ra's al Ghul didn't need to get his grubby hands on, it was ghosts.

That's probably why Jason was doing this. He had the unfortunate luck to experience both death and resurrection in a way he'd never recommend to anyone else.

Notes:

Possible needed warning? Talks surrounding death, dark humor related to death, and self-deprecating thoughts throughout the work.

This was supposed to be a one shot. It's definitely not a one shot

I honestly never thought I'd end up writing a DP crossover. This is completely self-indigent and partially inspired by great fics like 'Ghost Kings and Gotham Bats' by BlueGhostCardinal, 'And So It Ghost' by Evandarya, Crime, Love, and Ghosts. (And others, Probably) by Thornrose270, and 'Blue-Eyed Orphan' by Lilmia_Casand. This is also what happens when you have access to DC animated movies.

As a heads up, I'm a little shaky on the characterization with Cass and Duke as I'm not as familiar with them.

The title is a phrase that came from the show "Lost". It's in regards to departed souls who can't move on, and I felt like it fit

There is also a link to fanart by impyssadobsessions at end of chapter 1

Chapter 1 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/86482594>): Don't Be Surprised When Things Aren't What They Seem

Notes:

Update: 06/13/23 - work changed to be viewed by registered users only

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_1_endnotes\)](#).)

Why was he doing this again? Jason asked himself for the fifth time as he stared out the window of the plane.

He and his family flew to a small city in Illinois called Amity Park. They were taking a private jet to the place on the premise of some fundraiser thing the mayor there, the infamous Vladimir Masters, was hosting. While all of them had suspicions regarding the man, he wasn't the immediate reason for this visit.

Instead, one of their contacts passed along a rumor that the League of Assassins were investigating the place. The old man and Tim managed to find evidence of unusual paranormal activity in the town. While they weren't entirely certain it wasn't just infested with metas, the locals believed the entities that haunted, for lack of a better word, the town were actual ghosts. If there was one thing Ra's al Ghul didn't need to get his grubby hands on, it was ghosts.

That's probably why he was doing this. He had the unfortunate luck to experience both death and resurrection in a way he'd never recommend to anyone else.

Bruce said the town had a high level of ectoplasm, whatever that was, but there was some evidence it was similar to the Lazarus Pits. There was some worry among his siblings that the madness of the waters that still crept into his mind would rear its ugly head while they were there. There had been arguments among them as to whether or not he should even come. They eventually settled on a close monitoring system. He didn't need a babysitter, but it would make the rest of them feel safer. There was also a chance they might be able to find something that might be able to find a way to get the influence of those vile waters out of him, and that by itself was worth it. Besides, he had to make his yearly 'cryptid' appearance.

The first thing he was going to do after the fuss of appearing like a spoiled rich boy would be to find a burger joint and hopefully ditch his siblings. As much as he lov... err, tolerated them, most of his patience with them was already gone. He needed to recharge. It was probably moot point seeing as being around someone at all times was part of the agreement for him coming.

Deciding to pull away from those thoughts, he put most of his focus back towards the briefing of Amity's possible hero, Phantom. There were mixed reports about the probable meta, but most of the information they found pointed to him trying to protect. They'd all seen other heroes controlled by various magics and items in the past, so it's very possible that's exactly what happened to him.

"Ah, Vlad, it's a pleasure to see you again," Bruce pleasantly greeted as they exited the plane. Masters decided to meet them on the runway.

"Likewise. I see you've brought all of your children this time," Masters replied as they exchanged a handshake. He briefly glanced at all of them. "I believe there are a few I haven't met."

"Ah, yes. You've met Dick, Tim, and Damian, but this is Jason, Cassandra, and Duke, who is our newest addition."

"It's a pleasure." Masters extended a handshake to the rest of them.

When it was Jason's turn, his entire body shuddered, and for a moment, he could feel the toxic waters of the Pit whisper before it passed. Whatever Masters was, the Pit recognized him as something similar. He needed to get away from the man, but he had still had to take the limo ride with him to the hotel. Joy.

The closer they got to town, the more the Pit whispered to him. It's like the entire place was infected by it. This was going to be much harder than he thought.

"Jay. Jay?"

Oh, Dick was calling him. Catching all the stares, he waved his hand. "Don't mind me. I'm a bit worn out from traveling. Say, where can a guy get a burger?"

Bruce just sighed and fake apologized for him while Tim piped up that he was hungry too. Masters tried to hide a sneer behind a thoughtful hum before mentioned the 'Nasty Burger'.

Everyone in the car stared at him before Duke spoke up. "They actually named it 'Nasty Burger'?"

"Ah, I asked my godson about that once. The local rumor is that it used to be called 'Tasty Burger' but someone replaced the 'T' for an 'N' in the past. I have no idea if that's true or not, but the locals don't seem to want to change it."

"Could you drop me off there? I'll make my way to the hotel later," Jason attempted to politely ask. Attempted was the key word.

"I suppose." Masters tapped on the partition glass of the limo and made a gesture. The partition lowered slightly, and Masters requested the change. A few minutes later, they were in front of a burger place.

Jason grunted a 'thanks' as Tim and Dick got out behind him while offering a proper 'thank you'. Duke requested for them to bring them some food on their way back.

"A quick word before we leave you," Masters called to them. "The town can become unsafe at times. I'd recommend returning by sundown. While our resident hero," anger crept into his tone, "does a decent job at protecting us, but he can't be everywhere at a given time. I'd hate to see something happen to my guests." With that, the door was closed, and the limo sped away.

"Do you want to explain what all that was about?" Tim asked after they ordered their food and sat down. "Haven't seen you that irritated in a public persona for a while."

"This whole place feels like the Pit," Jason replied before taking a bite. Despite the name of the place, it had decent burgers. Not quite as good as the Bat Burgers, but decent.

"Is everything okay?" Dick tried to reach out to him, probably to check whatever, and he jerked away.

"Not as great as it could be, but it's manageable." It was true. Now that they were out of the limo, the stirrings of the waters weren't as strong as he originally thought. Apparently, Masters' influence amplified it somehow. "Masters reeks of it though."

Tim's eyes widened. "Really? That's pretty big. Do you think he has connections?"

He frowned before taking another bite. "Possibly... but it feels different? More concentrated and less toxic. Hard to explain."

"Hmm... B made sure most of them were either sealed or destroyed." Tim's murmurs were mostly to himself.

"It's possible there is another," Dick added as he took a bite of his own burger. "Would have thought the League would have already scoped this place out if that was the case."

"Or that Zatanna or Constantine would have mentioned it."

"Dunno, but do you have a clear view of that kid?" He gestured to a group of teens who just came into the store.

"Which one?"

"The one mostly likely to be adopted by Bruce." Which was bat-code for black hair and blue eyes. Jason spotted the kid from the window, and he immediately sent off alarms as he could feel the Pit stir again. "Kid feels similar to Masters."

"Seriously?" Tim's eyes widened before narrowing. "Hmm... he might be one of the metas. He tries to hide it, but he's wary and cautious. Steps are also light. Want to send the update? I'll see if I can get anything." Ah, lip reading. One of the best techniques Bruce taught any of them.

"Kid's purposely hunching his shoulders, too," Dick mumbled. "Have a feeling he's a lot stronger than he likes to show."

After taking out his phone and typing a quick message, he stiffened as the kid and his friends approached and took the seat behind them. He thought Masters was bad, but this kid was worse. It was so strong, but it wasn't as unsettling as Masters. The kid almost felt... was it peaceful? No, protective might be the better word.

"So, Danny," Tim motioned that it was the other boy's voice, "are you going to explain why you're going to Vlad's thing? I understand Sam, but you?"

A sigh answered. "He apparently wants to show me off as some sort of prize. I guess he has some sort of rivalry with Bruce Wayne or something stupid like that. And of course, my parents, well, my dad, said yes."

The girl, who had to be Sam, snorted. "Your mom figured out he's a creep, but why can't your dad?"

"No idea. But, I really hope this isn't some weird plot for Vlad to take over Wayne Industries." He sighed.

"Why would Masters do something like that?" Dick questioned as he stood and moved towards the booth. Well, they did need to gather information. Normally, Bruce would berate them from doing something so obvious, but screw it, direct was more comfortable for Jason.

When silence met him, Dick turned on the charm. "Oh, sorry to bother you. I'm Richard Grayson, though I go by Dick. I'm here with my adoptive father, Bruce Wayne, and my siblings for the fundraiser. If there's something wrong, I can let Bruce know."

More stunned silence met him before the girl, Sam, spoke up. "You're Dick Grayson?" Jason nearly snorted at the irritated tone of her voice. "I've heard a lot of stories about you, most of which say you're a huge flirt and playboy."

Jason turned so he could save the stunned expression on Dick's face. It was always nice when the golden boy was caught off guard. "Must be nice to be popular, Dickie-bird," he teased as Tim snickered.

His brother made a dramatic gesture to show how hurt he was before gesturing to them. "If you know me, then you might know those two jerks."

"Love ya too, bro." He glanced at the teens and gave a two-finger salute. "Jason Todd."

Tim decided to stand up and move next to Dick. "Tim Drake."

"Wait, you're Tim Drake?!" the unnamed teen sputtered. Jason could feel his excited vibrations through the seat. "I'm a huge fan of Wayne tech! Could I have your autograph?"

Tim seemed stunned for a moment, before Dick gently prodded him. Jason would have just smacked him.

The girl, Sam, frowned at him as Tim hurried scribbled on a paper that appeared out of somewhere. "I've heard a lot of weird rumors about you, Mr. Todd. I remember my parents gossiping about how you died? But I guess who ever started that rumor had no idea what they were talking about."

Jason shrugged. "Call me Jason. The stories are mostly exaggerated." He did die after all, but it wasn't permanent.

"Nah, he just enjoys tormenting the press and sometimes us by showing up every once in a while before vanishing into the night like a ghost," Tim teased.

"I prefer zombie, thank you very much."

The boy with blue eyes, Danny, stared at him, and the Pit stirred again. Trying to hide his discomfort, Jason decided to lead the conversation away from himself. "Anyways, you know our names, but who are you?"

The kids introduced themselves: Danny Fenton, Sam Manson, and Tucker Foley.

Danny seemed to remember his manners as he hesitantly invited the brothers to join them, much to Sam's apparent annoyance. There wasn't enough room in their booth even though Dick was clearly thinking about the logistics. Rolling his eyes, Jason decided to point out the larger corner booth they could use. He couldn't help but smirk as his brothers irritably acknowledged his good idea.

"Nice to meet you." Dick was all smiles as they settled down. They needed information, and he was the best at charming people.

"Sorry, but I got to ask, have you met the Batman? Or Robin?" Tucker blurted out.

"Tucker!" Sam scolded.

"What? I can't help it. They're from Gotham."

Danny chuckled. "Sorry about him, but I'd like to know too. What about the others? I've heard Batman doesn't like other heroes in Gotham, but online forums talk about sightings of Nightwing, Red Robin... I think the one goes by Orphan now? The newest one is called Signal? Then there's the reports of the Red Hood. I don't think anyone is sure what to make of him, but most think he's too brutal for Batman's liking."

Jason couldn't help but snort. "You can say that. There have been a few reports over the years of those two fighting, but yeah, we've definitely seen most of them."

"We've been adopted by Bruce. It's kind of in the fine print that we'll be in a situation where they need to get involved," Tim added, making sure to give plausible deniability. "Would you like to hear a few stories?"

"You bet!" The enthusiasm from Tucker and Danny was contagious.

Each of them gave a few stories of their extended family. Both Tucker and Danny hung on every word, but it wasn't until they started talking about Batwoman, Spoiler, and Bluebird that Sam seemed to perk up. For a few moments, Jason did debate on whether or not he should talk about the time he stole the tires off the batmobile. While it was pretty epic, Bruce would probably nag him about how that would give them info that could allow them to draw conclusions they didn't need. Yeah, he could do without the nagging.

"We've heard you had a local hero, too," Tim mentioned. "I'm surprised you're so interested in our stories."

"You mean Phantom?" Tucker questioned as Danny stiffened slightly. "He's really cool, but he's no Batman."

Danny let out a deep breath which struck him as odd. Did the kid have some connection to this Phantom? "It's true. I think almost everyone wants to catch a glimpse of members of the Justice League, but..."

"Danny, don't finish that statement," Sam scolded again. "We know your luck. You are not jinxing us." Danny huffed.

Dick chuckled. "I guess we've gotten a little jaded. But going back to what caught our interest earlier, you mentioned you were worried about Masters?"

The three exchanged looks before Danny took the lead. "Er... I might have accidentally found out that he's managed to somehow manipulate a bunch of other people into signing over money and companies to him in the past, and I don't put it past him to try something with Mr. Wayne."

Jason shared a look with his brothers. "We've heard rumors about him for a while," he explained casually.

"He definitely has a bad reputation among the boards and CEOs of big businesses," Tim added. "Bruce has made a habit of never meeting with the man alone."

Danny nodded, but his troubled expression suggested there was more to it. "Sometimes that doesn't work either."

"Do you happen to know what he does?" Tim kept his tone light. It was better to seem friendly than force an interrogation.

"Kind of? I know he'll bug places. Stupid creep keeps bugging my house." Jason didn't miss how Danny clenched his fists as he spoke.

"Dude, you found another one?" Tucker retrieved the fry he dropped on his tray. "How many does this make now?"

"Well, I found five of them this weekend, so I think makes fifty-nine in total since I first started finding them."

Sam made a disgusted noise. "Seriously? Is he that obsessed with you and your mom?"

Danny rolled his eyes. "You know how Vlad is. He's a lonely and desperate fruitloop, who needs a cat.... Wait, I forgot, he has a cat now. He named it Maddie. I'm half convinced those weird people we keep seeing were hired by him to spy on us too."

"Seriously?"

"That's messed up, dude."

After silently confirming with Tim and Dick that the Fenton family would be investigated as to why Masters was that interested in them, Jason decided to ask, "Why is that name an issue?"

"Oh, yeah, you wouldn't know. Vlad is obsessed with my mom, Maddie Fenton," Danny clarified.

That would make sense in a creepy way. "But let's back up a bit. You mentioned weird people?" Dick questioned. "I mean, Masters is throwing a fundraiser. Those tend to bring out all sorts of eccentric rich people and criminals. We'd know."

Oh, boy did they know. It seemed like there couldn't be one without someone crashing it. To be honest, Jason still had no idea why anyone in their right mind would through a fundraiser, gala, party, or anything in Gotham. Any of those were basically giant signs that said, 'rob me.'

The three of teens glanced at each other again before Sam spoke, "Amity Park gets its fair amount of weird people. Normally, it's just paranormal enthusiasts."

"We heard this is a hot spot for ghost sightings," Tim acknowledged with a polite grin.

"Yeah? Well, then you probably know that tends to bring in cults, occultists, parapsychologists... people like that," Sam added with a dismissive wave. "Normally, they aren't too big of a problem. Most of them get scared away when they witness their first ghost attack."

"Ghost attack? We've heard rumors of attacks, but we thought they were metas."

"I guess you could mistake them for metas," Danny agreed. He seemed tense but was obviously trying to hide it. "They're not though. Actually, do we have any stories of metas here?"

"Let me check." Tucker typed away at what appeared to be one of the newest Wayne Industries PDAs. "Uh... I mean, there might be, but any reports of possible metas from here are all reported in newspapers from other places. None of them are from Amity."

"He's not a meta?" Tim raised his eyebrows.

"Who? Phantom?" Sam questioned as Danny stiffened again. "He's a ghost too."

"So he's a ghost who fights off other ghosts?" Jason questioned slowly. "Is there something about this place that makes them come here?"

"You could say that." Danny didn't look up at them as he spoke. "Amity was already a thin spot before... well, uh... my parents tried punching a hole into another dimension."

"I'm sorry, what?"

"They're paranormal scientists," he hesitantly explained as he made eye contact with Jason. It almost seemed like teen sensed there was something unnatural about him. It made the Waters stir again. "They thought most ghosts would be found in a different dimension and tried to figure out a way to reach them by making a giant portal in the basement."

While it was clear Danny was withholding some information, the unsaid implications of his parents' experiment set him on edge. Whatever they did probably had some baring on why the entire town felt like the Pit. Did they have a sample of those waters when they did whatever they tried? Or did they make an artificial Pit?

"While I don't know exactly what happened," Tim's voice brought Jason out of his thoughts, "I guess the machine did something to make the thin spot thinner."

Danny nodded. "Most of their research is public, if you want to check it out. The calculations are beyond me, but the first reported attack happened... it was about a month later?"

Tucker checked his PDA again. "Yep, though there were reports of random ghost animals prior to that."

"And the weird people?" Tim prompted in hopes of steering the conversation back to what might prove to be important information.

"We don't think they're normal paranormal enthusiast," Sam hesitantly explained as she glanced at Danny. "They're easiest to spot when there's a ghost attack. They'll stand and watch a bit too long. I think they might be part of the GIW, but paranoid people like Danny think they're following people around."

"I'm not paranoid!"

"Unless the GIWs went through another upgrade and actually hired competent people, I don't think it's them. Oh, that's the Ghost Investigation Ward," Tucker explained while he munched on a fry. He must have caught their unfamiliarity with the term. "Dunno how common they are outside of Amity. We call them the Guys in White since the agents wear pure white suits. They have been known to investigate and terrorize people"

"Do you think these people might have something to do with Masters?" Dick questioned while trying to hide a smile at Danny's outburst.

Danny bit his lip. "I'm not sure, but I don't think so. He's my godfather," his nose wrinkled as he said the word, "so I think I know him as well as anyone else. I can't put it past him, but Vlad doesn't like working with people unless he thinks he'll have the upper hand. He did call the GIW to raid my room."

Tucker and Sam both gave him unimpressed looks. "You two were in the middle of a prank war during that," Sam reminded him. Danny just huffed.

"Good to know." Jason glanced at his brothers. Why in the world would Vlad Masters get into a prank war with a teenager? Music started playing. Judging by Danny's response of pulling out his phone, it was his ring tone. "It's my mom. I'll be right back."

As Danny left, Dick decided to turn the charm back on. "I think I heard you guys mention something about the fundraiser? Will you be there?"

"Didn't anyone tell you eavesdropping is rude," Sam mentioned as she rolled her eyes, "But yeah, Danny and I will be there. My parents are influential."

"Don't mind her," Tucker mentioned as he checked his PDA again. "Sam would rather change the world through activism than deal with a stuffy fundraiser thing. As for me, I'm just a normal person, so I won't be there."

"Sorry about that." Danny reappeared. His footsteps were virtually unnoticeable which sent off alarms to Jason. Only a handful of people could walk like that, and most of them were costumed heroes, villains, or assassins. "Looks like my parents want me home for a suit fitting." He made a face. "Vlad's paying for it."

"Try to stay still. It'll make it go faster," Tim offered as a form of advice. All of them had to go through suit fittings at one time or another.

"It was nice meeting you. I guess I'll see you at the fundraiser. Try not to let Vlad act like a creep." With that, Danny grabbed his bag and his trash before disappearing.

"We should probably get going too," Dick mentioned as he made a show of checking his phone. "We kind of ditched Masters' tour to grab something to eat. Wanna bet Damian has already threatened the man?"

Jason chuckled as he stood. As much as the demon brat got on his nerves, it was always a pleasure to watch the kid annoy someone else. "We'll be in town for a few days, so you might see us around."

"Yep... Seriously, Jason, move." Tim pushed him a bit.

Smirking, he just started leaning back on him. It was occasionally nice to be a walking tank. When Dick sighed, he straightened up and stopped. Tim grumbled at him as they left the building.

Once they were sure they were out of earshot, Dick spoke up, "So who's going to tail him?"

"I will. Give me the tracer's frequency."

"No." Both Dick and Tim spoke at the same time.

Tim ran his hand through his hair. "I'll do it."

Before he could argue, Dick spoke up, "Jay, something about him bothered you. Both of us saw your eyes flash green when Fenton sat near you. Let's report to B first. Maybe do a quick health scan, just to be safe. None of us want to see you benched on the first day."

He huffed. "Fine. Don't get caught."

His brother smiled at him. "Who do you think I am?"

As soon as they returned, Duke complained that they forgot to get him burgers. Dick smacked his forehead muttering that he knew they forgot something.

Once that was out of the way and Bruce verified that their rooms had been checked for bugs, Dick filled in the others regarding their conversation with the teens and how Tim left for an early reconnaissance. Although he was perfectly happy letting Dick run his mouth, he hesitantly explained about how Danny and even Masters affected him.

He hated admitting anything about how those vile waters affected him. They messed with his mind - forcing his negative emotions to the forefront, making it harder for the positives and logic to counteract them. Rage seemed to be the most obviously affected emotion, but loneliness, inadequacy, and depression were also right up there. It had slowly gotten easier to control, but there were still slip ups. If Fenton's parents did manage to do research involving the Pit, maybe they could help him find a way to better manage it. He had started making real connections and didn't want to ruin these ones.

Cass must have sensed his turmoil and placed a hand on his shoulder. He gave her a small nod.

"Will this affect your performance?" Bruce's tone was no nonsense.

"Doubt it. Spent an entire conversation with the kid without thinking about killing anyone. I think I'm fine."

Bruce didn't seem entirely convinced so, of course, the batscanner appeared. Seconds later, he verified there had been no change in his body. Paranoid old man.

Tim called them with an update few minutes later. "I think Fenton understated what his parents managed to do."

"What exactly is this?" Bruce question as he checked his own batcomputer as Tim sent him the readings. Of course, all of them crowded around to see.

"I'm not sure," Tim admitted. "Fenton mentioned his parents tried making a portal to the afterlife, and the energy readings underneath this house are off the charts. I can't do much in civies, but this is the base readings for the house. Even allowing for the suggested presence of a lab, this is unreal." He sighed. "I really want to take a look, but I'd need to disable the security system which contains actual laser weapons, by the way. Don't think you want me to do that."

"No, not yet. Anything unusual?"

"Other than how fast he got here? No. Check the tracer data. He either has super speed or he flew. I can't really get a clear view of them in the house. Right now, the only thing I can get is him, and someone he calls 'Jazz', complaining about Masters. Probably siblings."

"So, he's probably a meta?" Duke questioned as he moved away.

Dick nodded. "Yeah, you can tell he's hiding something. Tensed up a few times when Phantom was brought up."

"Tt. He's obviously an amateur." Of course, Damian would find a way to find fault with a person he never met.

"Not all are lucky to have help," Cass mentioned as her way of scolding.

"Those teens did suggest Phantom is really the only hero around here."

"Good job. Return for now," Bruce ordered. "Oracle, are you there?"

"I'm here." There was some static on Barbara's end. Odd, normally their lines were among the clearest available. "I've been trying to find any further information about Phantom or at least a clear picture of him. All photos, even closeups, are blurry. But I bet you want me to dig up some information on the Fentons? And see if I can get past Masters' firewalls?"

"Yes. We'll do a perimeter recon tonight. Remember, our goal right now is to see if we can find evidence of the League's actions. That's it."

Jason shared a look with his siblings. They all knew their luck. Nothing was ever that simple.

Notes:

Dani/Elle is not in this fic series, nor is she needed for the story I want to tell. I was going to leave her existence open ended, but I've put my foot down due to the constant questions about her. Danny has no surviving clones in this AU.

I'll be using aspects of the 2 main variations of Jason's death and resurrection in this.

I saw a post on Tumblr by [luminescentauthor](#) that described Jason as Gotham's cryptid, and I love it. That also falls in line with an interview he did with Vicki Vale in *Red Hood and the Outlaws* (2016), so it's being used.

[impyssadobsessions](#) drew the Nasty Burger scene:

<https://impyssadobsessions.tumblr.com/post/678285162284498944/finished-it-a-scene-from-to-join-the-whispers-by>

Because it came up before in a comment, here are the ages for the story:

Danny, Sam, and Tucker are approx 15. It's been 10-12 months since Danny's accident

Jazz: 17

Dick and Babs: 27

Jason and Cass: 22

Steph: 21

Tim: 20 (he's not eternally 17 in this! While ages keep changing, originally, he's only 2-3 years younger than Jason. I'm gonna peg them about 2.5 years apart here)

Damian: 13

Duke: 17

Bruce is in his 40s

Chapter 2 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/86535550>): Saw Some Things on the Other Side

Notes:

I think my favorite scene I've ever written is in this chapter. This is the last pre-written chapter, so updates will come when they come. Especially now that I started a new job.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_2_endnotes\)](#).)

It felt good to be out of the hotel and running across the roofs of Amity. Sure, the buildings were nowhere near as tall as those in Gotham, but the whole town still held an unnatural gloom that reminded him of home. The only thing ruining his mood was that Dick, excuse him, Nightwing, was with him.

The family would be rotating who would be with him each night. Annoying precautions. Did they really think he suddenly snap and make some elaborate revenge plan? Well, he did do that at a few times, and it was pretty fun when he impersonated Dick. Yeah, precautions were probably a good thing.

The Pit stirred again, and he motioned for Dick to stop. Something was nearby. Something that made the Waters churn and whisper.

"Since when do associates of the Batman show up in a town like this?" The voice was disembodied and sounded as if the source moved as it spoke. If he had to guess, Jason would peg the speaker to be a teenage male, but there was an odd static to the voice. Was there a modulator being used?

As he and Dick moved so they were back to back, both of them continued to scan the area. The scanners in his helmet registered an unnatural cold spot at his 2 o'clock. He drew his gun and pointed it at the area. "I'd recommend showing yourself." Whatever it was didn't feel hostile, but it was always better to play it safe.

A black and white figure seemed to materialize out of air. Glowing green eyes seemed unimpressed at his weapon. "It seems pointless to point a gun at a ghost, but you do you."

Despite himself, he chuckled as he lowered the weapon. "Better to play it safe."

"Don't mind him." Dick raised his hands in a placating manner. "As you might know, I'm Nightwing, and that's Red Hood. You must be Phantom?"

The figure nodded and floated a bit closer. While glanced at both of him, the Phantom's eyes seemed to linger on Jason. Could the supposed ghost tell...?

"Why are you here?" Phantom cocked his head. "Didn't think we had any issues that would bring any other heroes here. After the other ghosts started attacking, big crime rarely happens anymore."

"B, can you hear?" Jason whispered to the comm link as Dick moved forward to talk.

"Yes. See if you can get info from him. Don't give him too much." Jason rolled his eyes at the order. Him and Dick were long time pros at this, even if their tactics varied.

"You could say a rumor caught our attention, and we're looking into it," Dick explained as cryptically as possible.

Phantom raised an eyebrow. "Does it have to do with the fundraiser thing? Damn it. I knew Plasmius was trying to pull something."

Jason shared a look with his brother. "Plasmius? Who's that?"

"Oh, he's a ghost like I am, but he looks kind of like a vampire."

"Why would a ghost want anything to do with a fundraiser? Isn't that kind of weird for a ghost?" Realizing he might have said something rude, Dick quickly added, "No offense."

"The ghosts here are a bit different than the ones you've probably heard about." Phantom gave a wry grin as he leaned back into a sitting position while continuing to float. "But Plasmius likes anything that can give him an advantage. That can be money, electronics, connections, you name it."

That still seemed odd. "Why would he need things like that?"

Phantom gave him another stare, making the waters churn again. "Like I said, anything that will give him an advantage. That includes ghost hunting equipment."

"Hmm... if that's the case, this Plasmius must have some human contacts," Dick theorized. While Phantom didn't answer, his temporarily widened eyes gave away the answer. "Would he bring in outside help?"

Phantom frowned at that. "I've only ever seen him work with other ghosts, but there have been weird people in town. I've seen them watching me during fights. They don't seem scared like other visitors, but they don't react the same way locals do. I've been trying to figure out who or what they are, but they vanish whenever I have a chance to go look. Do you have any idea how hard it is to hide from a ghost?"

Dick glanced at him. Yep, it was probably the League, but they were usually better at keeping hidden.

"How many of... ah, your associates are here?"

"Why do you need to know?" A warning edge crept into Jason's voice.

"Whoa! I'm on your side!" Phantom raised his hands in alarm as he straightened his posture. "Look, ghosts can possess and control humans."

"So we've heard." Phantom spun around to find Batman behind him.

"How'd you do that?! Humans usually can't move that silent.... Oh, there's more of you." And it was true. The rest of the family could be seen either on the rooftop or on a nearby one.

"Relax, Phantom," Bruce instructed as the glowing teen tensed at the new company and floated a little higher. "Do you know a way to prevent a ghost from controlling someone? Or detect them?"

Some of the tension in Phantom's shoulders released. "Yes. Err... yes to both. I don't know if it's possible for normal humans to detect them without equipment... he might be able to."

Jason was surprised when the ghost gestured to him. "What do you mean?"

Phantom rolled his eyes as if it was the most obvious thing in the world. "I don't know how, but you've been exposed to ectoplasm, and a lot of it, at that. You could feel me as I got close, right?"

"You could say that, but I don't know what you mean by ectoplasm."

The ghost raised his hand and produced a glowing green orb. It was a bit too close to the color of the Lazarus Pit for his liking. "It might have looked something like this, but it can appear in a bunch of different forms. Personal favorite can only be described as goo." Phantom let the orb vanish with a wave of the hand. "Anyways, the Fentons make something called the 'Specter Deflector' and have various detecting devices."

"Tt." And Damian was already irritated. "Why would we need such a ridiculously named device?"

"To prevent a ghost from possessing you, duh." He lowered his head and muttered, "I like the term 'overshadowing' better though."

"I assume that means you can also do it."

Phantom winced at the old man's statement. "Yeah, but I don't like doing it. It's a big invasion of privacy." He winced again and shivered. "People with strong wills can break out of it, and that can sometimes make a ghost a bit too vulnerable."

"Anyways," Phantom continued with a clap of the hands, "those deflectors send out an electrical pulse when a ghost touches or tries to overshadow you. It won't hurt you, but it definitely is enough to stop the ghost. I think it disrupts us or something like that."

"You aren't sure?" Batman's eyes narrowed.

"Look, I haven't been a ghost for all that long. There's still a lot I don't know. It's not like you get a manual when you die and come back as a ghost."

Jason was glad his helmet hid his face as he'd flinched. The ghost's words were a bit too close to home, and, for a brief moment, he wondered if waking up as a ghost was as violent as when he was pulled back to the living world. Fuck, why was he thinking about these things?

"But why help us? I'm surprised a ghost would be so willing to give away information like that." Tim crossed his arms as he appraised the ghost.

Phantom just sighed. “I don’t like watching people get hurt. The one thing I do know about how a ghost is formed is that strong desires or regrets upon death can get enhanced. For some, it gets to the point of an obsession which can easily be warped into something it shouldn’t have been.” He glanced at Jason again. Yeah, that ghost had suspicions about him. “For me, you can argue it was my sense of responsibility.”

An uneasy silence fell between them for a few moments before what appeared to be breath misted in front of Phantom. Could ghosts breathe? Why would they need to breathe?

“Crud. Well, that’s my cue. Hopefully, it’s something easy like an ectopus or the Box Ghost,” he muttered before giving them an uneasy smile. “I guess I’ll see you around. Nice meeting you.” He gave a mock salute and flew up and to the south. His legs morphed into a tail as he moved.

“Orphan, Nightwing, Signal, see if you can follow,” the old man instructed. “See if you can spot anyone else nearby. The rest of us will finish the perimeter. Red Robin, you’re with Red Hood.”

Everyone agreed. As everyone else dispersed, Jason decided to swear a few times before following Tim off the roof. The ghost gave him a bit too much to think about, and he didn’t like it.

“Do you want to talk about it?”

Jason glanced at his younger brother as they moved. “No, not really.”

One of the things they learned from the previous night’s patrol was there was an actual ghost that called himself the ‘Box Ghost.’ The other thing they learned, this time from Bruce’s scanner, was that Phantom had a heartbeat.

The old man called John Constantine for confirmation on whether or not that was normal. While the Brit spent a few minutes cussing him out, he did confirm that no ghost should have a heartbeat. Once he found out where they were, he cussed a few more times before mentioning to be careful. According to him, the ghosts were stronger than normal in Amity, and that there were rumored to be a couple who weren’t exactly all the way dead.

When pressed for details, Constantine snapped, “Look, mate, death is a tricky business. Sometimes the process gets interrupted and unnatural things result. Now, if that’s all you want, could you kindly bugger off?” And that was that.

“I guess that means Phantom really isn’t a normal ghost,” Duke stated as he relaxed on one of the plush chairs in the hotel room. “Wonder what happened to the guy?”

“I might have an answer for that,” Babs answered through the com link. “If Phantom is Fenton like we think, I found record of him being hospitalized after an accident right around the time his parents announced that their ‘Ghost Portal’ started working. Looks like they were treating him for electrocution.”

“If... if that portal thing contained ectoplasm or whatever Phantom called it...” Jason couldn’t repress the shudder. Poor kid. No wonder why the Waters reacted to him.

“Are you suggesting they’re the same?” Bruce’s stare would have been unnerving if Jason was anyone else. Too bad he’d been on the receiving side of it since Bruce took him in.

“Similar enough, I guess. Would probably have to see the thing to be sure.”

“We have time in the morning. We’ll pay a visit to the Fentons.”

Duke groaned. “I don’t know how you people do this. Some of us aren’t cut out for being a late-night vigilante.”

The Fenton home was something else. Not only did they have a huge light up sign, but there was also a hulking metal monstrosity on top of it. How the fuck did the town allow them to do that? It practically screamed mad scientist.

But that wasn’t what unnerved Jason. No, it was the fact the entire place made his skin crawl as the Pit seemed to call to whatever unholy thing existed beneath it.

“Are you sure you can handle it?” That was Bruce speak for ‘it’s okay to back down if you want’.

Jason shrugged. He wasn’t going to let his brothers get any more fuel for teasing him.

Tim was with them. Since he was more involved in the day to day of Wayne Industries, it was best to have him be there when Bruce put on a show of being interested in potential purchases.

However, when Bruce walked on the door, none of them expected the force of nature that was Jack Fenton. The man was huge, towering over all of them, wearing a neoprene orange jumpsuit. And not only did he immediately react as if they were ghosts, but he bounced from suspicious to excited in the blink of an eye. Soon, they were ushered inside.

The inside of the house was surprisingly normal, if not a little outdated. There were pieces of equipment everywhere. Apparently, the parents work on their projects wherever they felt like it. Not necessarily the safest thing when they use Lazarus Pit water or ectoplasm. They were the same cursed thing as far as he was concerned.

Fenton’s wife, Maddie, appeared from the basement and gently reigned in the giant of a man. She introduced herself, and the two of them enthusiastically launched an explanation of their work and some of their theories. Tim and Bruce at least pretended to be interested, but Jason couldn’t. The whole feel of the house distracted him.

“Mom? Do we have any...?” a female voice called. Jason turned just in time to see a young redhead enter the kitchen where they were seated. Must have been the Jazz from Tim’s report. “Sorry, I didn’t realize you had company... wait. Oh my god! You’re Bruce Wayne and Timothy Drake from Wayne Enterprises!” She bounced in excitement. “I’m Jazz, err. Jasmine Fenton!”

“What am I? Chopped liver?” he grumbled making Tim chuckle.

Before anyone had a chance to give further introductions, they heard someone come down the stairs. “Seriously, Jazz. It’s ten A.M. in summer! Why are you screaming?” It was Danny, the boy they met yesterday. The one they suspected to be Phantom.

Danny yawned as he came into the kitchen. Crumpled clothes and messy hair suggested he just woke up. When he noticed them, all traces of exhaustion seemed to vanish. “There are normal people here.” He frowned for a moment before recognition came

to him. “Oh, it’s Tim and Jason, right? We met yesterday.” His eyes narrowed for a moment before his glance turned to Bruce, “Sorry, I don’t know who you are.”

“What do you mean you met them yesterday? You didn’t say anything about it!”

“I honestly forgot. Vlad being his fruitloopy-self distracted me.”

“Danny! How could you!”

It was somewhat refreshing to see siblings that weren’t his bickering like that. It also helped humanize Danny some. Here he seemed just like any normal person instead of a walking beacon of some unholy substance that shouldn’t be found on earth.

Jason was technically one of those too, but who was keeping track?

Maddie stopped the fight and proper introductions began. Jazz apologized to him for not recognizing him.

“Don’t worry about it. I tend to stay out of the limelight,” he replied with a practiced smile.

Jazz returned it, but her eyes moved towards the annoying white streak in his hair. A frown made her almost seem concerned, but her eyes glanced towards her brother. Did she suspect something? They never met before. Her reaction suggested Danny hadn’t said anything to her about him or the others, but it was possible she was better at hiding information than her brother.

“Since you’re here, why don’t we show you the Ghost Portal?” Jack’s booming voice redirected their attention.

“No! Dad, think about this,” Jazz scolded. “The last time you decided to show off the portal you accidentally let a bunch of ghosts come through. You guys were busy for weeks trying to fix that mess, and that’s with Phantom doing most of the work.”

Maddie frowned at her daughter. “Now sweetie, you know Phantom isn’t capable of helping humans. Anyways, I’ll keep your father from touching the controls to the safety doors. It’ll be perfectly safe.” Jazz and Danny rolled their eyes in sync. That was encouraging.

Bruce took them up on the offer, so the three of them followed Jack and Maddie to the basement lab. Jazz and Danny elected to stay in the kitchen. However, he wasn’t sure how true that was as he could feel something, or someone, follow them. Judging by the fact he couldn’t catch sight of anything, he figured it had to be Danny.

As soon as they got to the bottom of the stairs, the portal distracted him. Even with it closed, he could feel its energy, and it brought up one too many bad memories. He didn’t even register one of the Fentons explaining things, but like what Jazz predicted, Jack carelessly opened the doors to the portal.

That... that looked just like it. The Pit called out to it, and it called out to him. Green started to tinge his vision. Nope. Fuck this. He didn’t want to be anywhere near that thing. So, he did the only rational thing and hurried upstairs.

When he reached the kitchen, Danny was nowhere to be found, but Jazz was making coffee.

She glanced at him. “Was the portal too much?” Before he could give an excuse, she added, “You’re a lot like Danny. You’ve been touched by death. And with the portal being a literal entrance to the afterlife, it’s unsettling for you.”

“You... you can tell?” This girl was good.

She nodded as she poured herself a cup. “There’s something about you. Whatever it is, my brother also has it. Sorry if I made you feel uncomfortable,” she added after a moment. “I’ve studied a lot of psychology, and I’ve learned a lot of tricks.” Wait, she’s self-taught? Oh, she’s very good.

“You’re right, but it’s not something I like talking about,” he admitted.

She nodded. A comfortable silence fell between them before she stated, “Danny... He nearly died in that thing.”

Jason couldn’t keep the surprise off his face. “Wait, in that machine?”

“Yeah... I don’t know the full details. Danny says he just made a mistake.” She placed the cup on the counter. “Do you... do you have any tips that might help him? I’ve tried, and he’s still struggling. And after a ghost impersonated the school psychiatrist and nearly killed a few people, professional help isn’t an option.”

“That...” He was seriously the worst person to ask that question, but she didn’t know that. Instead, he gave her a genuine smile. “You’re a good sister, you know that? I’m still figuring that out too, but I’ll let you know if I figure out anything. But what do you mean a ghost impersonated a school psychiatrist?”

One and a half stories later, Bruce, Tim, and the Fenton parents emerged from the basement. Danny, however, wasn’t anywhere to be found. Jason could feel his presence though. The teen seemed to be in the living room, even though he hadn’t been there moments before.

“Thank you for the tour.” Bruce smiled pleasantly at them. He gave Jason a subtle nod. Oh, so now he decided to care. “I hate to ask, but we heard about a product you make that can prevent possessions...”

“You mean the Specter Deflector? It’s not something we currently sell,” Maddie mentioned. “How’d you find out about it?”

“Oh, Mr. Masters mentioned it briefly,” Tim quickly offered.

Jack Fenton beamed. “Good ol’ Vladdie! He’s recommending us now.”

Maddie frowned at her husband but didn’t correct him. They clearly weren’t on the same page regarding Masters. “Well, there have been times when several townsfolk have been possessed. I supposed it couldn’t hurt to show you. Please bear in mind these are prototypes.”

“Oh? We had been led to believe that they were functioning,” Jason added. Phantom made it seem like they were.

“For the most part, they are,” Maddie agreed. “But they still have some bugs in them.”

“Yeah, they keep zapping Danny for some reason.” The frown that crossed Jack’s face seemed almost unnatural.

Bruce raised an eyebrow. “Does that happen often?”

“Ever since Danny had his accident, a lot of our inventions either react to or target him,” Maddie hesitantly explained. “They work well enough to be able to protect you from any ghosts you might encounter.”

“If you do happen to wear them to the party,” Jazz added warily, “please be careful not to touch Danny. He’s mentioned those shocks hurt.”

“Fuck you!” Jason snarled at Tim, who was laughing at him. “That fucking thing hurts.”

“Come on, Jay. It can’t be that bad.” Tim was enjoying himself way too much. “We’ve all been tased before.”

The Fentons were able to give them three Specter Deflectors and promised to make them more in the next twenty-four hours.

So, of course, they were experimenting with the new tech. However, it became quickly apparent that they worked on him too. And his annoying brother was having a blast shocking him every few minutes. Dick and Duke were trying not to laugh, Cass was smiling, and Damian kept snickering.

“At least we have something to fall back on if Jason ever decides to go on another beheading streak.” At Dick’s words, Jason flipped him the bird.

“This does confirm that the waters of the Pits and ectoplasm are either the same thing or have the same properties.” Was Bruce smirking too? Fuck that bastard and his shitty suit.

Where the hell did he put his guns? All of them needed to be shown... Woah, where did that come from? He hadn’t wanted to seriously maim or kill his family for a while. Not liking how his vision seemed to be tinged green, he took a deep breath and let himself sit on the closest bed.

“Shit...” Glaring at his brother, who seemed to want to shock him again, he growled, “Go ahead and try it again, Replacement. I’m not going to feel sorry if you decide to keep trying your luck.”

Tim seemed to realize something was off and backed away. “Jay, your eyes...”

He snorted. “What? Are you suddenly going to tell me how they look like jade or something stupid like that?”

“No... they’re glowing.”

“Well, isn’t that just peachy.”

“I’m being serious.”

“So what? Does that mean you’re going to continue shocking me with that damned belt?” He stood up and towered over Tim. He barely registered the shift in the moods of the others and how they took defensive stances. “I didn’t ask to be thrown in that Pit. I didn’t ask to be brought back to life!”

“Jason, stand down!”

He blinked a few times before turning his gaze towards Bruce. His gaze seemed judgmental. No, that... that wasn’t it. The fucking Pit was screwing with his thoughts again. Breathing deeply, he backed away from Tim and collapsed back onto the bed. He’d been doing so well recently.

“Tim, remove that belt.”

“Right...” Tim almost seemed unnerved as he did as instructed and placed it in the old man’s hand. “Do you think it’d benefit us if I can find a way to make it... err...” he glanced at Jason, “more selective?”

“Yes.”

“Right... I’ll get on that after dinner.”

“Tt. I say leave it. It was nice to see Todd put in his place.”

“Arrogant piece of shit,” Jason muttered at Damian. Did that kid have a death wish?

Cass sat on his left and took his hand. “Breathe,” Cass instructed as she gave his hand a gentle squeeze. “This is... not you.”

While he could argue that it was, he decided not to. Something about her presence helped silence the Waters.

Dick sat on his other side and ruffled his hair. “Doin’ better, Jaybird?”

When he smacked his brother’s hand away, it left him open to an unexpected hug. He slipped out of Cass’ hand and pushed at Dick. “Get off of me, Dickhead.”

“I scared you earlier.”

“Huh? What would make you say that?” Duke asked, obviously trying to play it off as if he didn’t know what he was talking about, as he and Jason walked around the town after dinner. When Jason raised an eyebrow at him, he hesitantly nodded.

Although Jason didn’t know him too well yet, he seemed like a good kid. And since they still needed to get intel regarding the League’s whereabouts in town, they decided to take strolls as civies while Tim returned to the hotel and worked on those damned belts. Jason figured it was as good as of a time as ever to talk to the kid.

“You’ve probably heard the rumors about me. How I was when I came back. Not exactly my finest.” He didn’t want to talk about it, but he needed to say enough to make sure the kid would trust him enough not to fumble during the mission. “Things have been better for a while now, but I’m not going to pretend it’s perfect.” Well, that statement didn’t help anything.

“Dick and Tim have talked about it a few times,” Duke acknowledged. “This was the first time I think I understood what they meant about the...”

“The what? The rage? Bloodlust? Madness?” Bitterness crept into his voice.

“Yeah... You were like another person for a moment. I didn’t really believe you could have done all those things Dick and Tim told me you did... But I saw when it overwhelmed you. The glow...?” Oh yeah, the kid had meta abilities that dealt with light and stuff, similar to the Kryptonians with some extra things thrown in. He kept forgetting. So much for the ‘no metas in Gotham’ rule.

“And?”

“I can see now how a good person can get... err... overwhelmed by it.”

Jason snorted. He definitely wasn’t a good person.

“What? What did I say?” Duke genuinely seemed puzzled by his reaction. If that was the case, then Dick and Tim probably didn’t give Duke all of the details on what he’s done over the years. Probably a good thing.

“Huh? Oh. Prepare for a crowd coming this way.”

Only one or two seconds after the warning from Duke, a bunch of folks ran down the street. Most of them did seem to be alarmed, but none of them were screaming. Alarmed, Jason managed to grab a man’s arm to ask him what was wrong.

“Oh, you’re from out of town.” The man rolled his eyes as he batted Jason’s hand away. “There’s a ghost attack. Phantom and the robot one, Skulker, are going at it again. Best get away now. Skulker’s mostly focused on Phantom, but he’ll take hostages. Now, if you’ll excuse me.” He ran off.

Jason glanced at Duke. “Shall we?”

“Absolutely.”

The two raced in the direction the crowd came from and took shelter in an alleyway. In the sky, Phantom dodged a barrage of missiles and what appeared to be a net from what could only be described as a flying robot with a flaming mohawk. What in the world was that supposed to be?

While Duke called in a quick report to Bruce, Jason scanned the area. Phantom did mention that he’d seen the unknown people when there were ghost attacks. Ah, there!

Just beyond a building on the other side of the street, he could just barely catch the sight of a few other people who appeared to be watching. Pulling out his scope, he caught sight of Danny’s friends, Sam and Tucker. While they were out in the open, their worried expressions told him they knew the ghost above their heads was their friend.

However, someone else was watching. He could just catch sight of the glint of he guessed was a scope hidden within one of the trees. There were probably others, but most of them knew how to properly stay hidden.

As a news van and what could only be described as a tank appeared on the scene, Jason used the distraction to slip closer to where he suspected the assassin was. Duke followed him.

While a self-proclaimed weatherman started talking about the ghost attack, two figures who he recognized as the adult Fentons jumped out of the tank and started trying to blast both ghosts. Both of them belittled and dehumanized of both entities, leaving Jason stunned. He heard Maddie mention she didn’t think Phantom could help humans, but this was sheer hatred. Poor kid.

Eventually, Phantom trapped the other ghost in what appeared to be a soup thermos and sped off. Maddie and Jack jumped into their tank and chased after him. Somewhat worried, Jason radioed the others to see if they could keep tabs, if possible, on the kid. Tim’s tracker on him stopped working the previous night – they weren’t entirely sure if it’d been discovered or destroyed. None of them knew exactly what would happen to one if a ghost passed through a solid object while wearing it.

Duke got his attention and pointed to a figure who retreated from the tree Jason identified earlier. Even though the person seemed to be dressed in a normal suit, his movements gave him away.

“Up for some old-fashioned foot work?”

Notes:

For those of you who don't know, Jason did impersonate Dick as Nightwing for a while. That story line provided 2 of my favorite comic panels. It's called "Nightwing: Brothers in Blood"... but it might not be canon anymore? All the reboots have me a bit uncertain as what counts and what doesn't. No matter what, my mind still rejects the entire last half of that story arc. Why? Not gonna talk about it.

Duke is a meta. His abilities are light related, and as I understand it, it mostly affects his eyes. He'll get quick flashes of the past and future and can see outside of the normal spectrum. Some sources mention shadow manipulation, but we're not getting into that.

Also, if you'd like to stop by and say hi or ask questions, you can find me on Tumblr at ayamari-no-goshi. I promise I'm a lot less intimidating than I sometimes seem

Chapter 3 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/86874022>): I'm acquainted with your suffering

Notes:

New job is kicking my butt. And I am tired.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_3_endnotes\)](#).)

With Duke present, they were able to easily track the person from a distance. It made their task easier as they could follow from a greater distance and limit the risk of being caught. Next time he had a chance, he was going to upgrade the scanner system in his helmets. His was good, but not as good as Duke’s abilities. He was going to have to fix that.

They were using what appeared to be an old industrial building. Of course. What was it about criminals and places like that? So unoriginal.

Bruce wanted to be the one to set up their listening devices, but that didn’t mean that Jason couldn’t put some sensors around the area to keep track of whomever came and went. Or, take a quick peak inside of it. Satisfied, he and Duke headed back to their temporary base, also known as the stupidly posh hotel Masters put them in.

Back at the room, Jason found that Tim working on the belts. Not wanting to be anywhere near that mess, he decided to go up to the roof to smoke. He had been slowly cutting back, but with everything that happened today, he could use a cigarette.

The door was supposed to be armed with an alarm, but that meant little to him. It only took a minute to disarm it. While it didn’t seem like any of his siblings were following him, he wouldn’t be surprised if Cass, Dick, or Damian happened to be nearby. If they were, they decided to respect his privacy, for once.

The Pit stirred again. For the love of all things holy and unholy, why wouldn't it just stop today? He paused for a moment when he realized it was recognizing the presence of something else. Glancing around, he didn't see anything, but with a town supposedly full of ghosts...

"Who's there?"

"Sorry," Phantom appeared near the roof's edge. He nervously rubbed his neck.

"Are you tailing me? If you are, you're doing a poor job of it." Leaning against the wall of the staircase, he relaxed some. The ghost still didn't seem to be hostile.

"I... I was curious, that's all."

"Oh? About what?"

Phantom shifted uncomfortably as he slowly floated forward. "It's not very often a human seems to have been exposed to high levels of ectoplasm. I was trying to figure out if you were someone like me..."

Jason sighed before dropping his cigarette and stomping it out. "Your sister mentioned you had an accident in that portal."

"Sister? I don't have a...!!!" When Jason shot him an unimpressed glance, his shoulders slumped forward. "Damnit, Jazz," he muttered before he pleaded, "Please don't tell anyone."

"Saw how your parents reacted to you earlier. I can see why you aren't keen on sharing."

Phantom's eyes widened briefly before he looked away. "You saw that... Yeah, my parents love the human me, but the ghost me, well... they want to dissect me."

Jason ran a hand along part of his own dissection scars. It was an understandable fear. He'd been thankfully dead for it. Maybe that's why it was the only one of his 'injuries' that didn't heal in the Pit.

Phantom, on the other hand... Did Phantom count as being dead or alive? He hoped it wasn't the former. There were way too many researchers out there who would gladly ignore ethics. He decided to push those thoughts away for now.

"So, it was the portal that caused this?" he asked as he gestured to Phantom's glowing form.

He nodded as he gently touched down on the roof. Seeing him stand on something as opposed to float made him look more human. "Yeah, nothing like having something rip open a door to the afterlife where you're standing."

Jason winced at the confession. Yeah, that sounded even more painful than he originally imagined.

"How about you?"

"Hmm?"

Danny raised an eyebrow at him. "I saw how you reacted to the portal."

"Had a feeling you were watching us. But unlike you, I was dead, as in dead dead, when I was thrown into something that looks similar. It was a rather rude awakening." That was putting it lightly.

Danny seemed to realize he was staring at him and glanced away. "No wonder you said you preferred being called a zombie. I guess that wouldn't make you a Halfa."

"Halfa?"

"Oh, half ghost. It's what the other ghosts call us... er, me."

The kid said 'us' before correcting himself. How many other halves were there? Constantine indirectly mentioned them but didn't provide anything to hint at a number. If he had to guess, Masters would probably be one. He felt similar enough to Danny. Now the question was to bring it to Bruce's attention or let it sit. He'd make that decision later.

"Sorry to burst your bubble," he replied bringing himself back to the conversation, "but best I can tell, I'm entirely human. There were some side effects though."

"That's... that's why you kill people?"

He guessed this was Danny's way of confirming his suspicion of his alter ego and checking how the Pit affected him without directly asking. "No, but it makes it easier. I've seen a lot of terrible things, kid. Sometimes it's the only way to stop someone. Batman would disagree with me."

Danny nodded and surprised him by walking closer. "You aren't going to kill anyone here?"

"I'm not planning on it. Part of the agreement to have me come deals with using rubber rounds, but I can't guarantee anything. Death can still happen with those too." He pulled out another cigarette. "If it makes you feel better, the people we're looking for aren't locals."

"I wouldn't, if I were you. It's really easy for people to come back and haunt you in this town," the ghost boy, the Halfa, warned before floating up to the roof of the stairwell and sitting on it.

For some reason, his presence didn't bother him, probably because their shared understanding of life and death. A comfortable silence fell between them as he lit his cigarette.

That silence was broken when Tim burst through the door to the stairs, grinning like a mad man.

"I think I fixed it." He held out the Spector Deflector which appeared to have been activated.

Jason rolled his eyes. "Let me guess, you want me to test it. And if it doesn't work?"

"Back to the drawing board, I guess. Come on, Jay. You know I can't tell unless you try it." Stupid idiot tried to look innocent.

And he was just as much of an idiot for moving forward to touch the thing. As expected, it zapped him and he let out a string of curses as Tim backed away. Good, he learned his lesson the first time.

"Wait, the Spector Deflector zaps you too?" Phantom peered over the side at them before looking over at Tim. "Is that why you're tinkering with it?"

"Woah, Phantom?" Tim sent Jason a questioning look.

"We were bonding, or something liking that. He *recognized* me."

His brother nodded once before looking up at Danny. "Did you know this would happen?" He gestured with the belt.

"I... uh..."

"It's fine. Timber knows." The teen's eyes widened, possibly in understanding, making Jason smirk. He jerked his thumb towards him. "Glowstick here thought I might be a ghost or something like one."

"HEY!"

His brother gave a good-natured laugh. "Don't worry about him, Phantom. It's his way of showing affection. While you're here, do you have any suggestions on how to make this more selective?"

Danny slipped off the roof and floated near Jason. Odd. He figured he'd be more willing to get closer to Tim since he wasn't exposed to Pit water... ectoplasm... whatever the hell it was. Oh, but didn't Jazz mention the device zaps him too?

"If you could get it to tell the difference between different ectosignatures, then it'd work." Danny glanced between the two of them for a moment. "Err, ectosignatures are kind of like a fingerprint. While you'd sometimes find ghosts who have similar ones, there's always something that makes them unique. Skunk-head here," he gave a teasing grin, "probably has one if the Deflector affects him."

"Hmm... Human vitals are all unique, so I guess it would make sense ghost would have unique ones too. I think there was a mention of ectosignatures in the Fenton's published research... We'll get this to work, Jay."

"I'm not going to hold my breath. Anyways," Jason turned his attention back to Danny, "what exactly did you do to that other ghost earlier?"

The teen furrowed his brows in confusion for a moment. "Oh, you mean Skulker? I trapped him in the Thermos." He pointed to where the soup thermos looking device hung on his belt. "It's a containment device. I'll let him go in the Ghost Zone later." He made a face. "Actually, I might wait until that fundraiser thing is finished. Don't want to give Plasmius any advantages."

Mentioning the fundraiser reinforced Jason's suspicion about Masters. It was a little too coincidental.

However, Danny's explanation brought up a different question for Jason. "No punishment?"

"Skulker didn't... well... It's complicated?" He tapped the thermos. "Ghosts that we see in this realm are usually obsession driven. Skulker thinks of himself as the 'Ghost Zone's Greatest Hunter,' so he likes to hunt the rare and unusual. When he escapes to this realm, his main focus is catching me... unless he's getting intel for Plasmius."

"And what happens when someone gets hurt or killed because of that?"

"I can't destroy another ghost, if that's what you're getting at." Danny sounded almost insulted as his eyes narrowed.

Jason sighed as he moved towards the door to the stairwell. Tim gave him space. "I'm not suggesting anything of the sort. You're a good kid, Phantom. Better than I am. But if you keep letting your enemies off easy, it's going to bite you in the ass when they eventually go after someone else to harm you."

"You sound like you're talking from experience."

He glanced back at the teen. "It's how I got murdered. Anyways, I've got shit to do. See ya later."

As blunt as he was, he hoped Danny would seriously consider what he could do to help prevent his loved ones from being used as pawns. Jason's own mother had been used in that way, and he'd fallen for it without question.

Speaking of parents, Jason did have questions about Danny's. If they found out what their son was, would they harm him? They certain seemed to hate his ghostly persona, and Danny did verify they wanted to do him harm.

He probably shouldn't bring that up to Bruce. The man didn't need to consider adopting another one.

Shit. Duke probably brought it up to Bruce.

"You and Phantom seem to be getting along."

Jason glared at Dick and his stupid smile as they started their infiltration of the temporary, and still unoriginal, headquarters of the League. It didn't matter if the helmet was in the way or not; Dick could tell.

Banter had become a habit between them over the years. Sure, they could be quiet when needed, but it annoyed Bruce. And if you asked Jason, that was reason enough to do it.

"What? I can't make friends?"

"I didn't say that."

"Nightwing. Red Hood. Do you have eyes on them?" Bruce's voice came over the intercom. His slightly more gravely tone gave away his annoyance with them.

"Yeah, B," Nightwing replied as he took another look through his scope. "We can see five of them on our end. But is it just me, or haven't any of them moved?"

"Also five on our angle. No movement either," Tim reported. He and the demon spawn were paired together.

"Same," Duke added. In his pause, they could almost sense Cass nod beside him. "I'm not detecting any hint of past or future movement either."

"Hood, do you sense anything?"

Bruce's question surprised him. "You're actually asking me? What happened to the Fenton's devices? Though you swiped one." Technically, the old man bought it, but knowing him, it was going to end up being incorporated into Bat-tech sometime down the line.

"You were on the roof when B decided he wanted better proof it worked first," Dick whispered.

"What was the point in grabbing it then?"

"To study the energy source," Tim explained.

"Do you sense anything or not?" Ah, there it was, the tired father of six. Well, if you counted Stephanie and Babs, who both counted as a half, it came to seven

"No, not really." Pit had been surprisingly quiet after the chat with Phantom, but it had momentarily whispered at him near the perimeter of their current location. It happened often enough outside of Amity for him not to bother so it didn't warrant a mention.

"Move in."

They all dropped down from their places in the rafters to the floor below. Bruce, Tim, and Damian specifically aimed for the assassins. Duke tackled another from the back. Dick pinned the remaining one against a piece of old equipment while holding his escrima sticks to his neck. With that handled, Jason and Cass checked the area for hidden reinforcements.

A sense of wrongness settled over Jason. There was no noise. No sounds of struggling.

Dick stepped away from the assassin he pinned, and the guy's body just dropped to the floor. "He's dead." Surprise and confusion seeped into his tone.

"I... I think this one is too!" Duke stumbled away from his target. Tim, Damian, and Bruce all confirmed the assassins they targeted were also deceased.

No signs of injuries were evident on the bodies, but each one had an expression which suggested extreme pain prior to death. However, there were a few scuff marks on the ground that suggested a struggle. Duke's abilities confirmed they'd been taken by surprise. All of them were attacked at the same time, but he couldn't see who or what caused it. He also mentioned that each of them seemed to have odd marks around their hearts when he turned his attention towards the bodies themselves. Bruce's scanner confirmed the strange markings which were then shared with the group.

"Grandfather's men should be trained to handle anything." Damian voice contained an unusual hint of puzzlement.

"If I didn't know better, I'd say it looks like someone grabbed it," Dick murmured.

"Maybe someone did." Tim glanced around either in hopes of another clue or a glimpse at the attacker. "We're in a town where ghosts are reportedly commonplace. If these ones have abilities anything like a Martian..."

"Then it's possible that's what happened." If Jason didn't know better, he'd swear Bruce seemed unsettled by it.

"But why would a ghost do something like this?" Tim continued. "From what we can tell from the reports Oracle gathered, ghost-related deaths are rare. The only reported ones were associated with the town being supposedly pulled into a different dimension, and Phantom mentioned the ghosts we'll find in the different reports and news stories are obsession driven."

The Pit whispered what almost felt like a greeting. Glancing up, Jason's own scanners registered a cold spot similar to the previous night. "Instead of speculating, we could just ask a ghost what he thinks. Isn't that right, Phantom?"

The cold spot moved until it settled to his right. Phantom became visible a second later. "I thought you weren't going to kill anyone." He wasn't accusatory. And even though his voice seemed to be naturally distorted in his ghost persona... or was it a form, anyways, it still held a somber tone.

"They were posed," Cass stated as moved closer to Danny to silently study him. "We found." He flinched away from her before asking for more details.

Danny frowned at the information and outright grimaced when Bruce showed him a still image from the scanner. "I hate to say it," he eventually admitted. "A ghost could do something like that, but..."

"But?" Bruce prompted.

"But ghosts who target humans usually leave them alive. Emotions can be used as an energy source so..." He rubbed his neck while making a 'you get the picture' motion with the other hand.

Tim began tapping on his wrist computer as he spoke. "It wouldn't make sense to kill if you can continue using a person as a battery, but I take it that it does happen."

Danny nodded. "There are only two I know that would... but..." His breath misted before he had a chance to continue.

The Pit seemed to snarl at something. Not sure what to make at that unusual response, he drew one of his guns and fingered the taser hidden in his jacket. "Something's here."

"Multiple somethings," Phantom agreed as the faces of snarling animals started to slide through the walls. Well, they were green, glowing, and obviously mutated. "Ah, crud."

"Phantom, explain," Bruce ordered.

Danny jumped. Wide eyes showed just how unsettled he was by getting orders from the Batman. He was still a teen after all. "Uh, they're Plasmius' creations. Animal ghosts mostly run on instinct, but they have some intelligence. I'll be able to trap them in the thermos, but they usually need weakened first."

"Great." Dick's escrima sticks sparked with electricity. "So, any advice on how to fight them?"

"Don't get bitten." The kid was just as good at providing details in a fight as Bruce. Lovely.

The ghost animals moved as soon as Danny lunged forward. He flew so smoothly as he dodged and turned that if he didn't have a mutant ghost bear trying to bite his throat, Jason would have enjoyed watching the teen in his natural element. There was no shame in admiring the fighting style of someone else.

If you would have asked him what the ghost of an animal smelled like a week ago, Jason would have said nothing. He now knew better. It stunk like rotten meat and musk combined with the indescribable and repulsive smell of its saliva. As disgusting as it smelled, for a moment, part of his mind wondered if the smell of death accompanied him too. No matter what, a shower was absolutely necessary.

Annoyed at the bear deciding it wouldn't take a hint, he decided to taze the damn thing. It howled in pain and swung widely as stumbled away in pain. And it managed to knick the taser. Well, when he had no other immediate option as the taser built into his vest worked best if the enemy was touching it, best fallback was to punch it.

Even though he'd briefly caught sight of any non-electrically charged attack pass through the ghost animals, his punch connected. Maybe his dip in the Lazarus Pit would benefit him for once. When he attempted it again and got the same result, he smiled. It'd been a while since he had a good brawl, and he was going to enjoy it.

Something about the fight gave him a bit of nostalgia. Perhaps it was fighting along side Bruce and the others. Or maybe it was fighting a battle without the use of his guns. But for a moment, he almost felt as if he was back in the Robin mantle and kicking the shit out of some random henchmen. But those years were long gone.

The fighting stopped as Danny trapped the last of the ghosts in his thermos. Dusting himself off, Jason glanced around at the others. Most of them had wear and tear on their costumes, but there didn't seem to be any serious injuries with one exception.

Danny appeared to be nursing a bite mark on his arm. Instead of blood, a green ooze dripped from his arm. Did his body naturally produce that stuff instead of blood?

"I'll patch that up," Tim offered as he carefully approached Danny.

The ghost boy shook his head and floated backwards. "I appreciate the offer, really, but I can't stay here long. The Guys in White will be here shortly. They always come after a fight like this."

"We can protect you," Bruce offered.

"You won't be able to." Danny glanced at Jason again. "They might target you too, if they find out about you."

He snorted. "Wouldn't be the first time I had authorities after me."

Bruce chose to ignore him. "Fine. Do you have a place we can reconverge in an hour?"

"There's a clocktower in the middle of town. I'll meet you there if I can." Danny vanished from sight. Jason's scanners briefly caught sight of a cold signature dip into the ground and disappear.

"Phantom's not lying. I'm getting flashes of people rushing the building," Duke warned. After a quick nod from Bruce, all of the scattered.

For a few moments, Jason really did want to stay and see if these so-called government agents would decide to go after him. Dick and Bruce quickly put a stop to that. Maybe he could sabotage one of their vehicles with a bomb. If Tim or Babs could get him the schematics, that could be a little project while he was still in Amity. But he'd have to ask when Bruce wasn't around. Even if the explosion occurred when no one would be in the vehicle, Bruce would still lecture him. And if there was one thing Jason didn't need, it was another one of Bruce's lectures.

"Todd, how did you fight those ghost animals?"

Although Damian couldn't see it, Jason raised an eyebrow at him as they continued to wait for Phantom to show. It wasn't often the kid asked him anything. "And here I thought you were good at paying attention to your surroundings. I punched them."

"You know that is not what I mean."

"Dunno what to tell you. Wasn't expecting my fist to work either."

"You're lucky," Duke complained as he took a seat on the bell tower's ledge. "Even with my sight, I could barely dodge them let alone hit one."

"Keep this up and you'll end up working alongside Constantine," Tim teased.

"Do you really think I'd be able to put up with that Brit for more than a couple hours?"

"I don't know." Dick gave a playful grin. "I think the two of you could get along well enough for one mission. I think he'd be surprised to see the walking dead be able to sucker punch a ghost."

Jason had just enough of a warning from the Pit to glance behind him as Phantom manifested. The teen had a hastily applied dressing on his arm. His hunched shoulders and dimly glowing eyes suggested exhaustion.

He gave them a short wave and a tired grin before floating far enough forward to sit on the ledge of the clock tower. "Sorry I'm not floating. Fights like that take a lot of energy out of me. Oh, if you see a flash of light that means I probably passed out. I'd appreciate if someone would catch me so I wouldn't fall off the roof."

"Are you going to let me properly bandage that now?"

Danny glanced at his arm. "This? It's fine." When Tim just stared at Danny, he just held out his arm and glanced away. Of course Tim darkly muttered something as he went to work.

"Phantom, back to our discussion." Bruce stepped forward. "You mentioned a ghost could kill. You also said Plasmius made those creatures."

"Can I ask who those people were first?"

"Assassins. Now, explain."

"Assassin? Why the heck would assassins be in Amity Park?" At Bruce's glare, he gulped and explained, "Most ghosts won't kill. A lot of them... us... can get energy by tapping into human emotions. It doesn't really make sense to... well, you know."

"So, we really are like batteries to ghosts." Duke frowned at the idea. "I guess it wouldn't make sense for them to kill anyone."

"Er, yes? Especially to some like Ember and Spectra. My friends think I might have accidentally tapped into theirs at times when I've running on fumes."

"But it does happen." Danny winced at Bruce's tone.

"Yeah, but I only know of two who would do that, Pariah Dark and the Fright Knight." He rubbed his shoulder with his free hand. The momentary far away look in his eyes suggested he had an unpleasant history with at least one of them. "Pariah Dark would be more likely to crush a person than to do whatever happened there. Besides, he's currently locked away."

"Tt. And why would we believe that?" Damian did have a point.

"There'd be a mass exit of the ghosts of the Ghost Zone if he got free again. It happened before."

"And the other?"

"The Fright Knight is often said to be the spirit of Halloween. I know it's corny, but that's the way it is," Danny explained when Bruce raised an eyebrow at him. "But, Fright is more likely to trap someone in a nightmare using his sword than to kill, but he will if necessary. He's currently working with Plasmius, but I haven't seen him since Pariah was locked away."

"But what about Plasmius? Or should I say Masters?" Jason crossed his arms as he shifted. Danny mentioned the man in passing a few times already but never elaborated.

Phantom's eyes grew comically wide before he put a finger over his mouth. "Shush! Vlad has eyes everywhere."

"Hold still!" Tim warned. "I haven't finished yet. Besides, we already checked the area for bugs."

“So it’s true.” Batman took a step forward. “He’s like you then.”

“What part of ‘shush’ don’t you understand? If... if he thinks I told you...”

“Then what? What’s he got on you?” Jason asked as he shifted. Something about this kid really brought out his protective streak. “We can help.”

Danny wouldn’t look at them. “He’ll expose me... Ghosts and other ectoentities aren’t exactly protected by law.”

Quick glances circled around the group. Metas were protected by law. Surely Danny knew that, but he seemed convinced he’d be hunted. Was it the parents? No... well, probably not the main issue. Didn’t his friend mention something about a government organization?

“Under the Federal Anti-Ecto Control Acts, I don’t even count as sentient. That law allows the Guys in White to take unnecessary and lethal force... They’ll attack normal people too,” Danny explained.

Was that so? The Pit stirred at his anger, and for once, it didn’t seem to muddle his thoughts. He did want to explode one of their vehicles, but that was a bit too tame. Destroying one of their bases would do nicely. He should get Roy to come help.

“We will be able to provide you with asylum, if anything should happen.” Great. Bruce was considering adopting him. He could have sworn he heard Dick and Tim groan when they realized it.

Danny gave a humorless laugh. “Harboring someone like me is enough to get you jail time. Thanks though.”

“Do you really think that would stop him? Or any of us?” Jason wasn’t going to let Danny think he didn’t have support. He wasn’t an adult yet, and it wasn’t right for him to feel alone.

“We can discuss this at a different time.” Bruce shifted back to bat-business mode. “Would Plasmius do something like that? And what about the animals?”

“Plasmius sometimes... experiments. I think he was trying to figure out how to artificially stabilize ectoplasm.”

“Why?”

Danny took his arm back from Tim. His gaze seemed distant. “Doesn’t matter now. I destroyed that lab, and he hasn’t tried doing that again. But you asked about killing. It’s not really his style, but he might. He can make duplicates of himself, and a lot of them.”

“Duplicates?”

“Copies. Doubles. Some ghosts can split their forms. I’ve tried, but I’m not exactly great at it.” He wrinkled his nose. “You don’t want to see what happens when you mess that up. I don’t know how my friends don’t have nightmares about it.”

“When you said a lot,” Dick spoke up, “exactly how many did you mean?”

“I don’t know. He was able to control most of the town during the last election.”

“That is a lot.”

Danny yawned, and just for a moment, a ring of light appeared around his waist before fizzling out. “I guess it’s time for me to get to bed. Since I take it that you know who I am, you can easily find me.” He floated into the air and wobbled a moment.

“Do you really think you’re going to go home like that? You look like a breeze would knock you over.” Jason stared at the kid. Yeah, he was going to take him to his home. No way he was going to let a kid who looked dead on his feet attempt to go on his own.

Notes:

Jason does not canonically have an autopsy scar as the Pit was supposed to heal any scar he had. I don't care. This is a popular head cannon that I'm all for.

Nightwing's staff-like weapons are called escrima sticks.

I actually started reading Red Hood comics with the 2016 run of Red Hood and the Outlaws where Jason is teamed up with Artemis and Bizarro. Their dynamic great, but they're not exactly the best at covert. Roy is the better option in this instance. 😊

Chapter 4 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/87483016>): Can't Stand the Touch, Affection Weighs Too Much

Notes:

Possible needed warning? Talks surrounding death, dark humor related to death, self-deprecating thoughts throughout the work, and canon-typical violence.

Just as a heads up, I'm going to be very busy over the next month between regular job, my crafting business, and getting prepped for my first convention in 2 years. So, I have no idea when the next update is going to come.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_4_endnotes\)](#).)

Well, Bruce was the one who took Danny home. According to everyone else, he would jostle the kid too much while carrying him. Just because he doesn’t particularly like using grappling hooks, it doesn’t mean he can’t move smoothly.

But, he’d been tasked to work with Tim and Dick to review the information they took from the assassins’ bodies while the other three would return to the warehouse to see if they could find any more information. Bruce didn’t want him anywhere near an area where the G.I.W. could possibly be, at least until it was certain the organization’s equipment wouldn’t detect him. If anti-ghost equipment could harm him, it was possible various scanners could detect him.

They wanted to check it first with the one they got from the Fentons. Maddie had gone over how it worked, but due to Danny being in the house, she explained it would end up giving false readings. Might have been a good thing in the long run. As much as he was curious to see how badly the Fentons would react, making a public scene was currently a bad idea. They were trying to be discrete after all.

However, Jason decided to stay true to his promise to himself and get that shower first. He was not going to continue to stink like ghost bear spit for the rest of the night.

He tried to keep his mind from wandering too much during the shower. He knew full well that he shouldn't have been able to physically attack a ghost, but he didn't have much time to question it at the time. Had he been able to do that since he came back from the dead? What else did the Pit do to him other than the obvious body enhancement? Knowing he wouldn't get an answer from his own thoughts, he decided to finish up and rejoin Dick and Tim.

"Find any... never mind." He was going to ask but seeing as Tim already had two empty coffee cups, a compromise since he couldn't get his normal energy drinks in Amity, and Dick was hanging halfway off the bed reading something, they didn't have anything just yet. "What do you want me to start with?"

"Can you look at the readings of the assassins?" Tim didn't even look up from his laptop.

He grabbed his own computer, specifically supplied by Bruce for this mission, and began sorting through the information Babs organized for them. She also might be looking through the same information, but it was also possible her focus was on something else, like the Fenton's research or looking into Masters.

Duke's abilities suggested the assassins died shortly before they arrived to take them out, and the reading verified it. However, there was an odd temperature reading around the chest on the first one he checked. After death, the body cools down over the course of several hours, but it doesn't heat up. There was somewhat circular spot much warmer than the surrounding tissue just over the heart. A quick check showed the other four had the same spot.

"I might have something." His brothers crowded around as he pointed out the discovery.

"Could it have been a heat ray or something like that?" Dick questioned. "No, that wouldn't make sense. There's no evidence of the heart or any other organ being cooked, and the skin doesn't seem to have been burned."

"Could it have really been a ghost, and that's where it, or a hand at least, entered the body?"

Tim frowned as he turned his attention back to his laptop. "But aren't ghosts supposed to be cold. Phantom's readings are insane, and I have no idea how he's still alive... well, at least partially alive. How does that work?"

"We'd probably have to ask Phantom that one," Babs answered over their communicators. "However, some of the Fenton's and even the G.I.W.'s research suggest that some ghosts do have abnormally warm temperatures. The ones I can find have obvious fire related abilities, but it does appear most of them run cold."

"I guess we can't rule out ghosts."

"Babs, do you have any data about a ghost named Plasmus?" Jason had a sinking suspicion that Masters was somehow involved, especially after the appearance of the mutant ghost animals.

"Honestly, I don't have a lot," Babs replied accompanied by some tapping. "We only have a few hints from the Fenton's research. There's nothing in the G.I.W.'s database, but there seems to be some evidence of tampering. If they previously had anything, it's long gone."

"Any chance of restoring it?" Dick questioned as he maneuvered himself between his brothers.

"At this point, I doubt it, but I'll look to see if I can find the hacking signature."

Jason absently rubbed the large scar on his chest as he leaned away from Dick. "So, what do we have on him?"

"I'll send you the files, but honestly, it's just the basics like appearance, approx. height, noted abilities."

"Phantom wasn't joking when he said Plasmus looks like a vampire." After a quick review, Jason was disappointed that there wasn't a temperature recording for Plasmus. However, there was a note mentioned that either fire or electrical abilities were suspected. While it didn't confirm anything, other heroes and villains with those types of abilities did tend to be warmer than the average person.

After a moment of debating, he added, "You know... the Pit did react to something when we reached the perimeter of the warehouse."

"You said you didn't sense anything," Tim glanced over at him.

"Once we were inside, I didn't until Phantom showed up." He ran his hand through his hair. "It stirs a lot, and I thought it was just that. But maybe it wasn't. It's not like I really understand how this works."

Dick attempted to pat his shoulder, only for him to bat it away. "We'll talk to B about it. You might have to start letting us know when that happens until we get to the bottom of this."

"If you want false alarms all day, sure, because it happens all the time, especially here."

"If I'm not mistaken, you can tell when it's Phantom though," Babs noted.

"Yeah... it's..." he frowned for a moment as he tried to find the word, "...like a greeting? It's stupid when I try to explain it, but it really didn't like those ghost animals." If he wasn't mistaken, his brothers wanted him to elaborate further. Too bad he wasn't going to. "I'm going to review those images again, but unless something jumps out at me, I'm pretty sure a ghost is our best bet for a culprit."

About an hour later, the rest of them returned to the hotel room. Although it wasn't obvious to the untrained, the Batman was irritated. The G.I.W. contaminated the entire scene with their equipment. This included driving a tank through one of the walls and, judging by scorch marks, destroyed another one with some of their weaponry. Some of them were also still lingering around the fencing.

They quickly exchanged information. While they couldn't eliminate another force dealing with the League, as of right now they agreed the current most likely suspect was Masters. While Tim shifted back to working on the belts, Bruce took over for him.

Jason, on the other hand, decided to investigate Masters.

On the surface, everything seemed normal. However, with a little help from Babs, they found a lot more than they expected. “No wonder why Danny calls him a Fruitloop,” he mumbled. Weapons, ectoplasmic composition, ectobiology, cloning, and something referred to as ecto-acne were just the tip of the iceberg. He had to recruit Duke and Dick to help sort through all of it.

After a few hours, Tim announced that he thought he had isolated Phantom’s ectosignature from the samples he took from the kid when he was bandaging him. And with a caffeine-fueled grin, he demanded a blood sample from Jason.

“You have that on file already.” He narrowed his eyes. The most recent sample had been personally provided by him when he revealed himself to Bruce after his resurrection.

“Yeah, but I need a fresh one to try to figure out your ecto-signature. If I remember, there were some abnormalities in it.” Of course, the little nerd remembered that without checking. “We believed that was residue from the Pit. I’ll have to double check, but we might be able to label it as ectoplasm now.”

After rolling his eyes, Jason used one of his knives to cut the back of his hand and held it out to his brother. With the sharpness of the blade and the enhanced healing the Pit gifted him, it’d be mostly healed within a few hours. He’d still have to wrap it just to prevent any chance of it getting on anything prior to that. Leaving as little trace as possible was figuratively beaten into them.

The regular chatter soon filled the room as they continued to work on their projects. While they still had little to go on regarding the assassins, they slowly uncovered a great deal about Masters. If what Babs uncovered was correct, Masters had spent a great deal of time trying to cover up what was happening in Amity. There were several files regarding various events in the town and what was provided to outside sources.

On top of that, there were several documents regarding Danny and his family. The man was absolutely obsessed with the Fentons, particularly Danny and his mother. And if the files were accurate, the man tried to clone Danny several times but stopped after catastrophic damage to his equipment. That’s probably what Danny referenced when talking about the experiments. The oddest thing was the apparent lack of interaction with known supervillains outside of regular business deals.

“Was it really just a fight over turf?” Duke yawned as he flopped backwards on the bed.

“Until we have evidence to prove otherwise, it seems that way,” Bruce agreed.

With no other obvious motive, it really seemed Masters was trying to keep others from interfering in the town. What surprised Jason was the man only seemed to make a tentative move against them. Perhaps he wanted to see if they were only interested in the assassins? Or were mutant ghost animals retaliation for befriending Danny?

Damian tutted. “I still find it unlikely men trained by grandfather would lose in such a battle.” Cass silently nodded.

“You couldn’t detect Phantom, could you?” Tim glanced away from his tinkering for just a moment.

The brat huffed and glanced away. “That’s different.”

With a stretch, Jason popped his back. “If it was Masters, he can sneak in undetected and his multiple foes at once. He’s a new type of enemy with unusual tactics. Anyways, did someone want to see if that Fenton device worked?”

Dick’s grin could only be considered childish as he flipped over the bed to grab the device. Show off. “I call dibs!”

Within moments, the device was booted up and a pleasant but robotic voice spoke, “Welcome to the Fenton Finder. There is a ghost four feet in front of you. You would have to be an idiot not to see the ghost in front of you. Thank you for using the Fenton Finder.”

Jason tried to suppress his desire to punch Dick in the mouth for the stupid shit eating grin currently plastered on his face. “Don’t even say it.”

They slept in shifts. Tim was forced to sleep on the first shift. He tried arguing, but a threat of bodily harm helped convince him. Jason was not above pistol whipping his brother. He had kneed him the groin before. Or was that Dick? He was dealing with both of them at that particular moment.

He slept on the third shift. Why their hotel had a presidential suite baffled Jason since Amity wasn’t considerably important compared to say Gotham, Metropolis, or Star City, but it was nice having a place big enough that they could go into a separate room to sleep. It reduced the likelihood he’d be rudely woken up with Tim zapping him, but it didn’t completely get rid of the possibility.

If Tim pulled that crap, he would punch the idiot in the mouth.

Sleeping didn’t come easy. His dreams kept throwing him back in the Pit, complete with the unimaginable pain of being forced back to life. His psyche must have been sick of the reminder as he jolted awake.

But he didn’t wake up in a bed. Instead, wooden planks filled his vision. Was it a coffin? It better not be a coffin. Someone was going to die if it was. For years, he had nightmares about waking up in one. It hadn’t been something brought up to his family, but he did mention it in passing to Roy once.

However, after a quick glance. He realized he was just under the bed. Cussing out his family for playing such a stupid prank on him, he began the very annoying process of trying to get out from under it. His body type made it more difficult than it needed to be.

How the heck did they pull it off anyways? He’d heard of some of the pranks between Dick, Tim, and Damian, but those didn’t usually involve physically picking someone up off a bed. They were all trained to be light sleepers, and unless sleep deprivation took over, being jostled usually was enough to wake them up.

Grumbling after finally getting out from beneath the bed, he glanced up to see Dick staring at him from the other bed. “What’s your problem?”

Dick raised an eyebrow at him. “Was the bed that uncomfortable?”

“If I find out you put me under there, I’m going to break your leg.”

“That’s enough of that,” Bruce warned as he appeared in the doorway.

“Judging by your scowl, I’m going to bet we don’t have any new information.” Jason glanced at the clock on the nearby desk. It was just past seven a.m.

“Correct. Both Masters and the Fentons have already contacted me.”

Dick let out a low whistle. “The Fentons are already done with our order? I’m actually impressed. You said they’re an entirely independent operation, right?”

“That’s what it looked like. That basement of theirs is a lot like a smaller version of something you’d see at Star Labs or Cadmus,” Jason crossed his arms as he shifted his weight. “What did Masters want?”

“Business meeting, or at least that what it sounds like. He wanted to meet in neutral ground at a local restaurant. I was going to bring Tim and Damian with me while Cass and Duke search his manor.”

“That leaves us to talk to the Fentons.” Dick frowned as he went over the plan. “Why would you have Damian come with you?”

Bruce gave an almost smug smile. “Masters doesn’t seem to know how to handle him.”

After getting ready, Bruce pulled him aside. “I’d like you to see if you can get a clearer picture of Danny’s home life while you’re there.”

“Was already going to do that,” with how Danny’s parents acted around his ghost form, making sure the kid was safe at home was already at the top of Jason’s list of things he needed to do while still in Amity, “but are you sure you want me at the Fenton home?” It did have what they could basically call an artificial Lazarus Pit in the basement.

“You have the best rapport with the children. We still don’t have a clear picture of what Masters wants.”

“And you want me to see if Danny will be willing to give me more information. Got it.” Before he could move, Jason noted that Tim was approaching with Spector Deflector. “Guess you want me to test it before I leave?”

Tim held it out. “I think I finally figured it out.”

He heard that one before. After a needed eyeroll, he grabbed it. However, instead of the intense shocking pain of before, this was more akin to an unpleasant buzzing similar to using certain types of power tools. “Still feel it, but it’s nothing like what it was. I wouldn’t want to wear it for any length of time, but I’d love to hear what happens when Masters touches it.”

“I might not have enough time to tinker with it and fix the other belts before tonight so you might have to deal with it.” Tim then grinned at him. “I’ll tell you how Masters reacts when we get back.”

“Jay, you ready?” Dick called from near the door. He seemed almost giddy to leave. He hadn’t seen the Fenton household yet, so maybe that’s why he was so excited?

Shaking his head, he moved to grab his jacket. “Just need this...?” He thought he grabbed his jacket, but somehow his hand was sticking through it. Pulling his hand out of the leather, he found it appeared as a pale shadow of itself until about midway up his forearm. “Well, that’s new.”

Immediate alarm spread through the room. Everyone wanted to make sure he was okay, and that involved touching and more than a few scans. Sometime during the scuffle and trying to keep Dick away from him, his arm went back to normal.

“Back off! It’s fine now,” he snarled as he grabbed his coat.

“But, but you don’t know that,” Duke spoke up. “You said this wasn’t normal.”

Tim hummed for a moment as he checked the scans. “Vitals look normal, but didn’t you say the entire town feels like a toned-down version of the Pit? Maybe it has something to do with that?”

“Until we know what’s going on...”

Jason bristled Bruce’s attempt at concern. “Bruce, don’t finish that statement. If this is because of the town, do you really think staying here is going to change anything? It’s even more reason to talk to Danny. He’s probably the only one who might be able to explain what that was or if it’ll be a problem.”

“You know he’s worried about you.”

Jason rolled his eyes. “He certainly likes to pick and choose when he cares. Dick, you know how he is. Right now, he’s only worried about whether or not I’ll compromise the mission. Maybe if we were on our way home, I’d buy it, but not now.”

Dick stood in front of him, forcing him to stop walking. “Little wing... Jay... what happened to you affected him, badly. You didn’t get to see it. On top of that, you’re the only one we know of who seems to be permanently affected by the Pit.”

“Yeah? Well, it sucks.” Jason pushed past his brother and continued forward. Dick wasn’t wrong. The effects of the Pit were supposed to dissipate after a while, but they never did for him. “I had heard Cass was resurrected in it too. But she’s clearly not crazy.” He left out the obvious, ‘Like I am.’

“The only thing I think makes you crazy is your dislike of grappling hooks.”

“I don’t dislike them. I just don’t need them as much as you do.” He smiled despite himself. It was true. He had gotten so used to being able to bounce off the side of a building or catching himself with a ledge or flagpole that grappling hooks just weren’t as appealing as when he was younger. Made a great trick when trying to catch the attention of a Kryptonian. He still had one, just in case.

His brother nudged him with his elbow. “Now you’re smiling. None of us are still really sure what happened to you once you came back, but we’ve started seeing glimpses of the old you. That’s probably thanks to Kori and Roy more than anything we’ve done to help.”

When he didn’t respond, Dick took that as an invitation to continue. “We’re in new territory when it comes to ghosts and the like, so we’re all a bit on edge.”

“Meaning you’re worried I’m going to go on a killing spree.”

“What? No!”

“You don’t have to hide it.” Jason glanced up at the sky before taking a cigarette out of his jacket and lighting it. “The need... desire... obsession? I don’t know how to explain it... for taking them out, permanently, hasn’t been as bad for a while now.”

“Except for Joker.”

“Can you blame me on that one?”

“No, not really.”

A comfortable silence fell between them as they continued to walk until Dick pulled the cigarette out of his mouth. “What the fuck?”

“You know these will kill you.” Dick just grinned in a teasing way as he stomped out the cig.

“Been there. Done that. I think I’ll take my chances, especially if it helps me deal with nosy assholes like you.”

“You wound me, brother.” He dramatically placed the back of his hand on his forehead. “So, what’s the Fenton Portal like?”

“You know, if you ask them, I have a strong feeling they’ll show you.” Jason had no doubt the Fentons would do that. Glancing up, he caught sight of the metal monstrosity on the roof of the Fenton household. He gestured to it. “And that’s our destination.”

“How on earth is that even allowed?”

As predicted, the Fenton adults were more than happy to show Dick the portal after being introduced to them. Jason opted to stay in the kitchen while that occurred which was code for he was going to take a look around. However, he did make sure to ask two questions, one about the security system they had and the second about the hunk of metal they called the ops center.

Like Tim had found on his preliminary surveillance, their security system did include lasers. And after the quick demonstration via Jack, they quickly found out there were a lot of them. Who in their right mind did that in the main part of the house? He could see them doing that in the lab, but the staircase too? There were even metal claws and ecto-weaponry that appeared out of, well, everywhere.

After turning off the internal security, Maddie casually mentioned that the weapons vault under the stairs could withstand almost any attack. That is not something that should be mentioned to a virtual stranger.

Moments after that, both Jazz and an exhausted looking Danny hurried down the stairs. After Jazz reprimanded her parents for turning on the security, she greeted him and introduced herself and Danny to Dick, followed by an apology about having them see that.

“Oh, Jazzy-pants, now that you’re here, can you show Jason the Ops Center? We were going to show Dick the portal, but he’s already seen that,” Jack requested while wearing his signature grin. Apparently, he was a morning person. If he wasn’t, how in the world was he so excited so early?

“Are you seriously going to open that thing again?” Jazz demanded.

“It’s perfectly safe. Besides, we’ll be there.”

“Your mother is right. If any ghost scum bursts through, we’ll be there to take care of it!” Jack puffed his chest out. He was certainly sure of himself, but Jazz and Danny just shared a look.

“It’ll be fine. We’ll just be a few minutes, and then we’ll met you up in the Ops Center.” With that, Maddie led the way down the stairs to their lab. Jack wrapped his arm around Dick’s shoulders as he escorted him while talking about ghosts.

Dick looked back at him in mild concern. Jason just smiled and waved.

“You’re not worried?” Jazz questioned, noticing his reaction.

“Nope.” He popped the ‘p’. “Dick can take care of himself. Anyways, sorry about the rude awakening. I asked about the security, but I wasn’t expecting a demonstration.”

Danny grumbled something before speaking up. “They’ll show anyone basically anything if they think there’s interest.”

“With how advanced some of this stuff is, I’m surprised they’re so lax about it.”

“Up until more recently, ghost hunting really wasn’t considered anything but quack science. Both of them are brilliant, but not being taken seriously for years has made them a bit enthusiastic about sharing information.” Jazz then turned to the coffee maker while Danny sat at the kitchen table and started nodding off again. “Let me make myself and Danny some coffee then we’ll take you on the tour.”

A few minutes later, coffee was made. Jason decided to tell a few harmless stories about his siblings, such as one of Dick’s disastrous attempts at using a chandelier as a trapeze, while Jazz and Danny slowly became more alert.

Things were going well until the Pit decided to, for lack of a better word, violently flare. It could feel the portal in the basement calling to it. While trying to hide it, the hand that had been keeping him steady while he leaned against the counter slipped causing him to stumble.

Danny was by his side in a moment, now wide awake. “Are you okay?” When he nodded, the kid added, “The Portal is pretty intense when it gets opened. You get used to it after a while. Is your hand okay?”

“What do you mean...?” He glanced at the hand that caused him to slip and found it had that strange washed out look from earlier. “Oh... That just started, and I think you’re the only person who might have an idea of what’s going on. But...” He nodded towards Jazz.

“Don’t worry, I know about Danny’s situation,” she explained as she moved towards a section of the wall and pressed an unassuming panel. A staircase appeared. “We’d probably move the conversation to the Ops Center though. We can at least get a few seconds of warning before someone bursts through the hatch with some sort of ecto-weapon.”

“I’m assuming that happened?”

“A lot. They’ve destroyed my bed a few times, attacked one of my teachers...” Danny frowned for a moment. “How many times was the mailman attacked before the post office started forcing them to come to the station to get it?”

“I think it was five.”

“How haven’t your parents been arrested?”

Notes:

It's really hard to find panels of Jason using grappling hooks as an adult. I first noticed this in "Under the Red Hood", both the animated film and the comic, and I checked with other fans, who verified it's pretty rare to see it depicted.

While it's common fanon to have Tim as a coffee drinker. He's really not. He instead tends to drink these energy drinks called "Zesty". I'm gonna make the assumption that it's more of a local brand. You'd be surprised what drinks you can and can't get in different parts of the US.

In the comic version of "Under the Red Hood", Jason cut the back of his head to provide Bruce with a blood sample. In the movie, Bruce got it off of the sword of an assassin.

There is a wonderful panel of Jason fighting both Dick and Tim. One is being kned in the groin and the other is being punched in the mouth. This was during what I affectionately call his bat shit crazy days.

I previously mentioned the two different variations of Jason's resurrection. Which version is canon can vary between DC reboots. And for some reason, my mind has decided that as an effect of that, some of the characters might have nightmares about alternative versions of bad experiences. In this case, it's Jason waking up in a coffin.

There is a fan comic I saw years ago which had Bruce occasionally doing normal businessman things to annoy the crap out of supervillains. The one I particularly remember is him putting a giant billboard of himself in front of Luthor's penthouse view. I accept this occasional pettiness as a personal head canon.

One last note. Cass was killed by her mom and resurrected in a Lazarus Pit (I think this is still canon?), but she didn't have the so-called 'perfect' resurrection Jason did. As of right now, I don't think we have a proper explanation for why he did when others didn't. I'm going to make the assumption it either dealt with how he died or the length of time it took between death and the dip in the Pit. (edit: 2010 RHaTO state his connection to the Pits are due to him being dunked at the same time Ra's was. Doesn't make sense, but okay)

Chapter 5 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/87643591>): It Was Easier to Shatter Everything that Ever Mattered but You Didn't Because It's Your Obsession

Notes:

Possible needed warning? Talks surrounding death, dark humor related to death, self-deprecating thoughts throughout the work, and canon-typical violence.

Well, I didn't plan on getting this chapter finished this week, but it happened. And I am puzzled.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_5_endnotes\)](#).)

The Ops Center was very similar to mission control rooms Jason saw throughout his journeys after his resurrection. Parts of it were even like the main computer of the Batcave, and Jazz explained that it had the ability to switch between a plane, blimp, and car forms. Jack and Maddie really were giving Wayne Industries R&D department a run for their money. The only thing that struck him as odd was the working refrigerator Danny off-handily mentioned was filled with emergency ham.

"Before we talk about anything, I want to make sure this room isn't bugged." Maintaining secrecy was a core part of Batman's training. Sure, he was still technically legally dead, but he had been seen enough times recently that he needed to remember to keep up his civilian façade.

Danny raised a questioning eyebrow before smacking himself in the forehead. "That's right. You overheard me talking about the Fruitloop's stupid spy devices."

"The what now?" Jazz crossed her arms as her eyes narrowed at her brother. "Did you forget to tell me something?"

The teen rubbed the back of his neck. "Vlad sometimes puts these little spy robots in the house. They look like bugs. I haven't seen any since I destroyed the last couple."

"Danny! That's important!"

Chuckling at their antics, Jason pulled out the prototype domino mask he'd been working on. Since the helmet was a bit conspicuous when he was out and about, he'd been working on an alternative. "Give me a second to run a quick scan."

They watched in silence as he looked around the room. While there were still some kinks to work out, he did get a couple hits. Walking over to the first one, he found an insect-like machine sitting on top of a few wires. After showing it to an alarmed Danny and Jazz, he crushed it before moving on to the next one. Three more were destroyed before he was comfortable enough to talk.

"How does he keep getting them in here?" Danny wondered as Jazz darkly muttered something about checking the bathrooms.

"If they can fly, they can easily get into an open door, but they're also small enough to crawl through gaps," Jason mentioned as he put his mask away in one of his jacket pockets. He might want to invest in bots like this. They were much more discreet than the devices he currently used.

"I'm going to go through this house and seal up everything I can after this." Jazz's scowl softened as she turned her attention back to Jason. "You wanted to know what's going on with you, right?"

"That'd be nice," he glanced down at his now normal looking hand. "I have no idea what that was or why that suddenly started. There are others I know who have gone through something similar to me." When confusion flashed across Danny's face, Jason elaborated. "They had the same type of exposure I did, but none of them had lasting effects. And, none of them have displayed anything like this."

"Others?"

“Yeah, you met a few of them recently.” Debating on how much he could safely say, he added, “A regular pain in the ass watches over something similar to your parents’ Portal. He mostly uses it for healing injuries and keeping himself young and insane. Getting exposed to it is an occupational hazard when dealing with him. It’s more like a pool though.” That should be enough information for now.

Danny’s eyes widened in understanding. “Ectoplasm is a weird thing. Exposure to it can cause different effects. Most of my school experienced ghost-like abilities when they were infected by what I can really only describe as a ghost mosquito, but everyone recovered with no lasting effects.”

“Is that what happened?” Jazz shot her brother a look. “I had almost contributed that whole thing to a mass hallucination.”

“It’s probably better to think of it like that. It was one of Spectra’s plans.”

Spectra? That name sounded familiar. “Was that the ghost who impersonated a school counselor?”

“Yep.” The kid grimaced at the thought. “She feeds on misery and is well practiced at getting under people’s skins. Anyways,” he continued with a dismissive wave of the hand, “going back to ectoplasm. For me and Vlad, we both survived accidents with it that should have killed us. I had signs something was wrong almost immediately, but Vlad mentioned his powers came gradually. But, he did get very sick for several years first.”

“So... exposures usually don’t have lasting effects.” That didn’t really help him much.

“What happened to me was a fluke... Due to reasons, I know that the accident could be replicated with the same results if I happened to lose my powers.” His gaze momentarily grew distant before he shivered. “But, we don’t know if I am the only one who would have survived it.” He turned his attention back to Jason and studied him for a moment. “It’s possible since you already are ‘contaminated’, the naturally high levels of ambient ectoplasm could be affecting you.” He glanced at Jazz. “Do you think I should take him to Frostbite?”

“Who?”

“One of Danny’s allies in the Ghost Zone.” Jazz tapped her cheek a few times as she considered it. “That might not be a bad idea. It’s early enough to make the trip and get back in time to get ready for tonight. I guess you’d like me to get our parents out of the house?”

“That’d be great.”

“Fine.” Jazz huffed as Danny shot her an innocent grin. “But you owe me. Make sure to let Sam and Tucker know where you’re going to be in case they need to reach you.”

“Yeah, yeah, I know.” Danny typed something on his phone before showing it to Jason. It was just a message about him going into the Ghost Zone for a bit. There was no mention of the why. “I figured you probably don’t want my friends to know.”

“You’d be correct.” He was probably going to have to check how much Danny may or may not have mentioned to his friends. It was one thing to tell them his secrets, but another to reveal his or his family’s secrets.

Their plan was very simple. Once their parents finally came up to the Ops Center, Jazz and Danny would announce they got a report of a ghost all the way across the town to get them out of the house. While Jazz kept an eye on them from the safety of the house, Danny would lead Jason into the Ghost Zone to meet Frostbite.

It was a bit too simplistic for his taste. Who would fall for such a simple rouse? There was also no way Dick would let him go without tagging along. Danny reluctantly agreed that was fine.

Much to his surprised, when Maddie and Jack finally appeared with his brother, who almost looked shell-shocked, Jazz immediately announced that they got a reading about a ghost in one of the parks. Both of them immediately drew weapons from somewhere (he needed to find out exactly how they hid those ecto-weapons on them without them being obvious) before dashing off down the stairs. Moments later, they heard a roaring engine and screeching tires.

Jason stood there in stunned silence as he tried processing exactly what happened. “How... how did that work? That shouldn’t have worked.”

Danny gave him a tired smile. “It works every single time with them.”

“Guns blazing and all?”

“Yep.”

“What exactly did I just watch?” Dick finally asked with obvious confusion coloring his voice.

Jason patted his brother’s shoulder. “That was a distraction, Dickie-bird. Anyways, are you up for a trip?”

It took a little bit of coaxing from Danny to get Jason to enter the vehicle he called the Specter Speeder, which was a weird combination of a boat and some of the spaceships he’d seen in the past. Danny explained it was the fastest mode of travel through the Ghost Zone which waited for them on the other side of the Portal. Questionable vehicles he could handle. Going through that Portal, that was another thing.

However, Dick seemed excited about the situation and happily boarded the Speeder. He had removed his civies to reveal his Nightwing costume, much to Danny’s and Jazz’s surprise. Since they didn’t know who or what they’d encounter, it was the best way to protect his identity. While Jason didn’t have his helmet, his domino mask and lower mask were worn for the same reason.

“Changing up the look?” Dick just smiled as Jason joined him and Danny in the Speeder.

Jason just rolled his eyes. “Would you rather me carry the helmet, which I should remind you contains explosives, everywhere I go?”

“Point taken.”

Danny, now in his Phantom form, paused from pressing buttons on the control panel to stare at him. “You’re willing wear something on your head that can explode?”

He shrugged. “A lot of villains like trying to remove masks or helmets. If a helmet explodes, there’s always a chance it’ll happen again.” One of the cardinal rules of Batman’s teachings was that criminals were a cowardly and superstitious lot, and many of them were. Unfortunately, not all of them.

While Danny continued to stare at him, Dick laughed. “We watched your parents pull weaponry from out of thin air, but you’re shocked by this.”

“But it can...” Danny stopped mid sentence and rubbed his eyes. “You know what? Half of my parents’ inventions explode too. I’m going to stop thinking about it.” He pushed a few more buttons before grabbing the controls.

The Speeder lifted and smoothly drifted forwards. Danny tapped a green earpiece. “Jazz, can you hear me okay?”

Her voice came over a speaker system in the Speeder. “Loud and clear. I’ll do my best to keep Mom and Dad busy while you’re gone. Stay safe!”

“Ready to see the land of the dead?” Danny questioned as Jason and Dick moved forward to get a better view of the windshield. Before either of them could reply, he moved the controls forcing the Speeder forward as it slipped through the Portal.

Jason stiffened as they crossed the threshold. Images of being forced back to life and waking up in a pool of glowing green danced across his vision. Echoes of pain danced across his body. But it vanished almost as quickly as it came.

“Are you okay?” Danny glanced up at him. “I forgot that sometimes you can get an echo of what happened. I’m not sure if I just got used to it or if it stopped happening after a while.”

“Hood?” Dick steady gaze and uneasy tone showed his brotherly concern.

He shook his head. “Bad memories. It’ll pass.”

The Pit whispered, almost gleefully, as they got their first view of the so-called Ghost Zone. Swirling bands of green were only broken up by the site of floating islands and the occasionally floating door. In the distance, Jason could see almost familiar shapes. Were they stairs? Maybe walls? If it wasn’t for how active the Pit was, he might have been in awe.

Unlike the other times the Pit was so active, he wasn’t overcome with the obsessive thoughts. Instead, there was just recognition for something similar, like when he returned to Gotham after his time away.

As they traveled, Danny explained that the islands and doors often were claimed by various ghosts. Each area had become shaped by the influence of the resident ghost. Danny described some of them as they passed them. For example, one island contained a large manor building which Danny explained was a sprawling library owned by a ghost called the Ghost Writer. Apparently, the ghost did not appreciate intruders, especially if they caused any damage to his books. If he was honest, Jason wanted to peek inside. Maybe there were some rare first editions Alfred would like.

Soon, they started approaching what appeared to be a giant block of ice and snow, and the temperature inside the Speeder started to drop. Danny asked Dick to take the controls, “I just need you to keep it straight for a moment,” before disappearing for a few moments. He reemerged carrying two heavy coats.

“You’re going to need these,” he explained as he passed them out and reclaimed the controls. “This is the Realm of the Far Frozen, and it’s just as cold as it sounds. It’s one of the only places in the Ghost Zone where you can find a medical center.”

They touched down what seemed to be a few minutes later. Before he opened the hatch to the Speeder, Danny hesitantly explained, “Ah, you’ll hear Frostbite call me the ‘Great One.’ I might have helped stop the old ghost king from taking over both the Ghost Zone and Earth at one point.”

Jason shared a look with Dick. That was definitely a story he’d like to hear. While Danny didn’t seem too keen to talk about it, but maybe this Frostbite would.

Once they exited the ship, they found themselves surrounded by a group of ghosts Jason only could describe as looking like a cartoonish depiction of the Yeti. The one in center, who was distinguished by an icy arm which contained visible bones, moved forward and happily greeted Danny with a bear hug.

After escaping from the grip, Danny introduced them to the leader, now identified as Frostbite. He then gave a quick explanation as to why they were there. The yeti’s expression grew more and more concerned as Danny spoke.

“That is rather odd. Come,” Frostbite beckoned to Jason and Dick, “I will have my people run a few tests. I would also like to listen to your story. Perhaps that holds some answers.”

After leading them into what originally appeared to be a carved-out cavern in an icy wall, Frostbite led them to an intricately designed door which opened to reveal a sparking medical center. If he hadn’t just come from what appeared to be a frozen wasteland, Jason would have thought he walked into a state-of-the-art hospital. He hadn’t expected to see such technology in this place. It was also a great deal warmer than the icy exterior.

Frostbite instructed a few other of his yetis to get a few things ready before instructing Jason to remove his coat and shirt. With Dick and Danny present, it wasn’t really something he wanted to do. Neither of them needed to see that scar. However, Frostbite explained it would be easier for him to check for certain vitals.

After some encouragement from his brother, Jason just grumbled a bit before finally complying. The feel of the room, which was originally pleasant, turned tense as he heard gasps from those in the rooms. Yeah, it wasn’t normal for living people to have dissection scars.

“What... what happened?” Danny’s voice was barely audible.

“Told ya, kid, I was dead before I came back.” He gestured to the scar. “This is my permanent souvenir.”

“Little wing...” Dick didn’t pay any attention when Danny raised an eyebrow at the nickname. Instead, he moved forward to give a brotherly hug. “None of us knew...”

“And I wanted it that way.”

“I should have been there.”

“Don’t pull this fucking shit!” He snapped as he pushed his brother away. “What happened was my fault. I got duped and went in alone. Don’t you dare blame yourself for my stupidity.” He breathed heavily a few times as the greenish fog in his vision

dissipated. Strong emotions were apparently a bad thing in this place. He really didn't need to let the influence of the Pit take him in front of people who were trying to help him. "Don't go telling anyone else. I don't need anyone else blaming themselves."

Frostbite politely coughed to remind them he was there. Once making sure everything was okay, he requested for Jason to explain what exactly happened to him. So, he did, with the least amount of detail possible. Danny and Frostbite winced several times while Dick hovered silently.

When the ghost pressed for information about the Pit, he looked to Dick for help. How much should he say? How much could he say? For him, it was the hardest part of the tale to come to terms with, and he still hated talking about it.

Dick seemed to catch the drift and took over in the explanations. He kept it brief. The Pit could both heal the sick and dying but kill the healthy. For most people, it temporarily enhanced their bodies but brought madness that was usually temporary. He also talked about the color, that eerie glowing green.

"Being placed in that was how you returned?" Frostbite seemed horrified.

"Yeah." Memories of coming back to life once again flashed across his vision.

"I have heard of such places," the Yeti mentioned after some of his people ran a few scans. Jason had been allowed to replace his shirt. "They are pools of ectoplasm that form in areas where areas of the Infinite Realms leak into your world. But they are easily corrupted. I take it there are times where your thoughts and emotions become overwhelming?"

"You could say that."

Frostbite nodded as one of his assistants handed him what appeared to be a printout. "While I am unsure how your unique situation caused this, I can see there was a permanent bonding between you and the ectoplasm from those waters. However, the corruption of it could cause what I could only imagine to be a type of obsessive madness in humans. Something similar can occur in ghosts if the ectoplasm circulating in their bodies becomes infected or poisoned."

"I'm following so far." The explanation made sense. Danny had mentioned exposure to ectoplasm could cause enhance emotions and cause obsessive thoughts. While it felt nice to have some proof his thoughts had been affected, he knew most of the havoc he caused couldn't be blamed solely on that. "But why am I suddenly more ghostly?"

"I believe the corrupted ectoplasm in your system is slowly being filtered out by the clean ambient ectoplasm in Amity. This is the first time since..." the yeti frowned as he struggled with a word, "Ah... waking up, you've been around so much ectoplasm?"

"You can say 'revived', 'returned from the dead', 'rose again', whatever the hell you want." He hated when people tried to dance around the topic. Sure, he was stingy about certain details, but he wasn't afraid to say he died and came back. "But, I don't think I have."

Frostbite nodded. "For us ghosts, and those in between, like the Great One, being around ectoplasmic rich environments helps strengthen us. You can think of it like..." He frowned for a moment.

"Maybe like how we get nutrients from food?" Dick supplied as he rubbed his stomach.

That reminded him. They needed to get more of those Nasty Burgers before they left town, preferably without Bruce. Who ate burgers with a fork and knife? He guessed that was the one downside of being completely raised by Alfred. He needed to push those thoughts aside for now.

The yeti nodded. "Yes, like that. Being away from places like this can weaken ghosts. The Great One is able to supplement with human food and isn't affected as severely."

"Wait, wait, wait! You're saying I could have trouble if I leave Amity for long periods?" Danny almost sounded panicked.

"It's a possibility."

"Why didn't this get brought up before?"

Frostbite almost seemed puzzled. "You never asked of it before."

Danny smacked his face. "Of course that's why."

He partially tuned out Danny as he tried to piece together what Frostbite was getting at. "So, because I'm around more ectoplasm than usual, it's accumulating?" he slowly asked.

"Yes!" the yeti replied with a clap. "As a result, you're experiencing surges as your body grow accustomed to it."

"Like what happened shortly after my accident?" When the attention turned to him, a greenish tinge came to Danny's face. Was he blushing? "I fell through things a lot in that first month."

"Is this going to be permanent?" To Jason, that was the more pressing manner.

"Probably not, but it is a possibility." Not liking that answer, Jason pressed the ghost for more information. "The way you are now, you should begin to return to your normal once you leave the area."

"The way I am now?"

"Yes, our scans show that you haven't formed a core which you can think of as a ghostly heart. As long as that doesn't form, your situation will improve. And with that corrupted ectoplasm being cleared from your body, it should help make any obsessions or intense emotions easier to control. However, I would recommend having a strong support system with you. Even among ghosts where our emotions and obsessions literally give us our afterlife, having those we trust around us helps prevent us from losing ourselves to it. Having been in contact with so much corrupted ectoplasm, I can't imagine how intense those could have been."

Jason nodded once. That also made sense. Having Roy and Kori in his life and slowly reconnecting with his family helped him bring back a clarity he hadn't had since prior to his death. But, there was one thing about what Frostbite said unsettled him. "How or why would a core form? Would I be like Glowstick here if that happened?"

Frostbite frowned again. "I am unsure. The Great One and Plasmius are the only two halfas we have encountered in the last several centuries. The ones that were whispered about in the past have long since left your world and ours and did not leave any clues about how they came to be. We do know that intense and sudden ectoplasmic exposure created both the Great One's and Plasmius', but as you are already in a somewhat in between state, even being in this realm for too long could start that formation."

That presented an interesting dilemma. Could he eventually become an entity like Danny? Just think of what he could do with those powers! It would be so easy for him to slip into Arkham and finally end the Joker's reign of terror. By why stop at Joker? He could go after so many other mass murdering shitbags.

No, he needed to stop that train of thought. He wasn't a good enough person to be able to handle responsibility like that. It would be too much power, too much temptation. He was activity trying to redeem himself, and he would lose everything he gained if he let himself side like that.

"Hood?" Dick's voice and hesitant hand on his shoulder brought him out of his thoughts.
"I'm good." He turned to Frostbite as he pulled his borrowed coat on. "Thanks for all your help, but I don't think you want someone like me joining those ranks. Let's head back."

Danny didn't speak after they boarded the Specter Speeder again. He worked in silence as he maneuvered the vehicle back into what seemed to be the Ghost Zone's equivalent of the air before heading back towards the Portal. His motions almost seemed mechanical suggesting he might be upset about something.

Dick silently suggested that he say something to help. Like what? He wasn't exactly sure why the kid was upset. Could it be because there weren't many people like Danny? He had openly mentioned he was curious if Jason was someone like him.

"Are you mad that I don't want to share your situation?"
Danny didn't answer him. Instead, his hands tightened on the controls. At least he figured out what was bothering him.
Jason sighed and leaned against the wall. "Danny, I'm not a good person. Giving me that type of power would only end badly, for everyone. You don't need someone like me ruining your reputation by proxy."

"You should give yourself more credit."
Did Dick really just say that to him? "Did you hit your head or something? You and Arsenal are the ones who like to remind me about the eight heads I had in a duffel bag when I began strong arming Black Mask. I also tried, repeatedly, to maim you and the others." Maim was just a polite way of dancing around the fact he had tried killing is brothers. "You kicked me off a train because of that."

"I tried to help you, and I said I was sorry!"
"Why? I was trying to kill you."
"I'm sorry, what?" Danny finally spoke. His eyes danced back and forth between him and Dick. He eventually pointed at Dick. "You kicked your brother off a train, and you," he turned towards Jason, "had heads in a duffle bag? What the hell?"
He just shrugged. "I needed to get the attention of some crime lords, and it made sense at the time."

Notes:

In the newer comics, Jason has a domino mask and something to cover his mouth that's often described by fans as a muzzle as opposed to his tradition helmet. No idea why the change other than it's probably easier to carry around than a helmet. I actually really like the new look.

Mentioned in the Under the Red Hood comic, Alfred has a collection of first edition novels and had a yearly book exchange which was not commonly known.

In the comics, the Lazarus Pits contain a chemical called Dionesium which is what gives it the restorative properties. However, impure Dionesium can cause the Pit Madness. In the Arrowverse, they say the Pit contains traces of the souls which have bathed in them which contributes to that madness. Both make sense... I personally like the soul concept better, but both explanations work fine in the context of this fic.

Bruce eats burgers with a fork and knife when in public as Bruce. That has been shown in the comics. And yes, Dick did kick Jason off a train during the events of "Battle for the Cowl".

Chapter 6 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/87992305>): Chances are that you might find that we share a common discomfort now

Notes:

Possible needed warning? Talks surrounding death, dark humor related to death, self-depreciating thoughts throughout the work, and canon-typical violence.

Still puzzled over the appearance of a wild chapter. I've realized that I write Jason like he's one of my cousins... I'm not sure what that says about my family.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_6_endnotes\)](#).)
As they neared the entrance to the Portal, Danny received an update from Jazz. Apparently, someone tipped off the G.I.W. that something was happening at Masters' mansion. As a result, their parents had gone to investigate which meant it was safe for them to return to the lab.
However, there was a different problem. Cass and Duke were supposed to be at the manor. Did Masters call that group in retaliation? Or was it just a fluke? Thankfully, those two didn't show up on any scanners like he did.

Still, it was better to get a report. Dick appeared to already be trying to reach the others with his communicator, but there seemed to be an issue. Frowning, he called out repeatedly, but there didn't seem to be a response.

Danny noticed the trouble. "You're not going to have much luck until we get out of here. The ectoplasm causes a lot of interference with normal items. We have specially made communicators for this place." He tapped at the piece of equipment in his ear.

"Oh..." Dick sent him a look. Bruce was going to be pissed. At least, they hadn't caused an explosion, this time. That had to count for something. It also brought a question as to how well their masks recorded video of that place. That might work in his favor, at least to hide his scar. He'd forgotten about it in the heat of the moment.

About ten minutes later, Danny maneuvered the Speeder through the Portal and brought it to a gentle stop in the basement. Glad to be out of the world of the dead and away from the unsettling feeling it gave him, Jason exited the craft and stretched.

"Thanks for doing that, Danny." He turned to watch rings of light wash over the kid, returning him to his human form. "So that's how that works. Neat."

"I think 'neat' is an understatement." Dick appeared behind Danny and began working with the communicator again. He winced which meant it was back online and someone knew. Excusing himself, he began a quick explanation as to what happened.

"Will... uh... Nightwing be okay?" Jazz questioned after quickly checking Danny for any injuries. She had been waiting patiently for them. When her brother batted her away, she gave him a warm sisterly smile.

"Yeah, just job stuff. Losing touch with the others doesn't usually go over well." Jason gestured to one of the computers. "You mentioned something about Masters?"

"Yeah, come upstairs. It's all over the news."

After getting Dick's attention and gesturing to where he was going, he followed Jazz and a still reserved Danny into the kitchen. A small TV set on the counter showed a man, who introduced himself as the weatherman, reporting a standoff between Masters and several heavily armed men in white suits. The Fenton parents stood behind Vlad, apparently supporting him.

"I'm surprised they haven't blasted a hole in place yet," Danny murmured darkly. "Do you know what set them off this time?"

"According to the news, someone called in an anonymous tip about a ghost attack. But Vlad stated he didn't receive any warnings from his security until the Guys In White showed up."

"And because it's the Guys in White, they don't want to back down until they've had a chance to destroy... excuse me, search the place."

"Yep. I got a text from Sam stating her parents are about to mobilize. They can't tolerate those idiots being anywhere near their home, especially when there is a high society event happening tonight. She said you and Tucker can stop by to watch, just bring the popcorn."

A weak chuckle escaped Danny as he took a seat at the table. "Her parents really are a force of nature."

"So, I have good and bad news." Both Fenton kids jumped when Dick spoke. The fact he managed to sneak up on a ghost wasn't lost on him as he gave a mischievous grin.

"Let me guess. Signal and Orphan are safely out, but B has his pants in a bunch because we went offline."

"You get half credit."

"Oh? Enlighten me."

"Yeah, B's not happy with us, but he's more irritated that Masters dropped hints that he's aware we're looking into him. He also asked about you a couple times."

"Weird." After his death, his name became taboo during meetings with Bruce. That continued even after his slow reemergence into society. Now a days, it seemed most folk of high society understood he had been traumatized by something and resigned themselves to gossip instead of directly asking. "Wonder if he knows..." He gestured to himself.

"It's hard to say. Vlad doesn't seem to be as sensitive as I am to other ghosts, but if he suspects something, he might try recruiting you too," Danny mentioned as he stared at his hands.

"Why?"

"Vlad spent twenty years alone," Jazz hesitantly spoke up when Danny didn't immediately answer. "He sees Danny like a kindred spirit and covets him... well, at least the idea of him. We're not sure if he really wants a son or just someone he can completely dominate."

Dick shared a look with him. "And maybe he thinks Hood would be another potential target?"

"Yeah... It's..." Danny took a deep breath before continuing. He still wouldn't look up at them. "It's hard, you know? Both me and Vlad are stuck between two worlds, and it's hard to say if we really belong to either of them anymore. It's lonely. But..." he fiddled with his fingers, "Vlad's become obsessive about it."

"And because of the ghostly status, it's gotten warped, right?" When Danny nodded, Jason did his best to ignore the look he could feel Dick giving him. Loneliness could destroy a person without them being contaminated with ectoplasm. With it possibly warping it, it was unsettling to picture that happening to another person. Sure, he now knew that's what happened to him, but he was blinded by the green haze of living through it. "And since I'm an unknown, I'm currently an easier target to him." He grimaced. "I guess I'll have to wear that stupid belt at the fundraiser."

That statement caused Danny to perk up a bit. "I thought it shocked you too?"

"It did. Red Robin tinkered with it enough that it now feels more like using a jackhammer than getting tased. The goal is to make sure it won't hurt you either, but we'll find out how far he got later tonight."

"Speaking of which, we should probably go meet up with the others." Dick tapped his ear twice to let him know that the old man wanted them back immediately.

"Before you go," Jazz spoke slowly as her eyes moved between all three heroes. Her furrowed brows suggested that she knew she was missing part of the conversation, "I think you might want a few things from our weapons' vault."

“That’s a good idea,” Danny agreed as he stood up and walked across the kitchen. His motions quickly became more animated even if he made no sound as he moved. “Mom and Dad only showed you what they currently sell.”

“Won’t your parents notice anything’s missing?” Jason had no qualms with getting new weaponry for free, but this didn’t quite feel right.

Jazz patted him on the arm as she followed her brother. “They won’t notice. They end up making so much over the years that it just gets stored away and never thought about again. Most of what Danny uses has been taken from the vault and adjusted by either one of us or one of his friends.”

Surprised Dick didn’t object, Jason followed the Fenton siblings from the room. Free weapons were free weapons after all.

After making sure they were both street ready, Jason and Dick made his way back to the others. Canvas bags full of a few new Fenton tech were carried on their backs.

Jack and Maddie really did a lot make a lot of weaponry. After seeing the sheer number of prototypes, Jason really questioned whether or not they were actually paranormal eradicators masquerading as paranormal researchers. Most of what they created were designed to seriously harm or even destroy a ghost. It was unsettling to watch how Danny didn’t change expression as he explained the effects.

One particular gun could even make miniature portals. The fact it even existed was a scientific marvel, but because there was a battery power issue, it had been cast aside for a new product like many others.

Knowing Jason preferred guns, Danny handed him a few rifle and pistol-styled blasters. While they were lighter than what he was used to, their size and shape felt comfortable. They also had the added bonus that their very presence would annoy Bruce.

Danny also packed a few staff-like weapons for Dick and Tim. One of which could even become like a three-sectioned staff which Duke might like. There was even something akin to a sword for Damian. From what he knew, Cass didn’t have a preferred weapon like him and the others, but there was still enough variation that she might find something she liked. Overall, it was a good haul.

But it wasn’t good enough of a haul to wipe off the angry scowl off Bruce’s face when they arrived back in the hotel. Jason just rolled his eyes as he put down his bag of goodies and began sorting through it. He’d prefer to get familiarized with them while he still had some time. Better to know the weapon and its faults beforehand instead of finding out on the fly.

Bruce hovered near his shoulder while he worked. There was a sense of disapproval radiating from the man, but he didn’t say anything. So, to get the man to back off, Jason decided to explain what they were. Only some of Bruce’s disappointment waned.

However, he and the others couldn’t keep away from the new toys for long, especially after Dick unveiled what he had. Damian especially seemed intrigued. That wasn’t too surprising considering the two did have a shared interest in weapons. One of the last times they worked together, he and the twerp did spend some time quality bonding over whether a very nice set of axes would be inappropriate for a mission.

While they decided who took what, Tim and Duke pestered for information regarding what happened with Danny. Babs chimed in from her side and, surprisingly, so did Stephanie. She had a few hours to spare and decided she wanted to watch the circus.

After a quick check, they found that their audio from their trip into the Ghost Zone had been corrupted beyond repair, but the video, while hazy, was mostly intact. Lovely. He wanted that scar to stay a secret.

Dick graciously decided he would explain what couldn’t be heard, but he wanted to know what they had missed before he got into it. According to Bruce, Masters mostly tested the waters regarding business during lunch, but it was his interest in Jason which bristled Bruce. He played it off well, but the man seemed almost hungry for information on the most ‘secretive of the Waynes.’ Tim ended the summary by giving some highlights of Masters trying not to be driven insane by Damian and sharing a video file of the very satisfying way Bruce’s Specter Deflector shocked Vlad when they shook hands.

Duke and Cass were able to get out of Masters’ home just prior to the G.I.W. showing up on the premises. They hadn’t seen evidence of anyone else in the building at the time so the timing of it couldn’t be ruled out as a fluke or purposeful. But they didn’t find evidence of any other person coming or going in that house other than Vlad. It raised some interesting questions as to who maintained the property.

However, they were able to make it down into his lab. Jason examined the stills from his siblings’ gear. The lab held similarities to the Fentons’ regarding the set up and equipment. However, it was larger and almost immaculate. The files the two were able to pull were similar to what Babs already found, but it confirmed Vlad rarely strayed into the tinkering aspects of paranormal science. Instead, he meticulously researched whatever interested him, and that delved into dark corners that none of them expected.

There were records of cloning attempts and how drastically they failed. Those were images Jason never needed to see again. There were also thousands of documents regarding possible ways to subdue and control Danny. With how obsessive the man seemed, it was a surprise he seemed to be reluctant to act. Perhaps that was part of how the ectoplasm affected him which could act in their favor, if he decided to pull something.

Masters also had several files dedicated to known villains, heroes, and neutrals. Most of it tracked alliances, but also meticulously weighed the pros and cons of being involved with them. Notes were made regarding technology or wealth particularly of interest.

Then it was time for Dick to take the stage. He explained what happened with the Fentons and how they traveled to the Ghost Zone while the video feed played on Tim’s laptop. The others openly wondered at the strangeness of the place.

However, that wonder was replaced with horror as they got to the section with Frostbite and the tests. Why couldn’t that part of the video get corrupted? Now Tim and Duke were looking at him with the same pity Dick did. Damian tried to remain neutral, but

his eyes had widened, and his jaw had slackened some. A muscle moved in Bruce's jaw, but his overall expression was blank. While Babs and Stephanie were silent on their end, he could still sense their shock.

Cass, however, hugged him from behind. She didn't say anything, but the gentle squeeze she gave him let him know she understood. While he still didn't know what to make of the former assassin at times, she had more emotional intelligence than the rest of them. It made a difference at times like this.

After gently shooing her away, he berated the rest of them. "If you forgot, we have a job to do. Stop with the fucking pity party."

With that said, Dick continued but soon turned the stage over to Jason so he could make the determination of what to say regarding Frostbite's explanation. In true fashion, he gave only as much information as believed to be relevant to the situation. In this case, that consisted of letting them know he'd stop falling through things when he left Amity. To avoid others' annoying looks, Jason kept his eyes on the new weaponry the entire time.

"You're certain this situation won't become permanent?" A hard edge crept into Bruce's tone. The man had a funny way of showing concern.

"It was phrased as unlikely," Jason set the blaster in his hand down and turned on the chair so he could look Bruce in the eyes. "Best I can tell, as long as I don't get thrown into a malfunctioning Ghost Portal or back into the Pit, things will go back to normal." Well, back to his normal minus some Pit madness.

Bruce didn't need to know that. Having the old man still think his thoughts were clouded at times by the Pit could work in his favor. But there was the lingering issue of whether or not Dick would bring it up. Secrets like that could be used as leverage, and even Dick was known to use information best left alone to call in the occasional favor. Jason would check later. A bribe might be needed.

"Enough worrying about me." He did his best to ignore the fact his hand vanished from sight as he waved it dismissively. Bruce narrowed his eyes but didn't say anything.

"It would be amazing if I could find a way to replicate this. I'm surprised I can still feel your hand," Tim murmured as he took the chance to examine the situation close up. He smelled so strongly of coffee, for a moment, Jason wondered if he took a bath in the stuff.

Duke hummed as he also stepped closer. "I can still kind of see it."

Pulling away from his brother, Jason experimentally opened and closed his still invisible hand before hesitantly checking to see whether it would pass through the table. No intangibility this time. An unpleasant image getting accidentally stuck in the wall or floor flashed across his mind, and he briefly wondered if that ever happened to Danny. "Yeah, definitely solid. Just feels a bit chilled."

"Maybe a ghost needs to be both invisible and, what did you say Danny called it? Intangible? For me not to be able to detect it? Or maybe I can see it because you're not a ghost."

"No idea." Jason glanced over his shoulder. "Dick, while I work on handling this, bring the others up to speed about what Danny said about Vlad."

"Thought puns were my thing?" Dick's grin made Jason want to throw one of the ecto-pistols at him.

"Are you admitting I was funnier on accident than you are when you try?"

Bruce stepped between them when Dick went to retort. "What's this about Masters?"

After the summary, Bruce openly frowned as he rubbed his chin. For a man who mostly spoke in varying degrees of scowling, this was unusual. Or maybe he was just bothered that someone wanted to try to take away one of his soldiers again.

"The Justice League has spent a great deal of time debating Masters' motivations and whether or not we should consider him as another Luthor. Other than business deals which primarily focused on building his personal wealth, we had no reports of him doing anything overtly criminal. If his main focus has been simply to build up a way to obtain and keep what he covets, then it explains why he hasn't been too interested in approaching other parties."

"We can probably figure he killed those assassins for the same reason." Tim had lost interest with Jason, who finally managed to get his hand back into the visible spectrum, and turned his attention back to the Spector Deflectors. "If he doesn't want anyone else to know about this town, the Fentons, or his status, then it would make sense he'd take out anyone he considered a threat to that. Bet he knows our primary focus was Ra's men which is why we were only warned."

"You're calling a horde of ghost animals a warning?" Duke's eyebrows shot up comically.

Damian tutted. "Have you not learned anything, Thomas? Such tactics are common of the rogues in Gotham."

"Yeah, but those don't normally involve rabid undead animals."

"Would Scarecrow's fear toxin count?" Dick asked as he crossed his arms and leaned against the nearest wall. It was enough of a valid question to start a debate that would look like an argument to any onlooker.

A long-suffering sigh escaped Bruce. "Enough. We need to begin preparations for tonight. While it seems unlikely we'll encounter any immediate threat from the League, we should remain on guard. There is a chance for retaliation against Masters."

"How likely do we think Ra's knows that Masters is a ghost?" Dick tumbled across the room so he could steal one of the plush chairs. "If we could barely find any evidence of what he was, I doubt that he would."

"Perhaps Grandfather knows of Plasmus but believes he is simply working with Masters," Damian suggested.

"That could be," Bruce agreed. "If that's the case, if there is a retaliation, it might be a more public attack. They'd use the crowd to make it less likely Plasmus would interfere."

"Even though that wouldn't help them," Jason added. "Remember, Danny mentioned Masters can make multiple copies of himself. If they do try anything, it's just going to backfire on them. What the? Damn it!" As a brief moment of intangibility in his legs nearly caused him to fall off his chair, a nasty thought resurfaced.

Ignoring the laughter on the com from Stephanie, Jason continued to entertain that thought. "Is it possible... What if there have been others who tried to investigate here, and Masters just..." He stared at his hands. "Just pulled them into the ground and left them there."

Stunned silence filled the room. "We don't have many reports of people disappearing around Masters," Bruce replied slowly as he grabbed his computer and began typing. "But there have been a few, and there hasn't been any physical evidence of it. I'd like to confirm it myself... but, that may have to wait." He grabbed his Justice League communicator and stepped into the other room.

"Wanna bet he's asking Supes for a favor?"

Jason rolled his eyes at Dick. "Seeing as he's one of the few people we know with x-ray vision, that's a pretty good guess."

"I don't think I'll ever get used to hearing you guys talk about the big guy like that." With how new he was, Duke still got starstruck around the other capes. In all honesty, Jason wasn't sure how many of the others Duke met yet.

That reminded him; Superman once signed a piece of metal for him. Was that still at the cave? When he had time, he should go see if he could find it.

"Jason, you might be on to something," Babs interrupted from her side. "Our contacts have given us a few reports of missing henchmen around Amity. I have enough info on some of them that I should be able to find them no matter where they are, but I can't. They're just gone."

"Oh, it looks like one of them might have a tale for us. Can't wait to hear this. Hopefully, it'll be more entertaining than the usual blathering." That was Stephanie's way of excusing herself.

He rubbed his face as he and the others waited for Bruce and Stephanie's results. This train of thought was something he didn't want to have. Masters could possibly just stick someone in concrete or the ground, possibly while they were still alive, and just forget about them! What would that do to someone? Would it be an instant death? Or would they slowly suffocate?

God, he might be able to do the same to someone if this situation of his continued. That was the last thing someone afflicted Pit Madness should have access to.

When he next saw Danny, he was going to have to break down and ask the kid to keep an eye on him. While he didn't have too many lines he wouldn't cross, this was one of them.

Bruce stepped back into the room. "Clark was able to quickly travel to three of locations of interest. He confirmed the presence of bodies in the concrete of certain buildings. He's currently notifying the authorities." He glanced at Jason before continuing. "We're going to air on the side of caution and assume ghosts can possess any living creature. We also do not know how far above the city ghosts can safely travel. Any confirmation in this location will have to be made by one of us."

A Kryptonian being controlled by a normal villain was terrifying enough. They really didn't need one controlled by a ghost.

"I shouldn't be surprised Todd of all people considered such an uncouth manner of burial."

Jason ignored the dig from the demon spawn. Yeah, he did kind of earn his reputation, but did they really think he'd pull something like that? Even if Vlad killed them first and then placed them in the ground, being forgotten was just as unsettling.

"Actually, how did you come up with that?" He was surprised Duke had the nerve to ask.

"Wondered if it was possible to get stuck in something if intangibility wore off."

Surprise fluttered across the room. "I guess that would be something you have to worry about." Pity crept back into Dick's voice.

"So guys, I have a story for you!" Stephanie's chipper voice returned to the comms.

Notes:

Did you know an AK-47 is heavier than a longsword? Longswords tend to be 2-4lbs (1-2kg). AKs start around 6.5lbs. Adding wooden 'furniture' to the butt stock and heatshields can make it closer to 10lbs. Dunno if I should add this, but I will anyways. The great majority of civilian AKs in the US are semi-auto only which is due to legality/specific licensing. The only way to get somewhat close to a full-auto with the average civilian AK is to use a bumpstock - those are illegal, btw.

The metal on the barrel can get hot enough to cook bacon after a while... and getting hit by an ejected bullet casing that came in contact with that hot barrel can burn you. If you are using one and putting 100+ rounds through it, it should be allowed to cool down before being stored. Also trying to aim with iron sights when you have scarring on your dominate eye is a pain. (I will not confirm or deny whether or not I was doing in person research over the weekend)

Comic related - there is scene where you see Jason and Damian in the background examining an ax while Tim is explaining something to everyone else.

Bruce does canonically refer to the batfam as his soldiers at times. Heck, it's even on Jason's memorial in the cave - "A good soldier." And the mentality behind that and how it affects a child/teen is something that bothers Jason post-resurrection.

I don't know where it's mentioned in the comics, but I do have a Superman encyclopedia that mentions that Supes gave Jason that autograph. Edit: I did find the panel, but I still don't know which issue it's from.

As a side note, I have a preference for unintentional puns which did happen in this instance. I caught it, made a face, and decided to roll with it.

Chapter 7 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/88829341>): Save Me from the Ghosts and Shadows

Notes:

Possible needed warning? Talks surrounding death, dark humor related to death, self-deprecating thoughts throughout the work, and canon-typical violence.

This party scene shouldn't have been so hard to write, but it was.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_7_endnotes\).](#))

“So get this, our old buddy Bill got loaned out to Intergang a few months ago,” Stephanie began. “Best he can tell, they wanted to get a feel for how easy it would be to obtain ecto-weaponry and how it could be modified. However, they lost several men in previous attempts.”

“Let me guess,” Tim set aside one of the belts and began prying open the electronics on another one, “they wanted help that was more disposable.”

“You got it! Well, apparently Amity’s considered to be the Bermuda Triangle of cities in the criminal underworld. Most low levels are afraid of the place since there have been way too many stories of them vanishing after jobs in the area. Bill said if it wasn’t for the threat of being shot on the spot, he would have refused.”

Bill was one of the regular thugs in Gotham. He’d been around so long all of them knew him by sight, but he rarely stayed with one organization for too long. It was almost a rite of passage the first time one of them knocked him out during a mission.

“Anyways, once they got there, they barely had a chance to set up camp before things started happening.” She paused as she attempted to increase the drama of her retelling. “Someone heard something and raised the alarm. Before anyone had a chance to act any further, Bill says he saw someone vanish into the ground. He said it looked like he just fell into it, but there was no hole in the floor. There were no marks suggesting the guy had even been standing there.”

“A few people started firing guns, making the others run for cover. Others vanished in the confusion. Bill grabbed the talisman he managed to get from an acquaintance prior to coming to Amity. He didn’t know much about it other than it was believed to have been blessed or something by someone who practices the occult.” Stephanie huffed in irritation for a moment before continuing. “Normally I’d say old Bill lost it, but he’s absolutely convinced the thing saved his life.”

“Constantine and Zantana have both mentioned and used mystical artifacts in their line of work,” Bruce explained as a way of saying it was possible. “However, it seems unlikely any such object found its way into the ranks of low-level criminals.”

“Right? Well, Bill said something tried to grab him but shrieked in pain when it touched him. Said a ghost manifested in front of him and snarled. It then blasted him with something pinkish. He’s not too sure what happened after that, but he did come back to consciousness, he found himself alone. He couldn’t find evidence of the scuffle or what happened to the others. Spooked, he fled back to Gotham, reported what he knew to Intergang, and swore off stepping into Amity ever again.”

“Did he give you any description of what he saw?”

“No, not really. Just said he fought a ‘blue-skinned ghost’ dressed in white. Sounds cliché, but Bill’s terrified of whatever it was.”

Damian tutted as he shifted positions on the chair he was using. “His story comes across as fallacious.”

“With how long Bill’s been around, he doesn’t tend to get shaken up too often. I’m liable to believe him,” Tim murmured as he looked up from his work.

“Agreed. He possibly encountered Plasmus or one of his duplicates.” Bruce grabbed one of the completed belts. “Barbara, send me the coordinates of that building. Duke, you’re coming with me. We’ll make a quick verification trip.”

“I take it you want us to continue things here?” Jason had no idea why Dick would even ask. All of them knew they roles at this point.

“I’d also recommend getting ready. We do have a fundraiser to attend.”

Jason stared at himself in the mirror as he got ready. Was it just him, or did the white streak in his hair seem to be glowing? Pulling the tuft of hair down for a closer look, he found there did seem to be an unnatural silvery sheen to it. Had it been like this all day? Or was this one of those things that would come and go?

It wasn’t like he could dye it. He knew; he’d tried, repeatedly. So, he did the only thing he knew could possibly work, he begrudgingly asked Dick for advice and then immediately regretted it.

Dick ushered him into the bathroom with the others crowding into it just so they could see what happened when the lights were turned off. In the darkness, the tuft gave off a soft white glow, and of course, everyone had to try to touch it. So, he ended up elbowing a few people until Bruce, who must have just returned with Duke, heard the commotion, opened the door, and turned the lights on.

The man who spent so much time terrorizing the criminals of Gotham took one look at the scene before pinching the bridge of his nose and exhaling. It was nice to know, in a messed-up sort of way, that there was nothing he could do to stop their own sort of insanity.

Dick gave a pleasant chuckle as he manifested a jar of hair gel. Apparently, it was some weird high-end product. Jason wrinkled his nose at its unpleasant smell as his brother applied the stuff and teased his hair. Whatever it was, it gave his black locks a sheen which not only complimented the troublesome white streak but also helped mask the glow.

Once free of his brother, Jason made his way into the common area of the hotel room to tie his tie and work on figuring out which Fenton-tech he could hide on him.

While he worked, Duke quickly explained that Bill’s tip was correct, and the local cops had been provided an anonymous tip. He also tried and failed to not stare at the white streak.

“Apparently an aftereffect of being permanently bonded with ectoplasm is to glow.” He tried to keep his voice even, but the irritation still crept into it. The sooner he got back to Gotham, the better. Maybe then they’d leave him alone.

“Looks nice.” Cass, now in a flattering plum-colored dress, surprised him as she approached and reached out a hand to touch his hair. Nope, he wasn’t going to allow that to start again. He wasn’t keen on sitting through another styling.

Bruce almost smiled at them as he fixed one of his cufflinks, but a more neutral expression quickly replaced it. “How is the Fenton home life?” Oh yeah, that hadn’t been mentioned in the excitement of everything else.

“They have a better homelife than I did, but that’s not really that hard of an accomplishment,” he explained while crossing his arms. The Fenton home situation was a murky gray. “Maddie and Jack don’t seem to be purposely neglectful, but their willingness to drop everything and leave their kids alone at any sign of ghostly activity is worrisome. I also don’t know how willingly they’d accept the truth of Danny’s situation. Me and Duke got to see up close and personal how they reacted to Phantom, and a few of the descriptions he gave us about what some of the Fenton tech could do to a ghost made my skin crawl. It’s no wonder why he’s more willing to open up to a stranger.” After a moment of deliberation, he added, “Oh, and there was something that suspiciously looked like an Iron Maiden tucked in a corner of the lab.”

“I’m sorry, there’s what?” Duke, who had moved to a chair as they talked, went slack jawed.

“Danny said it was called the Fenton Stockades.”

“It.. wasn’t used?” Cass’ searched his face for a confirmation it wasn’t. She knew better than the rest of them how the threat and implementation of harm could be used to control children. Her mother had gone so far as to have her vocal cords damaged to prevent her from speaking.

“Doubt it. I’m absolutely positive Jazz would have called CPS herself if her parents tried that.”

“Jazz does appear to be exceptionally adjusted despite the eccentricities of her parents.” Jason raised an eyebrow at Bruce. Did he miss the irony of calling someone else eccentric? The man dressed as a giant bat to terrorize criminals.

He really shouldn’t say anything as he wore the Robin costume for a time, but those colors were originally implemented as an homage to Dick’s family. Bruce actively dressed as a thing he had a phobia of. Yeah, if that wasn’t eccentric, he didn’t know what was.

“I doubt you want my opinion on the matter, but don’t try to pull Danny away from his family,” he warned Bruce. “He’s already dealing with a maniac who wants him for a son, so offering to mentor him might backfire.”

“I’ll keep that in mind.” Bruce turned his attention back towards the bedroom. “Are the rest of you ready?”

Dick momentarily popped into view. “Almost.” A minutes later, he gently herded and obviously annoyed Damian into the room. Tim, who had the Specter Deflectors draped over his shoulders, closely followed.

“Alfred would like a family picture before we leave and predictably ruin our suits,” Dick explained as he fiddled with his phone. Jason didn’t doubt the butler said something along those lines. “We just need one.”

One photo took nearly ten minutes to get, but this time, the only injuries were a couple new bruises. In their family, that was a win. Alfred would be proud.

Although Jason would never openly admit it, he was impressed with how much work Tim put into fixing the Deflectors. It was still uncomfortable to wear, but at least it was more pins and needles as opposed to jackhammer vibrations. There was also the possibility that it would help keep any ghostly slipups in check. Danny did mention electricity disrupted a ghost’s abilities.

Speaking of electricity, a storm rolled into the area shortly before they left. While the rain hadn’t started, the rumble of thunder could be heard in the distance. As they traveled to the fundraiser in the limo Masters sent for them, flickers of blue and green flames could be seen around some of the buildings. St. Elmo’s fire maybe? At sea, the phenomenon was considered good luck, but when seen inland, it usually foretold bad times ahead. From what he’d seen of Amity so far, he’d take the warning.

The rain started as they reached the mansion. Even with the gloomy atmosphere, the white, gold, and green building was still tacky. Most sports fans just decorated one or two rooms with their team colors, but the man was so obsessed with the Green Bay Packers that he reportedly chose their colors for most of his properties.

Although somewhat muted from the effects of the belt, the Pit angrily churned as the doorman greeted them. At first, he couldn’t figure out why. The man seemed normal enough even if he’d probably been hired just for the fundraiser, but as they passed him, Jason noted an odd glow and a bluish tint to the man’s skin. Looking at the others, only Duke seemed to realize something was off. It was a ghost. Masters hired a ghost to greet people at the door? What the hell? A quick gesture to the others brought them up to speed.

Once they arrived in the ballroom, Masters greeted them. Jason didn’t miss how he purposely avoided touching any of them. Although he was nonchalant about it, he must decided to err on the side of caution. Being shocked in front of a crowd of people did make it difficult to keep ones cover after all.

After a few introductions and some photos from the press, Jason and the others slowly dispersed through the crowd. The room itself was unremarkable, which set Jason on edge. Most rooms used for such large gatherings were designed to flaunt wealth, but the walls were mostly bare stone with a couple paintings and banners. If it wasn’t for the large windows and the curtains, he’d say the room was designed to be part of a prison or asylum than for entertaining guests.

It took a few minutes, but Jason eventually found Danny in one of the corners, speaking with his friend Sam. The Pit whispered the familiar greeting as he approached, and Danny seemed to sense him in return as he gave a quick wave. With how tensed his shoulders were, it appeared he was expecting something to happen.

“Where’s everyone else?” Danny questioned when he got within earshot.

“Around. It’s pretty common for us to get in trouble at these sorts of things, so keeping us close together is often a bad idea.” He shrugged as he put his hands in his pockets. While it was true he really hadn’t contributed to the mayhem over the years, he’d heard some of what his siblings had pulled. Maybe he should conspire with Dick and the demon brat this time, just to get under Masters’ skin.

“Maybe I should take some lessons,” Sam muttered, “then maybe my parents will stop making me come to these things.”

Jason chuckled as he scanned the crowd. There weren't a lot of familiar faces. That was odd. Normally at things like this he'd see several familiar faces, good, bad, and neutral. Danny mentioned he thought that Masters might be targeting Bruce. Maybe that was true, at least at first.

"Jason?" He glanced over to see Danny giving him a concerned look. Oops, he had gotten distracted.

"Sorry, what were you saying?"

"Uh, have things been..." he glanced at Sam. Great, he said something to her. Kid needed to better learn how to keep others secrets, "erm... okay since your trip?"

"Couple accidents."

Danny nodded, but his eyes did momentarily flicker towards the white streak. Was it still glowing? "Did your brother fix the belt?"

"Yeah." It felt weird to hear someone else call Tim his brother. Deciding to not acknowledge it anymore than he had to, he lifted the suit jacket just enough for Danny to get a quick look. "Still not the most pleasant thing, but tolerable."

"Maybe we can get him to tell Tucker how he did that," Sam mused. "He's been trying unsuccessfully to alter them for months. Oh great, here they come." Jason followed her line of sight and found two annoyed adults coming their way.

"Sammikins," the woman tried to sound pleasant, but there was an edge to her voice, "please mingle with the crowd. Many of our acquaintances would be happy to meet you." She tried and failed to hide a grimace when she glanced at Jason and Danny. "They would be better company than these rascals."

Jason couldn't help himself and snorted. Even all dressed up, some folk could still tell he was a street kid. Though, it could also be the hair. The white streak was off putting.

The man glared at him. "Do you have something to say to my wife?"

"Mr. and Mrs. Manson, how lovely it is to see you." At the sound of the cultured voice, they turned to see Masters approaching. "I take it you're acquainted with my godson, Daniel." The sour expression they made was picture worthy. "And Jason, it's good to see you again. Forgive me for not being able to properly speak with you and your family when you arrived. I caught a glimpse of a couple of your siblings, but I haven't seen your father since then."

Jason took the outstretched hand. Masters did very well to hide the pain from the belt shocking him. "Sorry, I must be a bit staticky." He kept his voice light but gave a devilish smirk. "Bruce is around somewhere, but he's great at vanishing in a crowd. If you can find Damian, you'll probably find either him or Dick nearby." Someone had to keep the Demon Brat from attempting to stab the party guests.

"I'll keep that in mind." Jason didn't miss how Masters rubbed his sore hand. Or how the man gave him a calculated look.

"You know this scoundrel?" Mrs. Manson demanded.

"Mom, this 'scoundrel' is Jason Todd. You know, one of Bruce Wayne's children." Sam smiled in utter delight at the dawning horror on her parents' faces. It was great to not be recognized as easily as his siblings. Maybe he should come to more upscale parties. Well, maybe two or three a year instead of just one. "He's also friends with Danny."

"You've only been in town for a few short days. When did you have time to meet?" Masters raised an eyebrow as he turned his gaze towards Danny.

"We happened to meet at that burger place you dropped me and my brothers off at the day we arrived." Jason kept his voice casual as he leaned against the wall. He didn't want Masters to get the impression Danny told him anything about Plasmus. "We overheard him and his friends talking about the fundraiser, and Dick decided to interrupt."

Masters' expression relaxed as he entertained the idea. "With how frequently he eats there, that's not surprising."

"Hey, it's either eat fast food or risk being attacked by reanimated food." Danny was too nonchalant talking about reanimated food for his liking. Also, how the hell does someone reanimate food? He must have made a face because Danny added, "My parents like attempting to use alternative energy sources for cooking, namely ectoplasm."

"Remind me to never accept food from your parents." For Jason, that absolutely proved ectoplasm and the waters of the Pit were the same thing. What else could bring food back to life? And he was not going to mention that to Bruce. The man didn't need another reason to consider adopting Danny.

"Forgive us for our rudeness." Sam's mother looked as if she swallowed a lemon. "However, we had been told you had passed away."

"Mom, you can't just ask someone why they aren't dead," Sam deadpanned, making Danny snicker.

"I was caught up in an accident overseas. That part is true," Jason easily explained before gesturing to the white streak. "This is a souvenir from the healing process. I assume you can understand why I've shied away from public events for some time." Taking a page out of Bruce's book, he set his jaw and scowled at the couple to show the conversation was over. The sudden change in his demeanor unsettled them.

Rich people seriously had nothing better to do than to gossip. Sure, he and his family used that gossip train for information, but it always rubbed him the wrong way when they talked about others being injured or killed. There was just a kind of weird pleasure they got from discussing it. When he was on the streets, sure it came up, but there was more of a respect for the injured party, as long as they didn't deserve what happened to them.

"I'm sure you can forgive them for being curious," Masters interrupted with a practiced smile. "Most of the reports have been blown out of proportion."

Jason turned his glare towards the man. Was that just an innocent turn of phrase, or did he do that on purpose?

Sam's parents excused themselves and disappeared into the crowd. They were probably just trying to save face, but they might have been intimidated too. He was told he had that effect on people. No matter the reason, he was glad they were gone. But he still had to deal with Masters.

“Are you interested in getting involved in the business world like your father and brothers?” Masters continued as if he hadn’t said anything wrong. “If you’d like a change in scenery, you’re more than welcome to get some experience with mine for a few months.”

“That’s awfully nice of you.” Jason crossed his arms and looked Masters in the eye. The man’s hungry look morphed back into a neutral expression. “But why me? You aren’t well-known for offering positions to people. Besides, both Dick and Tim, hell, even Damian, are better suited for the business world than I am.”

“What can I say, I’m a bit curious.” Masters shrugged and placed his hands in his pockets. “Besides, I believe you’re selling yourself short. Rumors have persisted for a while that you were able to take most of Roman Sionis’ assets without ever meeting with him.”

Roman Sionis, the Black Mask. How did Masters know about that? That occurred right after he returned to Gotham, and other than the hints he had given Bruce prior to showing himself, he made sure not to let anyone else know he existed. They hadn’t found any information to suggest Masters knew about their family hobby, but it’s possible he made some connections when they came to town. Or, he’d known for a while. That was possible. Tim managed to figure it out when he was like nine, but Tim’s deductive reasoning was off the charts.

“I don’t think I know what you mean,” he replied evenly. “I briefly met the man once when I was younger.”

“Oh, I must be mistaken then.” The smug grin Masters wore confirmed he knew about his status as the Red Hood. “But the offer still stands. I believe I could teach you a great deal of things. But, I should return to greeting my other guests. Ta!” He turned, gave a small wave, and walked back into the crowd.

“Who’s this Roman guy?” Danny gave him a curious look.

“Remember the story about the duffle bag?” He almost laughed at the stunned expression on Danny’s face. “Well, that’s the guy who’s attention I was trying to get.”

While Danny told Sam it wasn’t a good idea to ask, Jason touched his earpiece to get the rest of his family’s attention. “Masters suspects us.”

Bruce’s voice crackled across the connection. The weird interference was back. Was it the storm? Or the high amount of ectoplasm in the air? “You’re sure?”

“He hinted he knew how I targeted Sionis. He didn’t mention anything else.”

“Understood.” After a brief moment of silence, Bruce added, “Any other reports?”

“You mean other than the usual mischief?” The smugness in Dick’s voice made him think he’d already figured out how to get up to the chandeliers.

Bruce gave his second long-suffering sigh for the day. He should know by now that if chaos didn’t come find them that they’d make their own.

“Movement at the windows.”

At Cass’ statement, Jason moved so he could better see the closest window. He didn’t see movement, but there weren’t any trees close enough to be mistaken for a person or persons. They couldn’t currently check outside, but someone else could.

“Danny, hate to ask, but would you be able to check something?” He tried to keep his tone light as to not scare the kid, but Danny saw through him.

“Does this deal with the reason you guys were investigating that warehouse?”

“You can say that. The organization those guys belonged to might want revenge against Plasmius, and might go after Masters to get to him.” He chose his words carefully. Between the possibility of the League attacking, and the Pit’s grumbles that something, possibly a duplicate of Plasmius, was nearby, he wanted to make it seem like he thought Masters and Plasmius weren’t the same person. “Cass, who you’ve only met in passing, noticed something outside.”

“And you’d like me to check.” At his nod, Danny frowned. “You know you could…”

“And I’d likely get stuck. Like you said, there aren’t any instruction manuals for this kind of thing.”

“Oh, right.” The kid’s expression fell. Was he really that desperate to have someone else develop those same powers?

“Remember to stay intangible so you don’t get wet.” Sam sounded tired, as if this sort of thing was a normal occurrence.

Danny gave her a sheepish expression before vanishing from sight.

She must have thought Danny was out of earshot when she glared at Jason. “You better not hurt him.”

Notes:

Bill is a nod to thepandaredd's skits on TikTok

Everyone else might have forgotten about the Fenton Stockades, but Pepperidge Farm remembers

I have a headcanon that due to the ambient ectoplasm in the air, St. Elmo's fire, which is a really neat plasma phenomenon, often occurs before storms in Amity.

The Black Mask was invited to a party at Wayne Manor when Jason was still Robin. At the time, Roman was trying to off Bruce... Is it still canon? Dunno know.

Revealed in Hush and Under the Red Hood (this was ignored in the animated films), Jason had slowly been planting evidence he'd returned to Gotham. That included showing himself to Batman (and grabbing Tim and threatening to kill him), and momentarily fighting him before switching out with Clayface. While Bruce concluded there's no way it could have been Jason, the familiarity of the fighting style unsettled him.

Chapter 8 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/89245540>): Going Under, Hypnotized by Another Puppeteer

Notes:

Possible needed warning? Talks surrounding death, dark humor related to death, self-deprecating thoughts throughout the work, and canon-typical violence.

Quick note: I'm going to try to get the next chapter out before New Year's, but I will be traveling out of state at the end of the year. One of my cousins decided to get married on New Year's in Florida. At least it'll be warm.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_8_endnotes\)](#).)

Sam must have thought Danny was out of earshot when she glared at him. “You better not hurt him.”

Jason raised an eyebrow at the girl. “I’m not sure what you’re implying.”

Although her features didn’t relax, she turned her gaze. “Danny hasn’t said much about you, other than you understand his situation better than anyone else he’s met other than Vlad.” Maybe the kid did have better sense about what to and not to say to people than he thought. “Vlad’s done a lot to harm and manipulate Danny...”

“So I’ve heard.”

“Then you understand why I don’t trust you.” She looked up and met his eyes. Although she tried to hide her unease, her lip quivered.

“To be honest, I wouldn’t trust me either.” Static momentarily filled his communicator. The interference seemed to be getting worse. Bruce wasn’t going to be happy, but then again, when was he ever happy? “But, if it makes you feel better, I don’t want to see Glowstick get hurt either. Kids shouldn’t have to fight an adult’s battle.”

She scoffed and put her hands on her waist. “You clearly don’t know anything. Here, the adults do more harm than good.”

“Didn’t say they had good intentions.” He almost smirked at Sam’s surprised expression, almost. She’d probably find it patronizing, especially coming from him. “Between his parents, Masters, and that joke of a government organization, I can understand why there isn’t a lot of trust. Doesn’t mean it’s right.” Too many kids and teens took on responsibilities beyond them without understanding the consequences of it. He learned that the hard way.

As Sam eyed him suspiciously, the Pit stirred in greeting again. He turned just in time to see Danny materialize.

“It’s kind of creepy you can tell it’s me,” Danny grumbled as he shook some of the water off of him.

“Oh, so it’s not creepy when you can find me?” Teasing the kid felt so natural. Danny stuck his tongue out in response.

“What happened to intangibility?”

Danny gave Sam a sour look as he momentarily became intangible. Water pooled at his feet. He was so comfortable using his powers in a public setting. Didn’t anyone notice? Glancing around, Jason realized no one seemed to pay them any mind. How? Were the people of Amity that jaded by the paranormal? Or was it something about Danny himself?

“Got attacked by some wannabe ninja.” Danny pulled a dart out from one of his pockets and handed it to Jason. “Don’t know how he saw me. I could have sworn I was invisible.”

The dart belonged to the League. Well, at least they had confirmation they were outside. “You show up as an abnormal cold spot on anything that can detect heat,” he absently replied as he tried his communicator. The static had gotten worse.

“Oh, I guess that makes sense, ice core and all.”

Ice core? Were there different types of cores? Frostbite did mention they were like a heart but didn’t mention much else. He should probably ask Danny about it when there wasn’t a threat of assassins.

The com was tried again, and thankfully, this time it worked. He didn’t need Bruce having his panties in a bunch because communications were down.

With confirmation the League was around, orders were given. Everyone else was to suit up and head outside to try to chase off the League members before Plasmius had a chance to kill them. Jason, on the other hand, was to stay near Danny and keep an eye on Masters. He immediately tried to protest. Who else could punch Plasmius if the Fenton tech didn’t work? But Bruce was firm in his decision. The Bat really didn’t trust him not to kill someone.

Grumbling, he fingered one of his hidden guns. Might as well be prepared to shoot when someone inevitably crashed through the window.

“What? Did you get benched or something?”

“The boss and I don’t exactly agree on how to handle situations like this.” Irritation crept into his voice as he leaned against the wall. Could he blame the man? No, not really.

A little voice in the back of his mind suggested maybe Bruce trusted him to keep Danny safe. Where’d that idea come from? It wasn’t like when he was Robin and still naïve, and Bruce trusted him to follow orders, well, mostly follow orders. Even back then, he had a habit of creatively interpreting them.

Deciding he didn’t like his train of thought, he distracted himself by scanning the crowd for Masters. The man seemed to be chatting with one of the guests, but he had himself situated in a way he could easily watch the area where he and Danny stood. The Pit also continued to grumble about something being nearby, but he couldn’t figure out exactly what or where it was.

As he continued to watch the crowd, the Pit’s grumbles became hisses. Something was wrong, and the crowd confirmed it. The babble of conversations vanished, leaving only the sound of music, and, to make it worse, everyone in the crowd stood unsettlingly still. Masters was nowhere to be seen. Not sure what to make of it, Jason pulled out one of his regular guns and one of the Fenton blasters.

As soon as the weapons were out in the open, the crowd turned to look at him. Well, that wasn't creepy. Was this Masters' doing?

"Hey, is there a way you can tell if people are being possessed?" When Danny didn't answer him, Jason stole a quick glance to see the kid gently shaking Sam. Her eyes were unfocused, and she seemed to be unnaturally stiff.

"Vlad!" Danny's eyes flashed green as he turned towards the crowd and snarled the man's name. Moments later, the white rings swept over him as he morphed into his ghost form. "What did you do to her? To the rest of them?"

"Temper, temper Daniel." Masters' voice was light as he appeared to their left and slowly walked towards them. "My duplicates are temporarily inhabiting them. As long as you behave, I won't hurt them." The man locked eyes with Jason. "I would recommend putting those toys away, son. Wouldn't want anyone to get stuck in the crossfire."

The controlled crowd took stepped closer to them. They almost looked robotic as they moved.

Cursing the realization no one asked Danny exactly what a ghost could or couldn't do when possessing a human, he put away the guns. Couldn't risk anyone getting harmed.

Black rings washed over Masters as he changed into his ghost form and smiled. "With the distraction outside distracting your family and the one in here handled, we can chat like gentlemen." Plasmius' expression turned predatory as he floated. "Jason, or should I call you by your moniker of the Red Hood? You know, I never understood why you decided to use that specific title. I heard rumors your father's nemesis, the Joker, once used it."

"Needed to remind someone of a mistake they made, but what can I say? I've become attached to the name." Jason stole a peek at the crowd. They had stopped moving again. "But why take such extreme measures for a talk?"

"As I'm sure you and your family know, I've spent a great deal of time researching potential business partners in order to further my goals. Your father has been of great interest to me for years. Due to some unusual coincidences, I decided to uncover what his connections with Batman happened to be. So many of us billionaires have our little hobbies after all."

"Wait... Batman?" Danny gaped at him. After blinking a few times, he pointed at window. "If... if your brother is Nightwing... Your entire family is...! But, but how? And do all billionaires either choose to be heroes or villains? Do you people seriously have nothing better to do with your time and money?"

"Did you really just figure that out, Daniel?"

"How many other families do you know where every single one of them decided to become heroes?" he snapped.

Jason decided not to answer that. When it came to human families, many of them did tend to get involved either directly or indirectly. Instead, he decided to ask a different question. "How exactly did you find out? It's not like that information is readily available."

"I can see you're intrigued by my tactics." Masters took a moment to gloat. "I'll assume you've heard the phrase 'ghost in the machine'?"

"Yeah, but something tells me it has a more literal meaning for you then the philosophical one." At Masters' smile, Jason tensed. If it was true that ghosts could infiltrate machines, then it was unlikely any information, no matter how protected, was safe.

"You'd be correct. While I currently hire those more adept at the practice than myself, I found it very beneficial as I expanded my businesses. Imagine my surprise to find out how much information Bruce Wayne has gathered over the years about everyone and everything. But what I think surprised me the most was you, Jason."

"Let me guess, you saw my death records."

"I'll be the first to admit how dreadful the report is. Between how the Joker used your mother as a lure, and his actions that lead to your demise, I don't understand how your father was able to restrain himself in order to capture him. I would have thought he'd permanently end the threat, but that mad man escaped yet again and crippled a dear family friend."

Jason narrowed his eyes and fingered his guns. What was Masters' game? Was he purposely trying to bring up his anger towards Bruce lack of killing that fucking waste of a human to get a rise out of him? Or was he going to offer to kill the Joker in order to sway him to his side? "You're awfully brave to bring up that bastard in front of me."

"Now, now, no need for the scary eyes."

"What? Can't handle someone glaring at you?"

Vlad's expression briefly morphed to curiosity. "Do you not know what happened to you? What changes are occurring?"

"Your eyes are glowing," Danny whispered as he floated to his right. "Strong emotions can cause ghost powers to trigger accidentally. With the modifications to the Deflector, I'm not sure if it'll still shock you if one activates."

His eyes were glowing? Shit. The last time it happened his vision tinged green, but that wasn't happening this time. The Pit was still active and angry, but it didn't seem to be clouding him like before. Maybe that trip to the Ghost Zone sped up the filtering process Frostbite mentioned.

"Good to know," he responded as he let some of the tension in his shoulders go. Even if he was currently in control, there was no telling what the tipping point might be.

"That's better." Masters smirked as he continued. "Now, where we're we? Ah yes, your death and resurrection. I've spent a great deal of time studying death and those of us who linger on beyond the grave. Your situation was so unique – being brought back to life in a pool of the same substance that half killed me, half killed Daniel. I wasn't sure what that entailed until we finally met in person. You might not even have noticed it, but I caught the glow of your eyes upon our greeting. And when I was escorting you and your family to the hotel, there was a brief slip of invisibility."

There was? He doubted that. In a car full of people who were either Batman or trained by him, there was no way none of them noticed. But, with how paranoid Bruce could be, he could have waited to bring it up when he was certain of what was happening or if someone else mentioned it.

"So what?" The longer he could keep Masters talking, the longer he had to try to figure something out. They were at a huge disadvantage if they stayed in the ballroom. His hands moved to a hidden pocket on the inside of his jacket. "Unlike you and

Phantom here,” he made sure to keep his fist closed as he gestured to Danny with his thumb before gesturing to himself, “this is the only form I have.”

“Perhaps.” Masters floated a little higher as he regarded him and Danny. A magenta glow encompassed his fists. “Or perhaps you’ve just never had a reason to discover it.”

“You think you’ve done your research, but you really don’t know a thing about me.” Smirking, he quickly dropped the smoke bomb he held. As Plasmius began coughing, Jason quickly put on his mask and grabbed Danny as he bolted for the door. If he wanted to even the playing field, he needed to get them away from the other guests. He let Danny go after he slammed his way through the doors.

“What’s wrong with you?” Danny demanded after coughing a few times as he watched Jason remove his jacket and dress shirt to reveal one of his bulletproof vests. “Vlad still has control over everyone in there, including one of my best friends!”

“Masters’ goal is us.” He was all business as he put on his experimental goggles and pulled up the red hood attached to the vest. “I doubt he’ll be able to keep control of his hostages while he looks for us. Now, what’s the best way to get out of here?”

The kid glowered at him but didn’t argue. Instead, he grabbed him and turned intangible. For a moment, Jason could feel a chill spread throughout his arm, but electricity crackled causing Danny to hiss in pain and pull away.

“Guess the easy way isn’t going to work. Whatever was done to the Deflector allows you to touch me safely, but as soon as try to use my powers on you, it zaps me.” Danny floated towards the stairs and beckoned him. “If any of them get hurt because of you...”

“Yeah, yeah, I get it. Lead the way.”

It seemed as if Danny was purposely trying to lose him as he zipped through the walls of the mansion. Thankfully, he could easily detect the cold spot that was Danny with his gear.

As they moved, he tried to contact the others, but static once again filled the com. Was it something to do with the storm outside? Or was it something that Plasmius was doing? Great, the Bat wasn’t going to like being kept out of the loop.

The Pit snarled, giving him just enough of a warning to dodge a flash of magenta, he grabbed one of the ecto-guns and spun around. It only took a moment for him to find the area with the unusually high energy reading and take a shot of his own. Fucking invisibility. While he didn’t hit center, he was still able to graze Plasmius’ shoulder and bring him into the visible spectrum. Now that he had a more defined target, it was time to show the creep just who he was messing with.

“Why won’t you hold still?” Plasmius demanded as he tried and failed to Jason with several more blasts.

If he had to guess, they were some sort of plasma or energy attack, but the man’s attack patterns were so basic. It was hardly a challenge. “Guess you’ve never fought someone who’s been trained to fight against metas and aliens.”

“Aren’t you worried I’m going to hurt my guests?”

“You have no need for hostages up here, Vlad.” Jason purposely hit his arm this time followed by a blast to the chest, knocking him to the floor. Plasmius quickly stood and backed away from him. “Besides, it’s difficult to fight when you have your attention spread out between so many duplicates of yourself.” He smiled as he followed the ghost and grabbed his suit. “I’m going to enjoy this.”

The punch to Plasmius’ jaw happened to be one of the most satisfying in his career. Not only did it feel like the jaw ended up dislocated, but the resulting electrical shock from the Specter Deflector also made him cry out in pain. The man deserved a few more. Maybe he should dislocate one of Plasmius’ shoulders too.

“JASON!”

He stopped mid-punch and looked towards the source of the voice. Danny was floating nearby, horrified. Ah, he must have gotten carried away if he hadn’t heard or noticed him. But it was weird, the green haze that usually accompanied such episodes wasn’t present this time. Unsure what to make of that, he released Plasmius’ suit jacket and backed away.

Plasmius seemed to be unconscious. Purplish bruising had begun to form on his face, but he hadn’t reverted back to his human form. Was Vlad able to hold onto that form even while unconscious? Or was he like Danny and would revert back?

“Something tells me you checked to see if the people in the ballroom were okay while I played with this idiot,” Jason kept his eye on Plasmius as Danny floated closer to him. With limited gadgets available, he wouldn’t be able to hold him, unless he used the Specter Deflector. He’d consider that.

“Yeah, and they’re okay, by the way. But I didn’t expect to come back and find you pummeling Vlad.” Danny frowned at the other half-ghost. “How’d you do that?”

“I punched him.”

“I got that part, but you knocked him down. Like, you won. How?” The kid gestures wildly towards Plasmius.

“You’re kidding, right?” If Danny was that impressed, then he really needed some help with training. Those ghost animals were more of a challenge than Plasmius. The man had gotten complacent with fighting people unequipped to fight back against him, but his ability to gather data he shouldn’t have access to still made him dangerous.

Or, was this entire situation too easy? Could Plasmius have intended to throw the fight to lure him into a false sense of security? It didn’t seem likely he would have allowed himself to take so much damage, unless it was another duplicate.

The one thing he didn’t know was exactly how duplicates worked for ghosts. If it split the power between the original and the duplicate, Masters would still take damage. But, if they fell more under the category of a construct, there was a good chance the damage wouldn’t transfer. If that was the case, Plasmius could send duplicate after duplicate which would be more likely to wear him out first than the reverse. Great.

He tried his comm again, but it was still full of static. Fuck. This was one of the few times he absolutely wanted to keep the others in the loop. “Phantom, save your questions for later. We need to get outside,” he instructed as he trained one of the ecto-guns at Plasmius.

“Why? You knocked him out.” As much as Jason liked the kid, Danny’s lack of training was starting to wear thin. This wasn’t the time to be standing around.

Before he had a chance to reply, the Pit hissed a warning. If he had to deal with it for the rest of his life, the least those vile Waters could do would be more specific about where exactly the threat would come from if it was going to be a built-in alarm system. Keeping the one gun trained on Plasmius, he glanced around for some sort of indication of where the new threat would originate.

He had just enough of a warning of an abnormal heat signature from his goggles to dodge out of the way from a magenta blast that came from just behind his feet. Yeah, there was at least one other duplicate, or it was the real Plasmius. But this one was going to take pot shots without revealing itself.

“Shit! This way!” Phantom beckoned to him as he flew down the hallway. As Jason raced to keep up, Phantom moved to his side. “I need to stop questioning the guy who has way more years of experience fighting bad guys than I do.”

“If that’s an apology, it’s a lousy one.”

“Would you rather I don’t admit I’m wrong?” Despite the irritation in his voice, his smirk suggested he enjoyed their back and forth. “Anyways, there’s a balcony down the end of this hall. Since I can’t get us out the easy way, getting down from there shouldn’t be hard for someone used to jumping around skyscrapers.”

Danny flew ahead and passed harmlessly through the approaching glass door, but as soon as he did, what appeared to be a magenta forcefield sprung up and blocked it. Well, there went that exit. Damn, he would have liked to see Glowstick’s reaction to him not giving a shit as he broke through the glass.

Spinning around, he aimed his ecto-guns at nothing. The hallway was empty, and he wasn’t getting a reading from his goggles. The color of that energy suggested it came from Plasmius, but without knowing where he was, he wasn’t going to risk being a sitting duck.

Good, there was a door to the left. Not bothering to check if it was locked, he kicked it open to reveal a relatively empty room with a few pieces of furniture covered by cloth. Very little cover, but there was a window. That was going to be his exit. However, just like in the hall, a magenta field of energy blocked it. Spinning around, he found the doorway blocked as well. Well, shit.

“I must admit, I am amazed at how easily you were able to defeat one of my duplicates,” Plasmius stated as he passed through the wall. “You even correctly deduced it was nothing but a distraction. But I don’t understand why you won’t phase through the walls. It’s so easy for someone like us.”

Jason trained the ecto-gun at him. “But that’s the thing, I’m not like you and Phantom. I’m human.”

“Do you really expect me to believe that?”

“It’s funny how many people seem to think that way.” For a brief moment, the memory of Supergirl’s reaction to him came to mind. She doubted his status as a normal human too. He was using Venom at the time, but semantics. “But you’re the one who supposedly read Batman’s files on me. He’s not one to leave out details.”

Plasmius glared at him. “No, I suppose not, but it leaves me to wonder how someone who isn’t half ghost like myself or Daniel is able to display the same rudimentary powers.”

“You said it yourself, I was submerged in the Lazarus Pit.” While Plasmius didn’t seem to be willing to directly attack, the Waters continued to churn within him. More danger was coming his way, but from where? Above? Below? Behind? He tried below before, but something told Jason he wouldn’t try the exact same tactic a second time. “We’re guessing I’m bonded to the stuff. Enough to make me a zombie, but not a ghost.”

Maybe he shouldn’t call himself a zombie. There were some unsettling reports of the Pit creating actual ones. Nah, he liked using it as a joke.

The hungry expression returned to Plasmius’ face. “Or perhaps you needed an environment more conducive to your developing powers. But to find that, I’ll need to you remove that damnable belt.”

“Fat chance of that.”

“Oh, you misunderstand. That wasn’t a request.”

Jason heard the buzz a millisecond before he felt it. Whatever tased him from behind was worse than any of the other ones he’d encountered in the past. It wasn’t enough to knock him out, but it did bring him to his knees. He had just enough time to catch his breath to allow him to dodge a magenta blast from Plasmius’ open hand.

“I’m impressed. Daniel can barely stay awake when faced with the same attack.” The Plasmius in front of him didn’t speak. Instead, it was another duplicate to his right.

“You’re telling me that you’ve tried tasing a kid who nearly died from electrocution?” The familiar green tinge started filling his vision again. Shit, it wasn’t the time for that. He needed to keep his head on straight so he could break the bastard who thought it was sensible to make a kid experience again the thing that almost took his life.

Deciding not to let the fucker have a chance to explain himself, Jason blasted both Plasmius and the duplicate, catching both off-guard. Deciding to ignore the duplicate, he focused all of his attacks on the main body. However, this one didn’t fall like the original duplicate he faced. Instead, he stepped back into the wall.

The duplicate vanished too, but the energy fields in front of the window and door didn’t. Time to improvise and start blasting walls. While he didn’t have his normal arsenal on him, he still had a few explosives. After placing a few on the wall, he dodged behind one of the furniture pieces as they blew.

He stood up only to find the wall hadn’t been damaged. Instead, Plasmius floated in front of it with a sphere of pink energy between his hands. Smoke could be seen within it. He managed to contain the explosion inside of it?

“I can’t have you destroying my home now, can I?” Plasmius smiled, exposing fangs. “I must applaud your creativity though. Batman has trained you well, but I don’t think you’ll be able to get yourself out of this.”

“We’ll see about that.” During the temporary lull, the Pit had quieted some, but now it was roaring. He found out why as several different duplicates of Plasmius phased through the walls. All of them had their fists glowing with that same energy. “Shit.”

Well, if he was going to be outnumbered, he was going to take as many of them out as he could before either they overwhelmed him or help arrived. The last time he took on someone he couldn’t handle alone, he got killed. While he didn’t think Plasmius wanted him completely dead, he didn’t really like his chances if the guy managed to knock him out.

Notes:

I have a weird love/hate relationship with writing Vlad. He's so manipulative, but seriously, what has he been doing with his powers over the 20 years he's had them? We know he's been overshadowing businessmen, but what else?

The Lazarus Pits has created legit zombies in the comics. One was through contamination with chemicals, and the other was because of how long it was between the death of the person and when they were put in the Pit.

Chapter 9 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/89731921>): Pain So Familiar and Close to the Heart

Notes:

Possible needed warning? Talks surrounding death, dark humor related to death, self-deprecating thoughts throughout the work, and canon-typical violence.

Quick note: Merry Christmas/Yule and Happy New Year's. It's after 3am, and I have work in the morning. I'll reread this on my lunch break tomorrow to look for errors. Also, I have messages I still need to respond to... I get so behind during the holidays.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_9_endnotes\)](#).)

His entire body ached as he slowly came to. What bullshit did Roy get him into this time? That idiot better not have tried to test a flamethrower on him again.

As his head continued to clear, flashes of the fight with Plasmius came to him. He had been outnumbered. How many duplicates were there? Twenty? Thirty? Thirty sounded like too many, but there were a lot. Now the question became whether or not he won.

He could remember starting with the duplicate closest to him. After surprising him with a punch, he took a few shots at some of the others before dodging blasts and grabs. The fight seemed to have gone in his favor, but the aches and stings of pain suggested it didn’t end as great as he hoped.

Opening his eyes, he found himself behind what appeared to be some sort of domed glass. What the fuck?

Now fully awake, he focused on getting as many details as he could before determining how to proceed. Although his mask and goggles were gone, he was thankfully still clothed. Some of the visible skin on his arms held burns. Bastard managed to get in a few lucky shots.

He tried to lift his arms, but something prevented much movement. He knew that feeling. Shit, he was strapped to something. Well, strapped might not be the correct word. Those looked more like metal cuffs. Taking a better look at his surroundings, he realized he was in something that suspiciously looked like a pod he’d seen in so many different laboratories over the years. Not a hospital bed, got it. That meant it was perfectly fine for him to work on escaping.

His wrist guards appeared to be untouched. Thank God he’d been able to originally hide them under his suit apparel before everything went to Hell. It made it much easier for him to get to any one of the small tools he had hidden for this very purpose. And none of them seemed to be in their spots. That meant someone knew he tended to have tools on him, lovely.

Was it Plasmius? It was probably Plasmius. He hadn’t done anything recently to warrant the old man to remove his gadgets.

Speaking of which, where was he? Where were the others? With the amount of time that passed prior to him blacking out, they should have finished with Ra’s’ men. And it was unlikely they couldn’t get back in the mansion, unless Plasmius managed to block them the same way he blocked Jason’s attempt at exiting. Did Plasmius decide to fight them instead? Or, did he move him to a different location? What about Danny?

He distinctly remembered Danny escaping, and he didn’t have any memories of seeing him prior to things going black. The Pit hadn’t sent out any greetings, but the distraction of the multitude of duplicates could have explained that. After he figured out how to free himself and where he was, locating Danny would be his primary objective.

After checking to see if he could see movement outside the pod, he did what he could to figure out the cuffs. These ones didn’t seem to have any sort of flaw or opening he could use. There should have been some sort of hole, either for keys or as a failsafe. Damn it!

Maybe he could pass through it? Sure, he didn’t have any clue how to do that, but he didn’t have a lot of options. How hard could it be? He’d already done it on accident a few times. Danny said strong emotions could trigger them.

Well, he was trapped in a goddamned pod by a man who thought it was an appropriate thing to electrocute a teenager. The matter-of-fact way Plasmius admitted it made his blood boil. Once he got himself out of this mess, he was going to attempt to figure out if it was possible to remove a half-ghost’s fingers.

Pain seared through his body, nearly making him cry out. Did he get tased, again? It felt similar, but it was worse than whatever Plasmius used earlier. Did he crank up the voltage because the first one didn’t work?

“I would avoid trying to do that.” Plasmius’ voice seemed warped and distant, but he was just outside the glass dome, peering in. When did he get there? Had the Pit reacted to his presence? But he did just get tased.

Seriously, where’d he come from? Guess that was payback for all the times he and the others pulled that same trick on people in the past. It was pretty funny for a human to appear and disappear like that. A super powered asshole doing it? Not so much.

“So what mad science experiment are you about to pull on me today? You do realize I’m not impressed with this set up.”

“Ah, yes, with all your time spend terrorizing the thugs of Gotham, I could scarcely imagine what you and your siblings have encountered over the years. However, I do believe this is a bit different then the trivial attempt at attention your normal rogues have done in the past.”

“Enlighten me.” He needed to keep Plasmius talking. The more he revealed, the more likely he’d say something Jason could use to get out of this mess.

The ghost chuckled as he moved out of sight. However, his voice seemed to come from just to the left, even accounting for the distortion. “I decided I needed to look into your claims that you’re still human. My devices don’t detect an active core in your body.”

“Told you I’m a zombie, not a ghost.” His body still ached, and he hadn’t found any weakness in the cuffs yet.

“Quite.” A sour note colored Plasmius’ voice. “Even in our human forms, it’s still possible to detect evidence of my and Daniel’s cores. Either yours is inactive for some reason, or it never properly formed. Perhaps being in Amity is completing the process that began those years ago when you returned from the dead.”

Jason rolled his eyes. “Even though it wasn’t my idea, I think I like being fully alive.” Well, most of the time, anyways. Lingering doubts of whether or not his return to life helped anyone often reared their ugly head on quiet nights.

“I suppose that would be the normal response. However, I believe you’ll change your mind when you have a chance to experience to understand things from my perspective.”

Well shit. If he didn’t get out of this soon, something told him he was going to find out if his morbid musings about the pain of a ghost being created were just as bad as coming back to life. Attempting to things discretely didn’t work so it was time to start being overt. He pulled at the restraints and tried to move his legs. Great, those were stuck too.

Plasmius laughed as electricity coursed through his body again. “Do you get some sort of pleasure by watching that happen to people?” Jason spat when the feeling stopped.

“Only when people continue to make the same mistakes. I’d already told you not to try that. Though, I am surprised that these things don’t seem to affect you.” Plasmius moved in front of the glass and held up the Spector Deflector. It looked like it had been cut. “Perhaps you are more underdeveloped than I thought. Anyways, Daniel already showed me how easy it is to escape from things like this if they get damaged in any way, so I made sure to rig it to send disruptive amounts of electricity if the person inside demonstrates any sort of ectoplasmic ability. We wouldn’t want you to leave before I’m finished.”

Plasmius moved out of view again. “I’m curious to see how you’ll look when you finally transform.”

Something thick and wet touched his legs. While he didn’t have much mobility, he could still see the reflection of the green glow on the glass of the pod. He could also smell the unforgettable arid scent of the Lazarus Waters.

Oh, oh, shit. This really wasn’t good. Sure, it could resurrect the dead, but it would also kill healthy people. And, he was pretty sure the minor burns on his arms did not count as being injured enough for the Waters to heal him. He was really going to die again this time, and just like last time, he was going to be alone as he died. No one was going to save him.

As the Waters filled the pod, electricity began to hum. This time, he couldn’t stop the screaming until the Waters reached his head. The pain tore through his body, burning him both inside and out. He knew this feeling, and he knew he was falling back through the veil, back towards death.

Blackness threatened to take him as the pain stopped. He could vaguely hear cracking glass and maybe a voice. His arms fell from their restraints as his body went limp. Hands, at least four, caught him as he fell forward.

More pain raced across his body at their touch. He could feel his back arch from the pain as they hurriedly pulled him from the pod, placed him on the ground, and gave him space.

His senses were muddled as he tried to move to his knees and cough up the remaining Water in his lungs. He couldn’t seem to keep himself balanced. Each time he tried to distribute his weight, one of his limbs tried to give way.

Eventually, someone grabbed and helped stabilize him. Whoever it was had an icy but comfortable touch. He could feel the rumbles from his helper, suggesting the person was trying to talk. But, it sounded muffled and distant.

A few shakes of the head and several blinks helped clear his head. Danny came into focus at his side. The kid’s eyes were wide and terrified as he said something. His voice still seemed far away, but Jason could get enough to know he was asking if he was okay.

Jason shook his head again and turned his head towards the others who he could almost feel hovering nearby. Tim had a hesitant hand reached towards him. Tense shoulders and a grimace suggested he wasn’t entirely sure what to do.

In front of him, kneeling, was the one man he didn’t think would be there. “You’re... you’re here.” Jason’s voice was raw and weak as he tried to speak.

Bruce gave him one of his rare soft smiles. “I’m here. Phantom told us what happened. You did well.” His smile quickly disappeared as he turned to Danny. “Stay with him. We’ll handle the rest. Red Robin, with me.”

“Wait!” He cringed at the sound of the damage to his voice. “Plasmius’ duplicates are similar to constructs. Defeating them doesn’t seem to affect him. Don’t let them corner you.”

“Understood.” Bruce raced off with Tim closely following. Flashes of magenta and the sounds of fighting appeared to be coming from behind some machinery. If Plasmius was fighting the others, they must have been able to catch him off guard.

Danny nudged him to get his attention. “Do you think you can stand?”

"I think so." His legs felt like jelly, so he begrudgingly let Phantom help him. His hearing seemed to have returned as the sounds of the battle started to drift towards him. "What happened when you escaped?"

"When I realized you didn't follow me, I tried to get back in. I think Plasmius used some sort of modified ghost shield around the house because I couldn't get back in, even when I changed back to my human form. Those shouldn't affect me when I'm like that. Stupid Plasmius." He glowered at the machine behind them.

Deciding to take a moment to see exactly what he was held in, Jason also looked at it. He recognized the design of it from some of the records of the clone experiments. Plasmius must have modified it. Some of the Lazarus Water could still be seen pooled in the bottom.

He shivered at the sight. He really had been submerged in it again, but he was okay? Glancing down at his hands and body, everything seemed to still be intact. The burns on his arms were healed which was a small blessing.

"So, I take it you alerted the others?" His voice wasn't as rough as before.

Danny nodded. "Yeah. I found them fighting ghosts outside."

Maybe Jason hit his head during the confrontation with Vlad because that didn't make any sense. "Ghosts? I don't understand. You said you were attacked by a 'wannabe ninja', and that dart you handed me was from the same organization we came here for."

"There were some bodies nearby. I think they were the people you were looking for..."

"Thought ghosts don't tend to kill."

"Normally they don't, but I think Plasmius hired them. He has a bit of a reputation in the Ghost Zone. Halfas are not only rare, but from what Frostbite's told me, we tend to be stronger than a lot of other ghosts. And in that world, strength is one of the few things universally respected."

Jason hummed in understanding. That sounded a lot like the world he grew up in. Strength, money, and connections ruled. Then Batman came and fear ended up added to the list, at least for the low-level punks and crooks.

"So, how did you guys find me?"

Danny looked up at him before looking away. That was an odd reaction. Was he ashamed of something? That was the same type of look he used to give Bruce when he got in trouble as Robin, usually for something that involved him directly disobeying orders.

"Well... after I helped them catch those ghosts, I explained you needed help." The kid glanced towards where the battle was ongoing. "The small one, that's Robin, right?"

He snorted. "Yeah, but don't let the Demon Brat hear that. He's not afraid of stabbing people."

Danny audibly gulped. "I'll... I'll keep that in mind. Well, he made a remark about that being unlikely or something, but Batman shushed him and asked for details. After filling them in, they were able to get back inside even though I still couldn't. Tim..." He backpedaled when Jason raised an eyebrow at him, "err, I mean Red Robin did something which fixed the ghost shield problem and apparently the security, and I lead them to the area I last saw you."

"Makes sense. B and the others probably were able to figure out what happened pretty quickly."

"Yeah. You know, it's kind of creepy to see how fast he works." It was funny how unsettled supers tended to be around Bruce and the various members of the extended family. "But he figured you'd been taken, and we hurried to the lab. We could hear you screaming as they broke down the door."

Lovely. He was never going to hear the end of that from his siblings. All things were potential blackmail material in their world, but with Bruce's reaction as he came too, this one might be off the table. He'd figure that out later.

"Thanks for the explanation." He pulled away from Danny and tested his movements. Whatever weakness was bothering him when he got out of that thing seemed to have worn off which meant it was time to go exact some revenge on Plasmius. While he didn't have any of his gear on him, it didn't mean he couldn't improvise. Besides, he still had his fists. "Time to go help."

"Woah! Did you not hear Batman? He said to stay here!" Danny floated so he was at eyelevel.

"No, he told you to stay with me." He brushed past the kid, who quickly moved to keep up with him.

"I... but he... I guess?" Danny sighed before a mischievous glint appeared in his eyes. "Well, if you're going to get me in trouble, we're going to do things my way."

A few moments later, Jason found himself floating invisibly in the air with Phantom. Turns out the kid was able to, if he wanted, extend his abilities to those he touched. Jason found himself impressed with Danny's strength – he lifted him with one arm like he was nothing.

For a few moments, Jason allowed himself to marvel at the feeling of being virtually undetectable while being in the air without the help of a machine. There was so much freedom in it, and once again, he wondered just how much he'd be able to accomplish with a similar set of powers. Ah shit, he needed to get rid of those thoughts and focus.

The others were fighting Plasmius, well, at least attempting. The half-ghost made several more duplicates. Seriously, just how many could he make in a day? Even if they were constructs, they still should take energy to make, and between the amount of damage he did while cornered and how he controlled the guests at the dance, Plasmius should be getting tired. The man had stamina most be envious of.

The various duplicates kept coming from the walls and floor and attempting to blast them. If Jason wasn't mistaken, the Deflectors seemed to be the main targets. Thankfully they were trained well enough to be able to dodge, but Duke was starting to stumble. And if one of the was showing signs, the others would be soon to follow. Even with all of their training, prolonged fights took stamina, and Plasmius didn't seem to be affected in the same way.

As one duplicate vanished, another would take its place, and the others seemed to be slowly wearing down. So, the question became which one was the real one? If they could find him, they might be able to use the element of surprise to get the jump on him.

“They need help.” Danny’s whisper held a note of urgency.

“Yeah, but we can do more if we can target the real Vlad. Which one...?” He doubted it was one of the ones directly fighting. That would put him at too much risk. There were a few floating above the fight just watching, and above them, appeared to be a few Batarangs and Birdarangs stuck in the ceiling and walls. Depending on who threw the Birdarangs, those trajectories could be off, but Batman almost never missed his target. That meant the most likely culprit would be...

“Danny, get me above that one!” He pointed to the one in question only to realize he was still invisible. Yeah, the kid probably couldn’t see him so he directed him where he needed to go. When Danny got in position, Jason wrestled out of his grip and prepared for the incoming impact.

The freefall only took a second. Jason honestly expected Plasmius to notice him and turn invisible at the last possible moment, but he didn’t. Instead, Jason connected and used his interlocked hands to bash the bastard in the head. As both he and Plasmius fell, he noticed two things: the duplicates began to vanish and Bruce’s frown. Why did he think Jason would ever stay out of a fight if he wasn’t incapacitated or tied down?

“Are you out of your mind?” Danny demanded as he caught him mid-fall. “You could have gotten seriously hurt or killed if you fell that hard.”

“Eh, it’s only about eighty feet. Survived worse.” He grinned as Vlad connected with the floor with a satisfying thud. Definitely made the list of one of his favorite hits.

After setting him down, the ghost boy gaped at him. “What’s wrong with you? Who in their right mind says things like that? Most people would get seriously injured if they fell that far.”

“It’s all about the landing.”

“Nice going!” Dick tossed him a Fenton blaster as he and the others moved to circle Plasmius.

While the ghost didn’t seem to be moving, it didn’t mean he was down for the count. He could just be biding his time before phasing through the floor. If he did that, there was little any of them would be able to do to stop him. But, if they tried to approach him and put one of their Deflectors on him, he could attempt to possess them. It was quite the conundrum.

Plasmius slowly rose to his knees when Bruce took a step forward. “I’m quite impressed. I wouldn’t have thought that humans would be able to hold out against someone like me, but today I have found myself humbled.” He chuckled darkly before standing.

Everyone moved to attack. Between the seven of them and Danny, Vlad couldn’t keep from being hit for long. And just like predicted, he quickly dove into the floor, quickly followed by Danny. As the others tried to find a way to follow them with their equipment, he tried to keep his wits about him.

The Pit seemed to be unusually quiet. No stirring or whispering to alert him. Nothing. It wasn’t like it was gone. He could still feel it within him, but it felt more concentrated than before, especially in his chest. Rubbing the area in discomfort, he decided to check the nearest tables for his missing gear.

As if the universe decided to spite him, again, the Pit stirred to life. But as it snarled in warning, he felt one of his legs give way. And instead of just tripping, everything from his foot to his thigh had plunged into the floor. Dick moved forward to help him, but Jason held up his hand. The Pit still hadn’t settled.

“You finally let your guard down.” Plasmius almost seem to purr before he grabbed Jason’s still solid leg and pulled him into the floor.

This time, there wasn’t a secret room or tunnel underneath the floor. There was no light or air. Instead, Jason could sense the pressure and oppressiveness of the rock and dirt that was harmlessly passing through him. If he thought he was going to die before, this time, he was absolutely certain of it. Any attempt at fighting back would result in either getting out of Plasmius’ grasp or him letting go which would ultimately make him solid again.

But then again, he really didn’t want to know where Plasmius was going to take him. Even if he survived this trip, there was a chance he’d get killed by whatever experiment the bastard tried on him next. And, he certainly didn’t want another dip in Lazarus Pit water. So, if he was going to die again anyways, he was going to die fighting.

Surprised he was able to catch something solid when he tried kicking Plasmius, he tried several more before the man finally let him go. Panic immediately set in, and the pressure surrounding him suddenly seemed more intense than before.

But, he was still conscious, and for some reason, he was still able to move. Maybe it was something to do with the Waters that still contaminated his body. No matter what unfathomable bullshit was happening, he was going to use it to his advantage. For lack of a better term, he tried to swim in the direction he believed was up.

He hated it. He hated the feeling of what should have been solid rock passing through him. He also hated how the Pit seemed to fuel his movements forward. It made his skin crawl. If this was the same thing as the intangibility he’d experience with his earlier accidents, why did it feel so much different? Maybe it was unique to actually having his entire body in something.

Eventually, one of his hands move through something with a different type of feel than the rock around him. Hoping it was a good sign, he pushed himself forward. Blinding light and angry shouts met him. After needing a few moments adjust to the light difference, he realized he was back in Vlad’s lab.

His attention was drawn towards the voices. Dick and Duke appeared to be holding back Bruce. Tim was doing something with his wrist computer while he argued with the Damian. Cass was gently patting Danny’s shoulder. The kid must have reemerged from the floor after Vlad grabbed him.

Not sure what he missed, he tried to move forward but was met with resistance. Glance down, he found he was waist deep in a table and stuck. More unnerved than when he was moving through solid rock, he tried and failed to remove himself from it. Thankfully, he did seem to be okay. He must have made some sort of noise as he caught the attention of the others, who rushed over.

Unspoken relief could be seen on most of their faces, except Cass. Hers was understandable due to the design of her cowl. Damian’s surprised him. Maybe the tiny ball of rage did have some sort of attachment to him and the others.

“I think you’re having trouble. Need help?”

Despite himself, Jason flipped off Danny. “I’d be more grateful if you’d did a better job at trying to not laugh. And you,” he pointed at Dick, “don’t you dare breathe one word of this to Roy.”

Notes:

Why Roy Harper decided to test a flamethrower on Jason while he was showering is something I’m never going to understand. And I hate to say it, but this is absolutely something some of my cousins would do if they had access to one. My bets lies with the two that threw the cinder block at the migrating bees nest. Why? Because one of them makes experimental weapons too.

I added a little nod to 'Batman: Urban Legends' in this chapter. While I have a lot of mixed feelings about arc between Bruce and Jason (mostly in the resolution of it), I really do appreciate it showing they do want reconciliation with each other, even if they have no idea how to do it. Poor Jason admitting he just wants to belong somewhere and feel wanted. I'm also going to mention I'm extremely angry that it shows Jason actually using a grappling hook after the sheer amount of time I spent trying to find panels that showed him using one without success.

Chapter 10 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/91877434>): Your Scream is Burning through My Veins

Notes:

I survived Florida. Almost didn't survive driving through Georgia, again. That state has it out for me. And Palmetto bugs are terrifying.

Also, this chapter was hard to write. Apparently, banter is what was needed.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_10_endnotes\)](#).)

“Are you sure you’re okay?” Duke hesitantly asked Jason as they made their way out of the lab. Plasmius hadn’t reemerged, and without a clear picture of where he might go, they decided to check in on the other guests.

“For the fifth time, yes! Can we move past this already?” The repetitiveness had gotten under his skin. After Danny got him out of the table, he made sure to check if everything was okay. Even Bruce ran a quick scan as he replaced his gear which Dick and Cass happened to find while double checking the area before they exited. Even though the man frowned, he didn’t actually say anything which worked for Jason because it meant he wouldn’t be benched.

Sure, he dealt with two rather unpleasant brushes with death in the past hour or two. But, at this point, it was par for the course for long missions. The only thing that made him wonder if something did change in him was the weird feeling in his chest.

It wasn’t hurting him or anything, but he didn’t like how it felt. While it still caused problems, the Pit’s affects over his mind we’re slowly diminishing, and if Frostbite was to be believed, being in Amity was helping that process. Things had been noticeably better during his solo fight with Plasmius so there seemed to be something to it, but now those Waters felt more concentrated. He really didn’t want to slip into madness in front of the others, especially Danny. The kid had already done so much to help him. He didn’t need to see that.

Speaking of Danny, he flew a little to his left as they moved. His furrowed brows and frown suggested something made him uneasy. Was it the tension his siblings currently held in their stances? Or was it the anger radiating off of Bruce? Usually, the Bat reserved that for days when he decided Jason’s stance on how to be a good vigilante got under his skin more so than usual, prompting a physical fight.

Jason heard rumors Bruce was sometimes like that after one of their family members got seriously injured and/or killed. Tim once mentioned that was one of the reasons he originally approached Bruce. Supposedly, during the months after Jason’s death, Bruce’s way of handling criminals was unprecedentedly brutal. While it wasn’t a secret Batman would rough up criminals for information, he wasn’t usually violent for the sake of violence.

It wasn’t a good idea for him to think about that time period. Most of the time, it just created turmoil in his heart and mind that tended to make the whispers of the Pit hard to ignore.

“Phantom, do you have any idea where Plasmius may have gone?” The anger in Bruce’s voice brought him out of his thoughts. Usually, the man could keep his voice even, but it seemed his ire seemed to be partially directed at Danny.

“I can’t sense him like other ghosts so I’m not sure. In the past, if I screwed up one of his schemes, he’d back down for the day, and that’s that.” Danny almost seemed to shy away from the group as he spoke.

“What about Axiom Labs?” Dick suggested. “We saw his company bought it.”

The kid considered it for a moment. “Unlikely. He bought it for... what’s the word? Leverage? Basically, a family member of someone he tricked into working for him works there. I think I saw some of their tech in the lab, but he hasn’t really used any of it in a fight after me and my sister tricked him that one time.”

“Didn’t think your sister was the combative type.” Jason teased as they reached the staircase.

“She will if she has to.” A scowl momentarily crossed the kid’s features. “Just don’t let her hold the Fenton Thermos. I don’t know how, but she always catches me instead of who or whatever we’re trying to get. Do you know how cramped that thing is?”

“I don’t think most people have to worry about being trapped in one,” Duke hesitantly pointed out to the teen as he glanced back at Jason. Great, if one of them was thinking about whether or not he could be trapped by that stupid device, it meant the others probably were too.

He glared at his newest sibling. “If any of you try testing that on me, I promise vengeance beyond anything you can imagine.”

For some reason, the idea of being trapped in that thing tickled the same fear he had of waking up in a coffin.

“Don’t worry,” Cass surprisingly said as she appeared at Duke’s side. Even though all of them had mastered Batman’s art of being able to move without a trace, Cass seemed to take it to a different level. “He is unlikely to... cause permanent harm.”

“That doesn’t make me feel any better!”

Phantom floated closer to him. “You wouldn’t seriously try to hurt him, would you?”

“You already know I tried killing this one.” He jerked his thumb at Dick. He also nearly cut Tim’s throat, but even now, he wasn’t entirely certain if he was ever serious about it. That stunt was specifically designed to unsettle Bruce during the time period before he truly revealed himself as being alive. There was also that time he shot Damian. It would have been so easy to end him, but he purposely avoided a fatal shot. “But if you think that’s bad, you should hear some of the bullshit Robin tried pulling.”

“Is trying to kill each other normal in your family or something like that?” Danny floated closer as he glanced back and forth between him and Damian. “Like, I’d get it if there was an evil clone or future self situation, but you’re siblings, aren’t you? I thought you’d be more like, I dunno, supportive of each other and less stabby?” He looked baffled as everyone, except Bruce and Duke, started laughing. Oh, the poor kid had no idea.

“I’m the only one here who is blood related to Batman. I merely decided to claim my rightful place,” Damian irritably replied. “It was Father’s choice to adopt these miscreants.”

Jason snorted. “If by adopted, you mean abducted first, then sure.” He just barely caught the old man glance back at him with a frown. Oh, did he not like being reminded his response to their first meeting wasn’t exactly normal?

“I’m sorry, what? What do you mean abducted?” Danny’s eyes grew comically wide as he stared at Bruce’s back.

Dick mischievously grinned. “Oh, it’s kind of become a legend in our family. Red Hood stole the tires off the Batmobile and then tried attacking B with a tire iron when they met.”

“Wait, that’s true?” Duke gaped at him. “I thought Al... I mean, Agent A was messing with me when I asked.”

“Why did you try to attack him with the tire iron?” Tim questioned. “That’s the one thing that’s bothered me about it. Even for you, it doesn’t make a lot of sense.”

“I was a street kid doing something illegal and got caught. It made sense at the time.” Jason couldn’t help but grin at both Duke’s and Danny’s dumbstruck reaction. Too bad they couldn’t see it through his mask. “I’ll admit, it was one of my finer moments, but it did lead me to being tied up in the Batcave for a bit. Someone thought sandwiches would make a good peace offering.”

“If you forgot, we’re still on a mission.”

A few sheepish looks were tossed around at Bruce’s words. With the fighting currently over, they had slipped into their normal habit of teasing each other. Danny’s reactions made it more satisfactory. But, Jason supposed the old man had a point. They still needed to check on the civilians, and none of them were entirely certain what Plasmius’ next move might be.

As they continued up the stairs, something started buzzing. When everyone turned to Danny, he apologized as he pulled a green earpiece out of his belt. If Jason wasn’t mistaken, it was the same one the kid used when they traveled into the Ghost Zone.

“Sam? What’s wrong?” Danny’s expression slowly morphed to concern as he listened. While they waited for an explanation, Tim made a quick motion to let them know he was trying to hack that frequency. “He’s what? I’ll be right there!” The kid didn’t say anything to them before rocketing upwards and slipping through the ceiling of the stairwell.

“I only caught the end of it, but I think Masters is attacking the guests,” Tim stated as he rushed up the stairs. All of them followed.

Just before they reached the door to the ballroom, Dick tugged on his hood attached to his vest. “Make sure to pull your hood up. People might recognize your hair.” Other than Bruce, he was the only one currently tall enough to attempt it.

Annoyed, Jason smacked his brother’s hand away. Pain blossomed at the brief touch as the electric shock from Dick’s belt raced over his skin. As Dick backed away, stunned, Jason swore a few times. “I didn’t miss that feeling.” Of course, Plasmius’ little experiment on him had to have some sort of result.

“But I fixed that...” Tim’s puzzled voice caught his attention. He and the others started making speculative glances at him.

“We’ll worry about it later,” he snapped. They did not have time for this. The Pit was angrily churning, alerting him that Plasmius was somewhere nearby. “Just don’t touch me.”

Someone wanted to say something, but instead of letting the idiots continue to worry about him, he kicked the door to the ballroom open. Bruce would probably lecture him about it later, but that didn’t matter. They had a psychotic billionaire with superpowers to stop.

The scene that greeted them was something else. Danny was floating between the crowd of guests and Plasmius, who kept firing pot shots at them. Although the shots were easy enough for Danny to deflect with a green shield, similar to the constructs the Green Lanterns could make, they were too frequent for him to go on the offensive.

“Nightwing, Red Robin, Signal, evacuate the guests,” the old man instructed. “Robin, Hood, Orphan, we’re going to help Phantom.”

That was fine by him. Unlike the others, the Red Hood didn’t exactly give people a reassuring aura. Maybe he once did when he was still Robin, but those years were long since gone.

However, he didn’t like the order to stay close to Batman’s side. It was probably a safety precaution in case Plasmius tried targeting him again, but it still felt more like the man didn’t trust him enough to wander away. If he was going to have a chance to break the older half-ghost’s jaw again, he was going to listen to the order, at least for now.

As they began their tasks, Danny gave them a relieved smile before he went on the offensive. Jason had noticed it in his other fights, but Danny really did seem to have a preference for close up fighting as opposed to long distance attacks. From what he could

tell, the kid did seem to have decent aim, so why would he risk being so close? Did he not trust himself? Or did it have something to do with damage control? Jason vaguely remembered someone mentioning the amount of property damage done by the ghost attacks while they were going over details of the mission before arriving in Amity.

While Vlad clearly had more experience, he wasn't anywhere near as fast or flexible as Danny. While the older halfa could use the openings in Danny's self-taught fighting style to his advantage, the kid's speed and agility helped even the playing field. And, Danny now had backup.

Jason's task was fairly simple: distract Plasmus enough to let Danny get some hits on him while trying to get Vlad closer to the ground. Luckily for Danny, he was a pretty good shot. Bruce and the others also helped. While the ones with him hadn't chosen any long range ecto-weaponry, Bruce and the others kept Plasmus busy with their own various projectiles, some of which could explode.

After a few good hits, Plasmus turned his attention towards them. He flew down to fire a few close-range attacks, but Jason and the others easily dodged out of the way. When he turned to try another volley, Danny hit him from behind with one of his own blasts. The kid followed up with a different colored blast, blue this time. Ice cracked as it formed on the older halfa's right arm.

Cyrokinesis? None of their intel suggested Danny had such a power. Maybe it was something he rarely used. But it definitely would have been nice to know about a few hours ago.

Speaking of abilities, Vlad hadn't tried duplicating again. He hadn't been shy about using it during his earlier fights. Maybe he was starting to tire. Or maybe he didn't want too many people knowing about it. There were still normal guests in the room after all. But it didn't make much sense why he had been so willing to use that specific power against them.

Had he just been flexing when he overshadowed the guests? It was possible since he did seem to view Jason as a potential candidate for a son. And since he wasn't used to fighting against people who could fight against him, he possibly figured it was the only way to get the upper hand against Jason and the rest of his family.

Judging by the narrowed eyes, Bruce noticed the difference too. He made a brief gesture to the demon brat, and the two shot a grappling hook into the ceiling in an attempt for an airborne attack while Plasmus was distracted by Danny. They were able to connect, and Plasmus shrieked in pain from the combination of the blows and the shocks from their belts.

Although he didn't fall to the ground, Plasmus did lose some altitude, allowing Cass an opportunity to launch an attack of her own. While he was distracted by her, Jason viewed it as the perfect opportunity for a few more shots while Bruce and Damian safely landed. While the first two hit, the halfa recovered enough to use the ice encasing his arm as a temporary shield before spinning around and smacking Danny, who had been closing in, with it. A pinkish aura could be seen in the ice before it was blasted apart. Energy crackled around Plasmus' hand in much the same way raw electricity would.

"I'm impressed, Daniel." The light tone of Plasmus' voice didn't match his scowl. "I didn't realize your core already developed an elemental aspect. It's already fairly rare among ghosts, and it's almost unheard of to develop one within a year of formation."

"You should be glad I did. If I hadn't, Undergrowth would have taken root in Amity, permanently." Danny shot another blue beam of energy towards the other halfa, who dodged out of the way. Jason and the others also had to move as it hit a little too close to them. A few spikes of ice grew where the beam hit the floor.

When they had more time, he was going to have to ask Danny about this Undergrowth. Judging by the name and the obvious pun Danny made, who or whatever it was probably had plant-based powers. He briefly wondered if this Undergrowth could control people like Poison Ivy could.

Plasmus chuckled as he let another volley of batarangs harmlessly pass through him. Something in his demeanor changed as that pink energy began crackling around him. "How cute. But Daniel, did you really think something like that would stop me? Even with help from the Batman and his menagerie of children, you're struggling to land any hits. Let me demonstrate why you need my help." Plasmus began spinning in the air. Sparks of that pink energy increased and danced around his form.

Jason didn't like where this was going. The way the energy seemed to build, and the air around them went from still to a howling wind. Shit, it was way too much like attacks he'd seen from some of the speedsters. Knowing something needed to be done, he fired a few shots towards Plasmus, but the now swirling magenta energy deflected it.

The old man tried his hand, but he had a bit more luck. Using a more volatile type of batarang, he was able to cause an explosion as soon as the few he threw met Plasmus' energy. While it stopped Plasmus from continuing to spin, it forced an energy discharge that swept through the room. Jason had to plunge his knife into the floor to prevent himself from being knocked backwards.

Thankfully, the rest of the guests had been evacuated by then. He wasn't sure how many normal people would be able to handle that discharge without injury.

When he righted himself, he realized Plasmus grabbed Danny by the neck. There didn't seem to be any visible machine, but he did something that made Danny scream and convulse as if he'd been shocked. The whitish transformation ring Jason has seen only once before momentarily appeared around Danny's waist before fizzling out. Plasmus repeated the action causing Danny more pain.

The Pit snarled and spit as green tinged his vision followed by a momentary flash of something bright. He vaguely heard Bruce shout something as he rushed forward, but it didn't matter to him. He needed to wrench that bastard's hands off of Danny before shattering them. Was it possible to kill something that was already half dead? He should find out. The Pit seemed to like that idea as it surged through his body and gave him strength.

Plasmus gave him an arrogant grin as he flaunted the now limp teenager in his grip. He said something, but Jason wasn't interested in listening. Instead, he fired a shot directly at the man's head. Ah, he dodged, but he wouldn't do that for long. Jason fired a quick volley of shots, most of which hit, and the ghost seemed to stumble in the air. It was enough for him to drop the unresponsive teen.

He should have continued blasting Plasmus, but when he realized that Danny wasn't moving as fell, he wrenched his focus on to the teen. Skidding across the floor, he just barely caught the kid before he crashed. While the kid's eyes were open, they were unfocused, and he was shaking.

Seething, Jason raised his ecto-gun towards Plasmus, who floated about twenty feet above him wearing a smug grin. "Go ahead and try it," he hissed as he started to pull the trigger. Before he had a chance to follow through, Bruce forcibly changed the trajectory. "Fuck off! I'll kill him!"

"Hood, that's a duplicate." He blinked a few times as he registered what the old man said.

"I see you caught on to my ruse, or perhaps one of your children told you. Either way, I got at least one of the things I wanted tonight." Plasmus bowed before his form dissolved into nothing.

"That bastard." As much as he wanted to continue chasing Plasmus, he needed to stop and take care of Danny. The kid wasn't shaking as much as earlier, but his eyes were still unfocused. Once he was sure Danny was okay, he was going to brainstorm several revenge plots. Although he'd prefer to do that on his own, he should probably recruit his siblings. Sure, he could come up with some very intricate ways of torture on his own, but sometimes the others had ideas that would never have occurred to him. And with Bruce being Bruce, having his siblings help 'reign' him in would probably make the old man feel better about it.

"Anyways, how'd you know that was a duplicate?" he asked as he maneuvered Danny so he could carry the kid on his back since none of the others could safely touch him in his ghost form. He noted that Danny barely weighed anything. Hopefully, that was a side effect of being part ghost and not from being malnourished from the lack of edible food.

The old man raised an eyebrow. "You didn't hear Nightwing's report?"

"Sorry, the fact that I just watched a kid who was already killed once by electricity be electrocuted, twice, in front of me took precedence." He gritted his teeth as he brushed past Bruce. While he probably already figured he'd temporarily lost control, Jason wasn't going to give him the satisfaction of acknowledging it. Besides, he'd been able to come out of it very quickly this time without him murdering someone, not for lack of trying.

Bruce surprisingly didn't say anything in response. However, the way his eyes narrowed and how he ever so slightly pursed his lips suggested he was analyzing him.

"What the fuck's your problem?"

"And here I thought you could multitask better than that. Did those shocks from Masters' machine affect your hearing too?" Damian teased. That brat enjoyed the misfortune of his family a bit too much at times. It probably just reinforced his superiority complex.

He ignored the demon brat. But now that he had a moment to calm himself, that feeling in his chest from earlier seemed more pronounced than it was. If he wasn't imagining things, the Waters of the Pit seemed to be humming. Weird. That sensation was almost calming. He'd figure out why it was doing that later.

"While we work on getting Phantom to safety, what did the Golden Boy say?" he asked as he started moving towards the door to the ballroom.

"Masters appeared in his human form and inserted himself among the crowd when he had his duplicate attack," the old man explained.

"He gave himself an alibi. Fucker." With him appearing in the same place as his duplicate, that meant it would be much harder to prove Masters had done anything criminal. It was just like with Felipe Garzonas all over again minus the diplomatic immunity, but wealth often provided similar protection. It would make him just as hard to touch as Luthor, maybe even harder.

As much as he wanted, attempting to go after someone with no known criminal record would probably backfire on him. That meant he was going to have to withdraw and bide his time before he could do anything, and that pissed him off more. And even if the police check the tips they provided about the bodies underground, Masters might just overshadow them to get out of any trouble.

He'd find a way to destroy Masters, even if he'd have to dismantle the man's empire brick by brick to do it. That was a promise to himself and Danny. The kid obviously had a complicated relationship with Masters, but he shouldn't feel like the man was an ever-looming threat.

"Hood," Bruce's voice brought him out of his thoughts of revenge, "take Phantom and go out the back. You can take him back to the room. Orphan, go with him. Signal mentioned the G.I.W. have arrived."

Right. The assholes who would kill Danny on sight if they had the chance. "Understood."

Notes:

In Hush (the comic), Jason did get a hold of Tim and held a knife to his throat when he momentarily revealed himself to Bruce. And he did shoot Damian in the head. If I remember correctly, it's played off that Damian was just grazed.

In one of the more recent tellings of how Bruce and Jason met, it's shown Bruce legit abducted him, took him back to the Batcave, and tied him up. And Alfred questioned whether or not Bruce would be keeping him. Also, in Jason's flashback to that event in RHaTO, he attacks Bruce with a tire iron after being caught. I believe it's mentioned only in the original telling, but Jason stole the tires on the anniversary of the deaths of Bruce's parents. And the absurdity of it actually made Bruce laugh.

Dunno if this is common knowledge or not, but Alfred is referred to as Agent A in the field.

I think Jason's official height is 6ft, but heights vary between runs and artists. I personally headcannon that he's somewhere between 6'2" and 6'4". I've seen some posts on Tumblr HC him around 6'7" (6'7" is 2.01 meters). While I can confirm someone of that height can conceal carry an AK-47 with the right clothing (there are reasons I know this), it just doesn't feel right to me to have Jason quite that tall. Dick is usually considered to be 5'10" (I swear the boots add an inch or 2), but it again varies, and Bruce is 6'2".

Kicking doors open is quite fun. Unless a wolf spider falls on you.

The kind of whirlwind energy attack me trying to describe an attack Vlad did in "An eye for an Eye".

Felipe Garzonas is the diplomat Jason may or may not have pushed off a balcony during his time as Robin. Jason was frustrated they couldn't act immediately due to diplomatic immunity, and it's unclear if he actually did kill the man or he felt like Jason said he did. The "death in the family" arc starts immediately after this one (them dealing with Garzonas ended in Batman #425 and the events leading up to death in the family starts with Batman #426), and it's mentioned Jason was acting off (abnormally moody, aggressive, resentful, and reckless). This probably contributed to his frustrations with Garzonas.

Chapter 11 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/93287008>): **There's nothing like a trail of blood to find your way back home**

Notes:

Hope everyone's doing okay.

I've had a very strange 2 weeks. Full moons are terrifying in the medical world.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#) (#chapter_11_endnotes).)

Jason had a love-hate relationship with silence. Sometimes it was great when he needed to be away from annoying people or when a task needed extra attention. But at the same time, sometimes it allowed his mind to wander along dark paths that he didn't need to consider.

In this case, he needed some sort of noise, but he wasn't going to get it. Danny was still unresponsive, and Cass was naturally silent, a side effect of not being raised to talk growing up. In a situation like this, he'd usually make a few comments here or there, but he didn't currently trust himself to speak. He didn't need to work himself back into a rage venting about Vlad while he was keeping an eye on someone. So, he was just going to grit his teeth and pray he'd be able to meet up with the rest of them soon. Their banter would be a welcome distraction.

Thankfully, it didn't take long for Cass to lead him to an old exit that appeared to originally have been used as a servant entrance. Must have been the same one she and Duke used to enter in their initial reconnaissance.

He hadn't realized the building was old enough to have one. Either Vlad or the person before him must have done a heck of a lot of remodeling. Either way, it worked out for them.

When they exited the building, Jason noted they were at the tail end of what appeared to be an ornate garden. Good. It gave them plenty of cover on the off chance someone decided they wanted to check behind the building. While he wasn't entirely sure how incompetent the G.I.W. were, their weaponry was dangerous to Danny, and that by itself was grounds for avoiding them. Hopefully, Sam's parents would be able to keep them at bay again like they did earlier that day.

As they approached the brick wall along the property line, he barely had time to duck down to avoid a green blast. The Waters churned uneasily as he realized it wasn't responding the same as when a ghost or a halfa was nearby. With a jolt, he realized the blast had to have come from ecto-weaponry.

"Did I get him?" an excited voice boomed from the opposite side of the garden. Jason recognized that voice: it was Danny's father.

"I don't think so, Sweetie. We didn't hear any screams," his mother responded.

When did Danny's parents even get here? They didn't have any reports that the Fentons were on the premises. Or, at least he didn't think they did. He wasn't entirely certain what Dickie-bird reported to the old man. But, judging by the gesture from Cass, he hadn't mentioned the older Fentons.

But this presented a new problem. Those two probably had some sort of detection device which meant they could easily pinpoint Danny's location. Amity wasn't anything like Gotham. The buildings weren't all that tall, and, especially in the wealthier area, the buildings had quite the distance between them. It made grappling nearly impossible. That meant stealth was probably their best bet... unless he decided to steal a vehicle.

Actually, that might not be a bad idea. Bruce would probably bitch at him for it, but if he didn't manage to damage it... He should stop that line of thought. With his luck, that vehicle would be destroyed.

"What's wrong, Spook?" Jack shot his weapon again, but this one missed by a few yards. "Too scared to move? I don't blame you! You're up against the Fentons!"

"Jack, is it just me or does it seem like there's a second signature next to Phantom's?"

"Huh? There is! That means we'll get two for the price of one!"

Jason swore. With everything else that happened, he forgot the Fenton equipment could detect him too. Great. It'd be easier if Cass wasn't wearing her Deflector. He could have just handed Danny over to her and distracted the pair until she got the kid to safety, but that wasn't possible in this instance.

Cass caught his attention with a small gesture. She was going to distract them so he could take Danny to safety. He didn't like it. That should be his job, but Danny's safety was more important in this instance. But, the Fentons didn't seem interested in attacking humans so it was unlikely Cass would get hurt. So, with a hesitant nod, he agreed.

When Cass gave the signal, he began running as fast as he could to wall. While he did that, he could hear the telltale sound of a smoke bomb followed by some coughing. Simple and effective. And judging by the grunts, she also disarmed them.

As he reached the top of the wall, something grazed upper arm. Searing pain blossomed through his body. Shit. At least one of the Fentons had backup weaponry. Gritting his teeth, he did his best to ignore it as he jumped down and continued moving.

“Could really use some directions, Oracle.” Glancing around, he decided it would probably be safer to stay off the road for now.

Static momentarily filled his earpiece. “...Can you hear...? ...interference...” That was putting it lightly. It was as bad as the old TVs his school would use. Well, his old school before Bruce adopted him.

“Barely. Too much static.”

“...sent Nightwing... he... Orphan... you.”

“I’m hoping that means you’re giving them my coordinates.” More static answered him, but his phone dinged. Nice, Babs sent him the blueprints for Amity’s sewer system. Hopefully, this place didn’t have any villains in them like Gotham. He really didn’t need to run into this place’s version of Killer Croc.

Getting to the sewers proved to be trickier than he anticipated. The closest manhole cover was several blocks away, and, sometime between getting those coordinates and beginning to move, the Fentons moved to their probably not street legal tank. He’d seen and done some reckless driving over the years. But, Jack Fenton’s driving was something else.

The man didn’t seem to care if the vehicle was on or off the road. Fences? He apparently didn’t see them. The only things he actively avoided were the houses and trees, and even then, some of the trees were cut down with some sort of large spinning blade on a robotic arm. Seriously. How the military not contract them yet? Not even the Batmobile had something like that.

Dodging around another house, he took a moment to check his phone again. It was on the fritz too. The screen oddly pixilated on and off, but luckily, he could still read it. The sewer entrance was only two houses away.

As he made a break for it, he caught sight of a green flash. Above him, some sort of dome was beginning to form. It looked similar enough to what Vlad used to trap him in the mansion and the energy shield Danny made during the fight for his liking. If it was what he suspected it was, it’d trap him and Danny.

Caution be damned. He needed to move.

It looked like he was going to make it, but, of course, his luck couldn’t hold out. He was forced to change trajectory as several blasts came his way. Even without them hitting, it still cost him the precious few seconds he had to clear the growing dome. Cussing, he turned to see Danny’s parents running towards him with weapons drawn.

“Stop right there you odd manifestations of ectoplasmic energy and post-human consciousness!” Maddie Fenton charged him with what appeared to be a rifle-style ecto-weapon. Jack was following her but ended up tripping.

“Post-human? Excuse you. I don’t recall losing my humanity when I was forcefully brought back from the dead.” He was pretty sure Pit Madness and the augmentation caused by the Waters didn’t count as losing one’s humanity. Ra’s al Ghul was living proof of that. Man had bathed in those Waters how many times over the centuries, and he still counted as being human. Though, since there had been some reports those same Waters could create zombies, there was probably some sort of fine line he could consider later.

“That’s just what you want us to believe, Ghost!” Jack shouted as he finally reached his wife’s side. “I bet that’s why you’re not trying to fly! You’re just trying to appear human to trick us!”

Jason rolled his eyes, not that they could tell. “I don’t really care if you believe me or not, but here’s the thing.” He adjusted his stance to look as tall and threatening as he could while still having Danny on his back. “My job right now is to make sure this kid gets to safety. I don’t give a shit who you are or who you think you are, but if you attempt to lay a hand on him, you’re going to find out the hard way why you don’t touch someone under my protection.”

He really hoped they took the warning and backed down. If he understood Danny correctly, the kid didn’t want harm to come to his parents. So, if they decided to push their luck, he’d have to be extra careful in how he handled the situation.

Speaking of Danny, he was pretty sure he felt the kid twitch. Good. He was starting to come out of it.

Jack straightened his shoulders in response as he aimed his weapon at Jason. “No ghost talks to Jack Fenton like that!”

On the other hand, Maddie looked over him and frowned before putting her hand on her husband’s arm. If he wasn’t mistaken, her eyes kept drifting to the insignia on his chest. “Jack, something’s not right. Phantom seems unresponsive, and this new one isn’t doing any of the standard displays of aggression.”

“Standard display of aggression”? I don’t recall reading that anywhere in the briefing.” The Fentons turned to see Dick leaning against the closest house. Both of them jumped in alarm at his appearance. “Hood, do you know what they mean?”

For once, Jason was glad to hear the annoying voice of his brother. “I’m pretty sure they want me to stand in a bed sheet and yell ‘boo’.”

“I could see you doing that. Just make sure not to use the good sheets,” Dick teased as moved closer. He tilted his head and frowned. “What’s with the blue? Did you decide to take after me? Can’t really keep call you ‘Red Hood’ if you’re not wearing red.”

“And risk dying a second time? I’m not that stupid.” One of the first things they learned after being brought to the manor was that the bed sheets were to be used for no other purpose than being put on a bed. There was only one exception, and that was if they needed to be used for first aid purposes, if, and only if, there was no other alternative available. Disobeying Bruce was one thing, but disobeying Alfred was another.

But what did Dick mean by blue? Sure, he borrowed some of his clothes a while back when he was impersonating him, but he wasn’t going to do that again. That costume was much tighter than he anticipated. He knew Dick wasn’t as tall or broad as him so why did he think that was a good idea in the first place? “Do you really think I had time to change costumes? You must be going blind in your old age.”

During their exchange, Jack Fenton pointed at Dick and bounced excitedly. “Look, Mads! It’s one of the heroes from Gotham! Uh, Batwing!”

Jason snorted as Dick gave the man a flat look. "It's Nightwing."

While Jack seemingly ignored the correction, Maddie raised her weapon. "Ghosts are nothing but obsessive shadows of who they formerly were. People who side with them have either fallen for their tricks and lies or are possessed. So, which one is it?"

Dick glanced at him. "So, have you pulled any tricks on me recently?"

"Besides greasing some of your gymnastics equipment? No."

"That was you? I face planted because of that!"

"Guess you need to work on your grip." Even after so many years, Dick was still the most flexible out of them. Jason guessed the circus training never really went away. But he did have a habit of showing off, so every once in a while, either Jason or one of the others pulled a prank on him in an attempt to get him to mess up. The best ones were when they never even messed with the equipment and just distracted him enough to fall.

Apparently, Maddie Fenton didn't appreciate their banter as she fired a warning shot near their feet. "Seeing as you're friendly with him, I'm going to assume you're either possessed or possibly a ghost yourself."

"Wait, that could explain the impossible moves we've seen him do on the news! Or how he's recovered from all the reported injuries! It's because he's a ghost! Does that mean Batman's a ghost too?" Jack rambled. "What about the other heroes? Some of them are aliens sure, but is that just a cover for some of the others? What about metahumans?"

Jason shared a disbelieving look with his brother. Did these people really think that anything outside the realm of normal meant that ghosts were involved? They called ghosts obsessive, but this was something else.

Was it possible they were like him and contaminated with ectoplasm? Either Danny or Jazz had mentioned their parents had been working in paranormal sciences since college. So, between the amount of time and their lax safety measures, it was more than possible.

He was going to have to have a long talk with Bruce. Between the concerns of the Fentons' health and the very real risk their skills in weapon development could be exploited, they were going to have to keep a close eye on the family. But that was something that would have to wait until after he got Danny to safety.

"We should look into that once we're done with our initial studies," Maddie agreed as she fired an easily dodged shot at them.

"Oh boy! I can't wait to dissect these spooks!" Jack's childlike excitement sent an involuntary shiver down Jason's back. While it wasn't the first time he'd encountered someone more interested in research than the safety of the subjects, it was the first time he'd seen someone talk about dissection with a smile like that.

"Want me to distract them while you escape?" Dick whispered as he moved his hands towards his escrima sticks.

"Can't," he replied as he dodged another blast, this time from Jack. "Phantom isn't going to be able to pass through that dome. I'm not sure if I can either. Would have to get their vehicle and turn off its power source first." After considering it a moment, he amended, "Actually, dismantling it is probably a better idea unless B decides he wants to take it."

"Right. Change of plans then." Instead of his sticks, Dick retrieved a pair of bolas and glanced at him.

After Jason's slight nod of approval, the two of them moved in opposite arcs around the Fentons. Jack seemed to focus solely on him, but Maddie surprised him. While it was mentioned in the file they had on her she had martial arts training, her awareness of the situation and how she moved in response suggested she might be far more familiar with combat than they originally thought. That would also have to be investigated later.

When Jack sent another blast towards him and Danny, Dick took his chance to let loose one of his bolas. Maddie cried out in alarm as she tried to dodge, but Jack didn't notice it in time. The large man had just enough time to look perplexed before toppling over. Maddie, on the other hand, managed to impressively dodge Dick's second bolas.

For a moment, Jason debated on firing a rubber bullet at her. While it should be fine, there was always a chance it could cause serious harm. Even if he hit her leg or arm, the force could end up breaking bones. Even the minor explosives he still had could be very dangerous to her. He could try a smoke bomb. That did seem to trip them up before, but it wouldn't change the status of that green dome. There was also the chance it could hinder them more since the Fenton equipment did allow them to get a hit on him earlier.

Maybe he should start listening to Bruce and start carrying more non-lethal containment methods with him. Or not. It wasn't like it was going to help him in the current situation.

Fuck it. Rubber bullets it was. While Maddie still had her back turned towards Dick, Jason quickly unholstered his weapon and fired two quick shots at both hers and Jack's guns. Both shots hit true. Maddie's was knocked from her hand, and both hers and the one Jack dropped where visible damaged by the bullet. Unexpected, but nice. The sound had the added bonus of causing a momentary distraction.

Dick took the brief moment to knock Maddie out before giving him a sour look as he used some of the cord he kept to restrain her. Jason just gave him a cheeky grin in response while starting to race towards the Fenton tank as Jack starting yelling threats. Dick would catch up eventually.

As he dodged around the house and caught sight of the vehicle, he found a sight that nearly stopped him in his tracks due to the absurdity of it. Orphan could be seen in the open door while Danny's friend, Tucker, was hesitantly trying to explain that he could help. He'd been wondering where Cass was. Sam was also there keeping watch and occasionally hissing at him to hurry up.

"If he can get rid of that dome, let him help," he called out making the three of them watch his approach. "Nightwing's coming."

"What did you do to him?"

Tucker put his arm out in front of Sam, who looked furious enough to attack. "What do you need? I don't know what's currently happening, but between the news and Sam, I know Plasmus did something." Although he kept his tone even, the teen stiff posture and uneasy frown gave away his nervousness. Danny really did have some good friends.

Jason nodded as he kept an eye on Sam. “Look, I don’t have time for this. We’re trying to him out of the area. Plasmius shocked him, and he’s only just starting to respond again. Both the Fentons and the GIW are nearby, and the Fentons have been tracking him.”

“And just how were you going to get out of here?” Sam demanded as Tucker hopped into the vehicle next to Cass and began pressing buttons. Whatever he did worked as the dome began disappearing.

“Sewer.” When the girl gave him a deadpan stare, he rolled his eyes and entered through the side door of the tank. She followed him and angrily hovered as he gently sat Danny down on one of the seats. “Look, I know us heroes are supposed to have all these ingenious answers and shit like that, but sometimes, the best answer is also the simplest one. We have limited movement here compared to Gotham so we’re working with what we have.”

“Sam, lay off. Danny’s safety is more important right now.” When she huffed, Tucker sighed apologetically. “Don’t mind her, she’s just worried. Would you guys like a lift? Both Sam and I are pretty familiar with Fenton tech.” While he tried to give a reassuring grin, it wavered a bit.

“If you can pilot this monster and put distance between it and the Fentons, I’m in.”

“I’m sorry, what are we doing?” Dick must have caught the end of the conversation as he appeared in the tank, making Sam and Tucker jump. Cass gave a couple silent chuckles at their response.

“Looks like we’re stealing a car tonight after all.”

“Were you seriously considering that earlier?”

“It’s not like it would have been the first time.”

“You know, I should probably be worried about professional heroes openly talking about car theft.” Tucker was watching them carefully with his hand hovering over the panel on the dashboard.

“You can worry about it later,” he mentioned with a roll of his eyes as his siblings shook their heads. “Right now, we need you to drive.”

Tucker surprisingly did know how to drive the tank, which Jason learned was actually called the Ghost Assault Vehicle. Having him drive it ended up being a blessing in disguise as he was able to get them closer to the hotel at a much faster pace than they would have been able to on foot, deciding that the halfway point would probably suffice. Tucker also offhandedly mentioned he’d be able to temporarily hack the system and completely shut it down so the Fentons wouldn’t be able to do much until they could get back into it.

It also gave Dick enough time to stubbornly demand to check the still burning wound on his arm. According to him, it appeared to be a nasty burn. When he wanted to clean it, Jason moved away, reminding him he still had that damned belt on. With everything else that happened, he had no desire to get shocked again.

That started an argument, excuse him, discussion about whether or not Dick should remove the belt. Without the necessary context behind it, Danny’s friends might have gotten a few wildly inaccurate assumptions about them, even after Dick specified they were talking about the Specter Deflectors. And to make it worse, between all of their equipment, there was no way Babs didn’t have a recording of that conversation. It was going to be used as blackmail. That was fact.

Once they were dropped off by Tucker, the trip through the sewers actually went well. Sure, they weren’t as big as the ones in Gotham, but they were relatively well maintained and didn’t appear to contain any supervillains. Though, Jason was almost certain he caught a couple glimpses of glowing rats. The Pit didn’t seem to react to them, and they didn’t show any hostility, so they were pretty far down on his list of worries.

In a surprising stroke of luck, there was a tunnel from the sewer system to the hotel they could use. Bruce and Duke were waiting for them when they emerged and led them through the emergency stairwell back towards their hotel room. He and Dick gave a brief summary of events with Cass adding a couple words here and there.

During the short trek, Duke kept sending glances his way. It was clear something was bothering him, but he didn’t want to talk about it. Was it because of Danny? Or was there something else? He’d worry about it later.

Thanks to Tim, they didn’t have to worry about the hotel security catching them moving. It was honestly refreshing to be able to enter a room in his gear without having to use a window. Speaking of the replacement, him and the demon brat seemed to have been discussing something with Steph and Babs over one of the computers when they walked in.

Deciding that wasn’t currently any of his business, he announced he was going to put Danny on one of the beds. Bruce nodded at him as Tim got up to follow in case any first aid was needed.

After getting the kid on the bed, Jason ripped off his goggles and mask and threw them on one of the plush chairs in the room. It had been one hell of a day, and after everything, they hadn’t really accomplished anything other than getting some new bruises. At least Danny was currently out of danger.

Glancing at the kid, he noticed that the dazed and unfocused expression had softened. It now appeared he was resting. Good. He could relax a little.

That might have been a bad idea. As soon as he loosened some of the tension in his shoulders, exhaustion like he’d never felt before washed over his body. He managed to take one step before something bright filled his vision before darkness overwhelmed him.

Notes:

I already briefly mentioned the time Jason impersonated Dick as Nightwing. But as a side note, I have heard that one of Jason's Red Hood costumes after starting to redeem himself was in part created by using parts of some of Dick's. Can't seem to

find the panels in question though. Edit: someone was kind enough to point out that occurred during RHaTH (2012).

Also, I could have sworn I got a comment asking if Danny's accident is canonically an electrocution or not. I have no idea where this comment went, or if I imaged it. Gonna answer it anyways. It's not explicitly stated in the show, but due to how it was portrayed in the opening and 'Memory Blank' most of us in the Phandom do believe it was some form of an electrocution. As a side note, there's a lot of debate on what ectoplasm might be. It's one of those things that seem to exist in any form it needs to be in the show. But, if it was in a true plasma form in the portal, then there's more credence to the electrocution idea as in scientific experimentation plasma is often either electrically charged or superheated. Ectoplasm is actually mentioned in parapsychology and paranormal studies, but all supposed photos of it during the spiritual craze in the 1800s/1900s are staged.

If it's not obvious, gun shots are very loud and can damage the hearing. The closer you are to it firing and the smaller the area where it went off (like a small room or car) the more likely it is to cause disorientation. If you're at a normal shooting range, the workers will not let you go into the room without ear protection because of how damaging that sound can be.

Hilariously, I recently realized that I can ultimately blame the creation of this fic on cosplay. A former friend coaxed me into cosplaying as the Red Hood as she wanted to cosplay Nightwing a while back which reintroduced me to the Bat Family, and things progressed. I have proof on my Tumblr.

Still taking suggestions for chapter titles. I'm currently going the song lyric approach which has led me to realize how many Avenged Sevenfold songs work really well with the Bat Family and their rogues in general. And random fun fact, in the 2021 Nightwing Annual #1, a flashback shows Jason is both a Slipknot and Lacuna Coil fan per the posters on his wall.

Chapter 12 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/93617506>): **Among the Broken Mirrors I Don't Look the Same**

Notes:

How am I not done with this fic yet? It's over 100 pages in Word. Also, be prepared for possible feels.

Please make sure to check out the end of chapter notes. Both impyssadobsessions and elle-mrly on Tumblr made amazing artwork for this fic! Much love and thanks to them!!! That's where the links to their art will be.

One last thing, I just got promoted at work, and I have no idea what my new schedule will be yet so the next chapter might be delayed.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#) (#chapter_12_endnotes).)

Jason's head was pounding as he came to, and his arms felt like someone tied lead weights to them. Groaning slightly, he sat up and glanced around. He was back in the hotel room and on one of the beds. He didn't remember going to bed. Was he just that tired? Or had he passed out? Judging by the fact his red vest was on the same chair as his mask, it was probably the latter. Great.

But what happened before that? His last memory was making sure Danny was safe... Shit! Was the kid okay?

Bolting upright, he ended up hissing in pain as his arm throbbed. A quick glance told him someone must have given him first aid as the place where the Fentons grazed him was bandaged. That must have been worse than he thought it was if it was still bothering him like that.

"I don't think Batman wants you to get up yet." Glancing over, he found Danny in his human form sitting on the other bed. His smile seemed forced, and he wouldn't look up. "The others filled me in. Thanks for, uh, helping me and not hurting my parents."

He nodded. "Are you okay? Whatever Plasmus hit you with..."

"It's fine," Danny cut him off as he rubbed the back of his neck. "He's done the same thing before. Guess he just put more power behind it this time. But see," he transformed into Phantom, "I'm all good. I have a few bruises, sure, but that's a lot better than I normally get from fights."

"Do you hear yourself?" Jason swung his legs over the edge of the bed to more comfortably face the teen. Everything hurt.

Danny shrunk back a little as he returned to his human form. "It's fine."

"No, it's not fine." He pushed his bangs back before bringing both of his hands to rest on his legs. "That shock triggered a freeze response, a traumatic response, in you. You were completely unresponsive. What if the G.I.W., or God forbid, your parents managed to do something similar?"

"But it wasn't them. It was Vlad, and as fruit loop-y as he is, he's not going to kill me."

"Danny," Jason sighed before continuing, "look... you know I got murdered as a teen. I thought with all the training I had I'd be able to get out of any situation, and even if I couldn't, Batman would swoop in at the last second. I was a hero, and heroes always win." He gripped his hands as he continued. "When you fight the same people again and again with the same result, you can start to forget how dangerous they really are."

"I'll fully admit I let myself fall into a trap, that I didn't realize I got manipulated until it was too late. And in those final moments, I knew no one was coming. I knew I was going to die alone." He glanced at Danny as he let himself have a small pause to make sure he kept his emotions under control. The kid's eyes had widened, and his complexion paled. "So many of us get wrapped up in the chance to play hero that we forget the dangers. Even if we have a mentor, sometimes we still end up as cannon fodder for a crusade that was never ours."

That was one of the reasons he couldn't get rid of some of the resentment he had towards Bruce. Even after losing a Robin, he still took on and trained more kids for the role. No matter how talented, kids shouldn't be on the front line. They shouldn't be

fighting criminals and risking their lives. And for some fucking reason, he couldn't get Bruce to either acknowledge or understand it. But those were thoughts for later.

As an uneasy silence began to fall between them, there was a knock before the door opened to reveal Bruce, still in costume. They momentarily stared at each other before the others, led by Dick, brushed passed him and into the room. Although Damian elected to stay near the door, the others came over to poke and prod at him. No one seemed to be wearing the Deflectors as he wasn't getting shocked, but it still didn't mean he liked it.

Cussing, he ended up standing in an attempt to better fend them off. What was their deal anyways? He was fine, or at least he was pretty sure he was fine. Did something in his appearance change from whatever Vlad did to him? He better not have more white hair.

All thoughts and everyone else's actions screeched to a halt when his arm accidentally went through Cass' chest. He stared in dawning horror that he could feel the sensation of her heart beating and the motions of the lungs and surrounding muscle as she breathed. Oh fuck. Oh fuck. Oh fuck. What was he supposed to do? He needed to remove it, but what if he accidentally damaged her heart or lungs? What if he got stuck? What would that do?

"Panicking will make it worse." Danny's voice was soft and sullen as he came over and gently touched his arm. Just like when the kid made them both invisible at Vlad's mansion, he could feel Danny's energy wash over the intangible limb. Seconds later, he had them safely separated. Cass tentatively checked the area for a moment before giving a reassuring smile. It didn't make him feel better.

Bruce cleared his throat, getting everyone's attention. He wanted to talk so that meant everyone needed to pick a spot and stop fussing. Danny frowned in confusion at the sudden change, so Jason gestured for him to have a seat.

Once that was settled, he decided to sit on the floor using the bed he woke up on as a back rest. Well, that was what he planned on doing. It was like it wasn't even there as he fell backwards. He blinked a few times in confusion as he realized he was staring at the underside of the bed. He had fallen through it. What even was his life at this point? "I can't wait 'til this shit stops."

"Are you okay?" Duke questioned as feminine laughter could be heard throughout the room. Sounded like Stephanie. Bruce must have set up communications.

"Oh yeah, I just love counting the ungodly number of dust bunnies under beds." After pulling himself out from under the bed, he once again tried to lean against it. This time it worked. "Guess that's how I got under there yesterday." He glanced at Dick. "That means you're off the hook, this time."

"That's happened to me more times than I can count," Danny admitted while trying to suppress a smile. "It was really bad in the month following my accident, and me panicking every time didn't help. I don't have a clue how I managed hide all my slip ups from my parents or my classmates."

"Anyways, what was that about?" Jason asked he eyed his siblings as he rubbed his chest. That weird, concentrated feeling of the Pit was still there. "Is something glowing again?"

"I knew you were dense, Todd, but this level of unawares is almost impressive." Damian gave an arrogant smirk, impressed with his own insult.

Bruce frowned at the brat before focusing his attention on Jason. "What do you remember from last night?"

"Let's see, Plasmius decided to play puppeteer in ballroom." He glanced at Danny. "Did Glowstick tell you guys what he said?"

"Yeah," Babs affirmed with an irritated huff. "We're already working on how to upgrade our systems so that doesn't happen again. We have one of the most, if not most, secure computers in the world, and a ghost can bypass everything just by possessing it. It's frustrating."

"It also paints the data Vlad had on various heroes and criminals in a new light," Tim added as he typed on his wrist computer. "We thought he'd gathered that on his own. So, now we're trying to see if there are any independent systems where he might have stored more information as well as prepping for any potential fallout."

Jason nodded before giving a quick summary of the events after getting out of the ballroom and up to when he set Danny on the bed. When he mentioned the pod, he couldn't repress a shiver. That thing was going to haunt his dreams for a while. "I don't think there's anything else. Am I missing something?"

"Did Plasmius tell you what he was trying to do to you?" Bruce pressed.

Jason could tell something the old man was hiding something, and it made him uneasy. "He was unhappy about my lack of ghostliness and thought I might have an incomplete or inactive core. He wanted to fix that." He could still feel echoes of the burning pain across his skin from being submerged in Pit water again.

Danny seemed to wince on his behalf. "Well, on the bright side, Vlad didn't try duplicating his own accident on you. That involved cola contamination, a blast to the face with a proto-portal, and ecto-acne."

"What the fuck, Glowstick?" he asked after a moment of stunned silence.

The kid shrugged. "Ectoplasm can do a lot of weird things to normal people and objects. I already told you my parents managed to bring food to life with it on accident when they modified the microwave and oven. I think they finally learned not to use it on turkeys and chicken after the multiple times they've tried taking over the house, but my dad did somehow befriend the franken-wiennies. They're now part of the home security."

"You know, just when I think I can't be surprised anymore..." Dick murmured while he ran his hands over his face. Tim nodded in agreement.

"I probably shouldn't ask, but what did they do with the undead food? You didn't eat them, did you?" It looked like Stephanie scooted closer to the screen as she waited for the answer.

"My parents did. Jazz and I ordered take out."

Everyone, including Bruce, showed or vocalized some sort of disgust. But if Maddie and Jack really would eat stuff like that, then maybe they really did have some form of ectoplasmic contamination. Funny, he never would have thought food would be the potential cause.

“Back to the matter at hand,” Bruce eyes wept around the room before focusing on Jason, “you’re not aware of anything abnormal?”

“Did you forget I got stuck in a table? That’s pretty abnormal, if you ask me.”

Stephanie openly snickered. “Did he really? Oracle, you’ve got to show me the video of that!”

“Spoiler.”

“Alright, alright.” Some of Steph’s excitement vanished at Bruce’s admonishment. “I can watch it later.”

“B, I really don’t think he knows,” Tim stretched his arms as he spoke. “It’s probably best to show him the footage.”

Now on edge, Jason took the laptop Dick handed him while their siblings and Danny crowded around him. The screen was split between the four feeds from when they were fighting Plasmius. Babs must have hit play on her end as the recordings started. Everything seemed normal. So why...?

When Plasmius shocked Danny, that’s where things changed. The visual feed from his equipment went out while the other three momentarily glitched. When the three feeds corrected, he noticed he looked different. The red parts of his costume appeared blue, and his boots and knee pads looked off. At first, he thought it was part of the glitch, but no one else looked different.

He glanced down at his shirt. His symbol was definitely red, and he distinctly remembered when he looked at his vest earlier, it was also still red. A growing sense of dread filled the pit of his stomach as Babs changed it to just Cass’ feed when they were escaping.

In the dark, it almost appeared as if he was glowing faintly. It had to be from him carrying Danny, but as the feed was switched to Dick’s, he realized it was slightly different than the kid’s. He also noted the injury on his arm and how it wasn’t bleeding. Instead, it was oozing an unnatural green substance.

The feed once again changed to when Tim watched him put Danny on the bed. When he pulled down his hood, white hair with a black streak was now visible, and when the mask was removed, glowing green eyes could be briefly seen before the feed glitched again. When the distortion cleared, his unconscious form could be seen looking as normal as always.

No... No. No. NO! Fuck no! It couldn’t be. It was supposed to be temporary! Things were supposed to go back to normal.

This was Plasmius’ fault. He knew. He saw. That’s why he said he got something he wanted. That fucker did this to him.

The Pit churned uneasily in response to his inner turmoil. With a jolt, he realized why it felt more concentrated than before. That... that was his core. What did that mean? Did it replace his heart? No, he could still feel that pounding in his chest. That was one good thing, he guessed.

But what was this going to mean for him? Having unstable abilities made anyone a liability, but there was also Bruce to contend with. Things still weren’t great between them, and there was a very real possibility he could get blamed for crimes he had nothing to do with. While he knew he brought that lack of trust on himself, he was trying to stay on the lighter side of gray, but Bruce’s paranoia could get the better of him at times. Then there was the temptation it’d bring. He might have to leave Gotham for a long time, maybe even permanently.

Then there was the planning. They’d have to figure out what to do if someone else found out and gained control of him to hurt the others. Should he hide it from Roy and Kori? It’d probably be safer, but at the same time, if he didn’t and it was used against him to hurt them...

His world was falling apart. Wait, no, he was actually starting to fall through the floor. There was a flutter of confusion as someone grabbed the computer off him before at least two people hoisted him up by the arms. Breaking out of their grips, he found his siblings staring at him with concern or pity or amusement. He didn’t know at this point. He just needed to leave.

“I’m... I’m going to go smoke.” Not caring he was technically still in uniform, he brushed past Bruce, who didn’t try to stop him. He grabbed the jacket he knew had his cigarettes and headed towards the roof.

“Did the old man send you?” Jason questioned as he lit another cigarette. He’d already gone through five of them as he sat and tried to quiet his chaotic mind.

“No, I decided to come on my own.” Danny sounded like he was sitting on top of stairwell. “I think the others aren’t sure what to do.”

“That’d be a first.” Technically, that was a lie, but they were all pros at improvising until something worked in their favor.

Unlike their previous rooftop conversation, the silence wasn’t comforting. Maybe it was because, while he never openly voiced it, the kid was hoping for a similar outcome, even if it wasn’t what Jason wanted. It wasn’t like anyone else really understood his reality, save for Plasmius. Just thinking about that bastard made the Pit whisper, stirring thoughts of punishment and revenge. No, he wasn’t going down that road. Not right now anyways.

Eventually, he couldn’t deal with it anymore and put out his cigarette. “This isn’t going to go away, is it?”

“No, it won’t.” There was a hesitant pause before Danny quietly added. “And I know from experience trying to go back to normal turns out badly.”

“Of fucking course.” He stared up at the sky and sighed. “Just when things were finally getting better, karma or whatever decides to punch me in the gut. Wait... What?” Did Danny say what he thought he said? “You tried...?”

The teen didn’t answer immediately. Instead, he slid off the roof of the stairwell and sat next to him. “Yeah. I was brought up being told that ghosts are malicious and evil. That they’d do anything to hurt the living.” His gaze was distant. “My parents used to joke that if something ever happened to me or Jazz and we came back as ghosts, that they’d make sure to destroy us before we had a chance to hurt anyone. I think they thought it was comforting.”

“That’s pretty messed up.”

"I guess. It was just part of life growing up, but then the accident happened." Danny momentarily gripped his jeans, probably due to the memory. "I was terrified. Suddenly, I had all these powers and no way to control them. I didn't even know if I was still alive or just pretending to be. And according to my parents, I was supposed to be evil. I think some part of me took responsibility for the others ghosts just to prove I wasn't evil."

The kid leaned back and stared upwards. "Sam and Tucker were there when it happened. If... if it wasn't for them, I might have gone crazy. There were times I even debated letting my parents know so they could fix me. Even though I'm pretty sure now they would have accepted me, the 'what ifs' stopped me. Hearing your parents talk about dissecting you isn't exactly comforting. Besides, it's just been easier to keep them in the dark."

"My friends tried to do their best to get me to think positively about the situation. I mean, who doesn't dream about being a superhero when they're little at least once? But they didn't understand how hard it was. Between trying to hide my powers and the sleepless nights trying to stop the ghosts coming from the Portal, I was struggling. I just wanted everything to go back to normal, and only worry about normal teenage things and work my butt off in school so I could get into NASA and become an astronaut..." He sighed before continuing. "My parents once invented something that could separate ectoplasm from almost anything. I tried that, but it didn't go well. It split me into two incomplete bodies."

When he grimaced at the mental image, Danny backtracked. "Oh! No, no, no! According to Sam and Tucker, we looked okay, but it wasn't exactly a perfect split between human and ghost, and our personalities were all screwed up. My memories from that are really fuzzy so I can't really explain it better, but I'm pretty sure the mostly human me rode a vacuum cleaner at one point. I should ask Tucker about that. If anyone has video of it, it's him."

"You know... I think something like that once happened to Big Blue..." Jason was pretty sure he'd previously read through files referencing a red and blue Superman. "But Bats and the others have dealt with alternative universes, so I'm not completely sure if that happened to ours or a different one."

"Big blue?"

"Oh, Superman. You wouldn't think it, but him and Bats are friends."

Danny's mouth dropped open as his eyes widened in shock. After a moment, he seemed to realize he was staring. "I don't know why I'm surprised. Batman is a member of the Justice League, and you and the others have probably met a bunch of other heroes. I've always wanted to meet Martian Manhunter. I mean, he's from Mars! How cool is that?"

Despite himself, Jason chuckled as Danny launched into an explanation of what fascinated him about space. It was nice to see some of the wariness he carried behind his eyes and smile momentarily melt away. He really had been forced into a situation he shouldn't have been. Maybe he could hint to Bruce to introduce the kid to J'onn. Their abilities had some similarities after all.

Oh, that applied to him now too. Fuck. He was going to have to figure out how this whole thing worked. And knowing Bruce, he was going to do everything in his power to keep him in the manor until he wasn't a danger to himself or the others due to an accidental slip up, especially with what happened earlier.

"Huh? Sorry, I got distracted." He hadn't realized he got lost in his thoughts until Danny waved a hand in front of his face.

"It's cool. Things are probably really weird for you right now." A troubled expression crossed his face. "I was talking about how things were at first and how I wanted to have things go back to normal... For a while, I tried to ignore everything. That backfired."

"What do you mean?"

"For us, our human side gives extra energy to our cores, and if it's not used, you might find yourself unintentionally sinking through furniture or having an invisible arm for hours. It sucks." Danny raised his hand and formed a small crystal in it.

"That's ice, right? Saw you use it against Plasmius."

"Yep, but I can make more than ice." He mischievously grinned as a snowball formed in his hand. "Catch!"

Jason barely had enough time to prevent it from hitting his face, but that didn't stop some of the snow from getting in his hair or on his clothes. "At least I know who to bring with me the next time some decides I need to join a snowball fight."

"Nice, right?" Danny's smile faded again. "This is probably the power that gives me the most trouble. If I don't use or practice with it a couple times a week, I risk freezing myself solid."

"Are you telling me your powers could kill you?" This kid was going to turn more of his hair white. That was an extremely important bit of information to know.

"Maybe?" He rubbed the back of his neck. "Look, I don't really know if I can properly die or not. It's not really something I've wanted to test. But, from talking to Frostbite and some of the other ghosts who have been around a while, it's really only an issue for stronger ghosts with elemental cores. You don't currently have one, so you don't have to worry about it."

"Don't currently have one..." Jason repeated as he ran his hands over his face. "Glowstick, I can barely wrap my mind around having a normal one or whatever. I don't need to think about it changing or whatever down the line right now."

"You know, if you're going to continue calling me that, I need to give you a nickname too, at least one better than Skunkhead." Danny tapped his foot for a moment. "Hmm... maybe Antares or Naos."

"What are you calling me?" He wasn't familiar with either word, but neither sounded like an insult. He was going to have to remember to look those up later.

"Don't worry about." Danny stood and stretched his back. A few pops could be heard. Once he was done, he turned and grinned. "How about we go flying? It'll help take your mind off things, and there's nothing quite like it. What do you say?"

Notes:

Fun Danny did ride a vacuum around his room in Identity Crisis. No clue why I remember that.

So, Superman Red and Superman Blue are a thing - same person split into 2. First appeared in a 'what if' type story in 1963 (Superman #162). The most famous version is from 1998 where it's a one shot. The 90s were a weird time in comics. Also don't know if this is still canon either.

Antares and Naos are the names of stars. Antares is a red star in Scorpio, and the name means 'opponent to Ares(Mars)'. Naos is a blue star that's part of the constellation Puppis which is one of three constellations that represent the ship Argo that was used by Jason and the Argonauts.

Here are the links!!!

jaxOnarts (formerly elle-mrly) made a full image of Jason's ghost form:

<https://at.tumblr.com/jax0narts/sketch-and-lineart-heavily-inspired-it-basically/uk92acuaczfq>

<https://at.tumblr.com/jax0narts/finished-product-of-the-jason-todd-halfa-concept/m9miwts1anpo>

impyssadobsessions drew 2 separate scenes from chapter 11:

<https://impyssadobsessions.tumblr.com/post/677503889641275392/what-i-originally-was-going-to-draw-keke-i>

<https://impyssadobsessions.tumblr.com/post/677414230385917952/i-didnt-mean-to-leave-this-messy-but-i-loved-how>

Chapter 13 (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/34733752/chapters/93790114>): **And the Answer Lies Between Good and Bad**

Notes:

A wild chapter appears! I was hoping I'd finish this before 4am. No such luck

More artwork links down at the bottom! This time from Tumbling-Darkling and crazydemigod666!

Edit: I've had enough comments about this to warrant a blanket statement. I chose blue for Jason's ghost form because the color inverse of red is cyan. Yes, green is the opposite color of red and can be argued as well, but I personally didn't think it fit as well.

(See the end of the chapter for [more notes \(#chapter_13_endnotes\)](#).)

It took quite a bit for Danny to finally coax Jason into agreeing to fly with him. He didn't want to admit the concept scared him. He could pilot an aircraft with the best of them and maneuver the skyscrapers of Gotham like it was nothing. But flying without aid? No, that wasn't something he was supposed to be able to do.

But Danny did make a good point that it would be good practice. He probably should get some in before returning to Gotham and dealing with whatever bullshit regimen Bruce decided to design for him to get everything under control.

First thing he had to do was switch to his ghost form which proved to be annoyingly harder than Danny made it out to be. The kid could do it without much effort, but he couldn't really find the words to describe how it worked since he never really had to walk anyone through it before.

But, Jason had done it once already, so hypothetically, he should be able to do it again. Per the recordings, that happened when Plasmius grabbed hold of Danny. Just picturing it made his blood boil and the Pit stir. Or maybe it wasn't exactly the Pit anymore. Doing the one thing he'd sworn to not purposely do, he focused on that feeling.

A bright light momentarily filled his vision. In alarm, he pushed his back against the wall of the staircase, but there didn't seem to be any sign of danger. Unsure what to make of it, he checked himself over. He seemed okay, but why was he wearing his vest? That was still in the room, and why was it blue?

"You did it!" Jason looked over at Danny, who seemed to be trying to not to laugh. "I have no idea what you've gone through in Gotham to be that jumpy over a flash of light though."

"You don't want to know..." He murmured as he continued his examination. Overall, he didn't feel too different with one major exception. Unlike in the hotel room where he could still easily feel his heartbeat, it was mostly masked by the humming sensation of his core. He didn't particularly like it, but he guessed he was going to have to get used to it.

Running his hand over his face, he realized he was wearing his mask. It wasn't there a moment ago. Confused, he removed it to find it was also the wrong color, but as he held it, it began to sublime causing him to drop it. "What the fuck?"

"It's okay. That happens to this too if something rips a piece off," Danny explained as pulled at his suit. "When you revert back, it seems to reset everything, and it'll be back next time. I'm not exactly sure how it works."

"Right... Is there anyway to change this?" He gestured to himself.

"I know there is because Plasmius wasn't wearing that stupid getup when he got blasted in the face, but I haven't really experimented with it."

That was definitely something he'd have to investigate later. Just like the others, he was constantly updating his equipment and uniforms. It might end up being a fun project down the road to see what could and couldn't be changed, especially the blue. He wasn't sure how he felt wearing his brother's color again.

"Anyways," Danny gave a childish grin as he began to float, "let's get you in the sky."

Although Jason didn't want to admit it, Danny was right. There was a freeing feeling he hadn't experienced in a long time as the kid pulled him through the air by the arm. While it didn't quiet all of the turmoil in his mind, it helped.

At first, their flight was entirely Danny's doing, saying he just wanted to get him used to the feeling, but after a while, he could tell at least some of the lift, levitation... whatever the correct term was, came from him. The kid seemed to notice it too and gave him a knowing grin but didn't let go. That was oddly reassuring.

Their flight was cut short when Danny received a phone call from his sister. It didn't last long, but she sounded distressed. Once he was done, Danny sighed before asking, "What did you guys do? My parents now think Batman and the other heroes are ghosts."

"Don't look at me. They came to that conclusion when Nightwing came to help. According to them, gymnastics are inhuman, or at least that's what they made it sound like."

"You've got to be kidding me!" Danny let go of him as threw his hands in the air. While secretly happy he wasn't plummeting to his second, or would it technically the third, death, Jason didn't want to risk moving and having that change.

"Next thing you know, they're going to plan a ghost hunting trip to Gotham and get themselves hurt because they've convinced themselves that... Oh, I don't know, Poison Ivy or the Joker, or someone else is a ghost, and that they can handle it." Danny's shoulders sagged as he muttered. "Looks like me and Jazz will have to sabotage their work for a while again."

Ignoring the flare in his chest when Danny mentioned the Joker, he decided to focus on the last part of Danny's rant. "What do you mean again?"

The kid stared at him a moment in confusion before panic set in. "Crap! I'm sorry I let go! I forgot..." He grabbed Jason's wrist and began leading him back towards the hotel. "Erm... but my parents tend to jump from one project to another pretty quickly, but when they get focused on one particular idea, like catching me or that time they convinced themselves Lake Eerie, the one with three E's, was haunted, they'll do whatever they think is necessary to remove the threat... And you've already seen the chaos they can make with the RV, so imagine that but worse."

"Worse? Your parents are already on par with a force of nature in that thing."

"Don't I know it. The weather report has even started including sightings of it, so people know to be careful."

"Seriously, how haven't they been arrested yet."

"I think the local police are afraid to. They're mostly harmless to people who aren't ghosts or halfas."

A comfortable silence fell between them as the hotel started coming into view. If he wasn't mistaken, it looked like there were a few familiar forms on the roof. How long had their flight lasted anyways? It didn't seem like it was that long. But he hadn't taken any of the tracking equipment with him when he went on the roof, and even if he did, it'd probably have gone offline judging by the glitches from the previous night. And knowing how the living embodiment of paranoia was, not knowing where he was for any length of time would send him into a tizzy.

That gave him an idea.

In retrospect, Jason shouldn't have been surprised at how easily Danny agreed to help him. He'd seen glimpses of his playful side when he was interacting with his sister, but he honestly didn't expect the kid to be willing to risk getting on the Bat's bad side.

Danny turned them both invisible and intangible and slipped into the hotel room. After checking to make sure no one was there, Danny said his 'goodbyes' and headed home, leaving Jason by himself. Phasing through the wall wasn't as bad as the trip through the ground, but it still made his skin crawl.

Deciding to wait a bit to trip the silent alarm Bruce set to protect their equipment, he elected to get a shower first and wash off any residual gunk from Plasmius' stupid experiment. It was pretty rare for him to be able to get one without the risk of interruption when he was on family missions.

Well, that was the plan anyways. He stared at himself in the bathroom mirror trying to look everywhere but his green eyes. The color unnerved him. But how the hell was he supposed to turn back to his human form? He should have asked Danny for a tip or something. Thankfully, the universe decided to give him a break, and that light from before flashed leaving him looking like his normal but exhausted self. Sighing in relief, he removed his uniform before taking one of the most satisfying showers in his life.

Pleasantly refreshed, he bagged his uniform since that was probably going to need to be decontaminated and sent a quick status update to Roy and Kori. While he still wasn't sure what he should and shouldn't tell them regarding his new status, he could at least mention he was exposed to Pit water again. Roy, at least, would know that meant he'd have to stay in Gotham for a bit for observation. Satisfied, he grabbed one of the books he brought with him for the plane flights, picked one of the chairs that would be visible from the door, and waited. It took five minutes longer than he expected for there to be a commotion at the door.

"I'm telling you he's in there." That sounded like Duke, who seemed exasperated. Guess the others didn't believe him. "I saw him."

"How could he be in there?" Tim argued. "We know no one came through the door or the windows."

"Besides, he left his jacket on the roof." Was it just him or did Dick sound worried?

"Did you imbeciles forget he could have just fallen through the roof?" Leave it to the demon brat to be able to insult everyone and still make the most sense. "Though considering Todd's lack of control, he has probably found himself trapped in another piece of furniture."

"Damian." The old man sounded tired as someone unlocked the door.

As Bruce swung the door open, he stopped and stared once he caught sight of Jason lounging in the chair. The others, puzzled by that reaction, pushed around him to see what was wrong. With the exception of Duke, who donned a validated smirk, the others wore various degrees of surprise. All of them were in civies.

Jason couldn't help himself as he closed his book and stood. "What's wrong? It looks like you've seen a ghost." At the chorus of groans he received, he just snickered.

"You're a jerk, you know that?" Dick threw his jacket at him before stealing his chair.

"Tell me something I don't know. Oof." Cass surprised him by giving him a tight hug around the middle. He froze, not knowing what to do other than pray his body remained solid. After what happened earlier, why would she risk it?

"You are okay." She looked up and gave him a soft smile. "See? Not scared."

Damian tutted as he found a seat of his own. "Todd, I would advise you to provide some form of a warning for future vanishings to prevent unnecessary distress." Wait, was that demon speak for saying he was worried? That couldn't be right. Maybe it was because Dick was upset? The kid did like him best.

"I take it you were with Danny."

Jason watched the old man take a seat on the couch as Cass let go and moved to sit next to him. He wasn't as tense as when he first walked in the door, but there was a hint of suspicion in his gaze. Ah yes, there was the paranoia he was so familiar with. "Yep. We discussed a few things."

When Bruce raised an eyebrow, Jason just crossed his arms. What was said on the roof was private and personal, and he was going to respect that.

"Whatever he said seems to have put you in better spirits." Everyone groaned as Dick grinned at his own pun.

"Where is he anyways?" Although he'd also taken a seat, Duke glanced around the room. "I don't think he's here."

"Headed home after dropping me off." Deciding he didn't want to sit again, Jason hesitantly leaned against the wall near Dick's chair. Thankfully, this time he didn't have any trouble with intangibility. It didn't mean it wouldn't happen again later though. "His sister called him. Apparently, their parents are seriously considering that all costumed heroes might be ghosts."

"You know, I'm not sure if I'm insulted or flattered they thought I couldn't be human because of the acrobatics."

"I'd take it as a compliment," Tim told their bother as he made himself comfortable on a different chair. "But there's no telling what those two might make if left alone."

"I agree. There's also a risk of them drawing unwanted attention from any number of criminals, especially after our unintentionally involvement with them," Bruce added. "A contract with either Wayne Tech or Chemicals or even Star Labs might work for now, but with how rapidly they seem to be able to create weaponry, we might have to put them in their own lab." He glanced at Jason. "The fewer people who know or have access to their research, the better."

"I think the bigger problem would be if Plasmius tried that crap on someone else. We know he's fucked around with cloning experiments. Who's to say he wouldn't get desperate enough to try it on someone else?" Once he was certain he had these abilities under control, he was going to dismantle everything that asshole worked for.

Tim hummed for a moment while he considered the idea. "I think it's unlikely, at least for now. He's going to be too interested in you."

"Just what I wanted."

"But, while I think it's unlikely because of how closely he's guarded the secret of his powers, he might sell that knowledge to someone else who might want to create super soldiers."

"An army of people with powers like Plasmius and Danny..." Duke shivered for a moment before giving a sideways glance towards Jason. "We could barely hold our own against Plasmius."

"Speak for yourself, Thomas."

"I'm not sure it could be easily replicated..." Jason tried to keep his expression neutral as he crossed his arms. This event was being filed under things that happened that he didn't want to talk about. "Danny's probably been exposed to ectoplasm or whatever since birth. We know Plasmius was working with it prior to his accident... and I was fucked up by the Pit." He couldn't hide the bitterness in his voice. Ra's and Talia would have saved everyone, including himself, a lot of grief if they just left him dead.

"What?" he snapped at Dick, who gave him a concerned frown. "Call it a hunch, but if someone tried to repeat it on someone who wasn't already somewhat contaminated by ectoplasm, the Pit, or whatever, when the experiment," he growled the word, "happens, I doubt they'd survive. And I'll personally dismantle anyone who thinks doing that to someone else is a good idea." No one else needed to experience that type of pain.

"We'll keep a watch for any evidence of that," Bruce promised as his expression softened slightly. How shocking. They were actually on the same page for once. "However, I believe the more likely response will be Plasmius more willing to work with known criminals."

They debated for a while which criminals might be most likely to reach out to Plasmius. Channels would have to be closely monitored and plans would have to be made regarding the response and what may or may not happen. The biggest concern by far was Luthor. They might have to introduce Danny to the Justice League so the others could learn what to expect from ghosts and how to respond. And much to Bruce's annoyance, he admitted Constantine might be their best bet on creating countermeasures.

They also had to watch how the police investigation progressed with Vlad. If things went well, he might get hit with some real charges. However, they knew it was unlikely to stick. The police didn't know about his powers and wouldn't be able to stop him from possessing the court. Dick joked maybe they could sic Lois Lane on him. If anyone would be able to bring that connection to light, it was her. Big blue wouldn't appreciate it though, especially after the warning he got about Plasmius' powers.

Then there was the Anti-Ecto Acts. Danny hadn't been kidding when he said anyone involved with him risked being arrested. The specific way it was worded made it difficult for the kid, and by extension Jason, be classified as metas. Judging by Bruce's expression, he was going to work on dismantling them as soon as possible.

As evening neared, there was talk about getting food. Dick, Tim, Duke, and even Damian, who didn't trust the others to find something he'd eat, decided to go get takeout for them. Jason wanted to go too, but Bruce quickly put a stop to that. They couldn't risk him having an incident in public after all. Noticing the tension between them, Cass decided she'd head out with the others. Traitor.

Pissed, he retreated to the bedroom so he wouldn't risk the man seeing any other slip up. Didn't need to prove to him he was a liability now. He might as well get some practice in before the plane flight home. He didn't want to risk falling through the damn

thing.

Practicing ended up just being a lot of frustration and cursing. He still didn't have a good idea of how to trigger the powers, and he was dead set on not transforming. Maybe once he had time to process and accept it, but right now, it frightened him. But he did have a small comfort knowing Danny also struggled with acceptance at first too.

Inevitably, Bruce ended up watching him from the doorway. "Come to gloat over how uncontrolled I am?" he hissed as he sat down on the bed. "Or maybe you're happy it'll be easier to take me down if I decide to turn on you and the others."

"Jason."

"What? You're probably sorry you even asked me to come here. I bring unnecessary problems with me wherever I go, and I doubt the others want me around."

"Jason!" Instead of the neutrality the man tended to wear around his family members, his brow furrowed as a muscle moved in his jaw. He let some of the tension out of his shoulders before he sat down on the bed next to him. "I... I know our relationship hasn't been great since you came back." Bruce ignored his snort. "There was a time last night when I thought I'd lose you again. I... we... weren't sure if you were alive or not when we pulled you out of that thing. Then Plasmius grabbed you..."

An uneasy feeling filled his chest, making him rub the area above his core. Was that simply from Bruce being candid for once? "Is that why you were so angry at Danny?"

"He was the only one who could have prevented that, and he wasn't there."

"Don't be too hard on the kid. While I didn't exactly enjoy that experience, I got out unscathed."

An uneasy silence fell between them until Bruce ruffled his hair before standing. "I'm currently debating on whether or not we should have a zeta tube between Amity and Gotham. Danny probably has questions about himself which we could help with without it being leaked to the wrong hands, and I know you'd feel more comfortable if we at least offer him the chance for proper training." He actually smiled. "Don't worry, I'm not going to adopt him, but he and his sister will be welcome at the manor if his situation at home changes."

Jason nodded, uncertain how to reply. Danny did need support and training, and even though there was the chance he still might not accept it, the choice would be his to make. He also had a sinking suspicion Bruce wanted it this way so Danny would be available to help him adjust. It wasn't a terrible idea, but he was rarely home for any length of time. He didn't belong there. Not anymore anyways.

"Alfred misses you. Anyways, I think I hear the others."

Jason hesitantly followed Bruce into the living room area of the suite just in time to watch Tim and Damian stumble through the door, fighting with each other. "Do I even want to know?"

"It's just the usual," Dick tiredly explained before he brightened up. "Look who we ran into!" He moved out of the way to show Danny, who hesitantly rubbed his neck. "Hope it's okay we invited him."

Bruce smirked at him for some reason before donning his more public persona and beckoned Danny in while Dick tried to separate their younger siblings. The key word was tried. Duke carefully moved around them while he and Cass put what smelled like Thai on the dining table.

"Should we do something about them?" the kid hesitantly asked as he watched the fight.

"Why? Means more food for us."

"You better not touch my dinner, Todd." Damian hissed as he turned his attention away from Tim and towards the table.

When Danny sent him a confused look, he just winked. Sometimes, it was just better to suggest Damian wouldn't get something if he continued to be a brat instead of trying to directly stop him. If it worked, it wasn't stupid.

Dinner was relatively fun. Since Danny had been so surprised again and again during the fight with Plasmius, they decided to share more stories with him. The kid listened in awe at some of their exploits, especially during the early years. Dick must have sensed how hard he could be on himself, so he was the one who started some of the stories about their mess-ups in the field, and the pranks they pulled on each other.

Some of the stories were new to him too. There was a lot he'd had missed over the years, and it just reminded him of how unsure he was regarding his place with the others.

"So, Jason, you never did explain how you broke your friend out of prison."

He broke out of his thoughts to see Duke waiting for a response with a raised eyebrow. "Dressed as a priest, infiltrated the prison, and broke Arsenal out." His fork slipped through his fingers as a momentary flicker of intangibility happened. He'd been hoping there wouldn't be an issue during dinner. "Damn it."

"Oh, no, you're not getting away with not giving us details this time." Dick poked him in the side a few times. "Spill."

Sighing, more out of theatrics than actual annoyance, he launched into the story. Although Bruce frowned at him a few times, he didn't openly admonish him for the more problematic parts of the story. The others laughed and groaned at various parts, especially when the breakout went south, and all bets were off.

"Um... So, I might have kind of caused a prison riot and breakout in the Ghost Zone once."

Jason knew there was a reason he liked this kid.

After dinner, Danny was surprised to learn they'd be leaving in the morning. It almost seemed like he was hoping they'd stick around for a little longer, but Bruce hated leaving Gotham alone for too long. Too much could go wrong after all.

Catching the look Bruce gave him, he pulled Danny aside for a few moments and explained Bruce's offer. When the kid didn't immediately answer, Jason quickly made sure he knew that he didn't have to agree if he didn't want to. He just knew an offer like that would put him on edge with how Plasmius was. But Danny surprised him and agreed, saying it'd be nice get answers from a human who didn't think he was some sort of evil obsessive entity.

Hesitantly, Jason also gave Danny the number to the phone that only his family, Roy, and Kori had access to. “Look, I might not always be able to answer immediately, but if you need me... I’ll do my best to respond.”

Danny’s response was to give him a hug. He really must have felt alone since the accident. Didn’t mean Jason had any idea what he was supposed to do so he awkwardly patted the kid’s head while glaring at his siblings who were silently teasing him for the display.

After Danny left, the night was surprisingly quiet for them. He did have a few more minor accidents including his leg turning invisible for an hour which was unsettling to everyone, including him. But, he thankfully didn’t fall through a bed when he tried to get some shuteye so that was considered a win.

Unlike when they arrived, Vlad didn’t meet them though he did send a limo. Guess he wanted to demonstrate he was still outside of their reach, at least for now. It made his blood boil, but after Cass motioned to his eyes, he realized he couldn’t risk thinking about it for now. How in the world did Danny deal with all this shit?

He felt calmer when they were the plane and getting out of Amity. The feeling of the Pit, or more accurately the ambient ectoplasm, lessened, and his core seemed to settle. He hoped that meant there’d be fewer accidents.

About an hour into the flight, he got a text from Danny double checking it was the right number. Once it was confirmed, the kid surprised him by sending him two links. Turns out the two names Danny thought about calling him were the names of stars. For some reason, that gave him a warm feeling he wasn’t overly familiar with.

However, it had the unwanted effect of triggering him to change into his ghost form. “God fucking damnit,” he groaned. Now he had to figure out how to change back again. It was going to be a long flight home.

Notes:

So, we are officially done this arc. Thank you all for coming on this weird ride with me. The only thing I knew I wanted going into this fic was an open ending so I can continue it later if the urge hit. Everything else has been a pleasant surprise. I do know I have some companion chapters to write from Tim's, Dick's, and Danny's POVs. Dunno about the others yet.

Crazydemigod666 drew Jason in his ghost form:

<https://crazydemigod666.tumblr.com/post/677913207722147840/jason-todd-in-ayamari-no-goshi-s-to-join-the>

Tumbling-Darkling made an alternative version of Jason's ghost form:

<https://tumbling-darkling.tumblr.com/post/678033068858245120/i-am-really-loving-this-fic-to-join-the-whispers>

riverside—wren also drew their version of Jason’s ghost form:

<https://riverside--wren.tumblr.com/post/681650602360684544/lately-ive-been-enjoying-ayamari-no-goshi-s>

Series this work belongs to:

- Part 1 of Whispers (<http://archiveofourown.org/series/2844469>) Next Work → (<http://archiveofourown.org/works/38160376>)

Close (#)